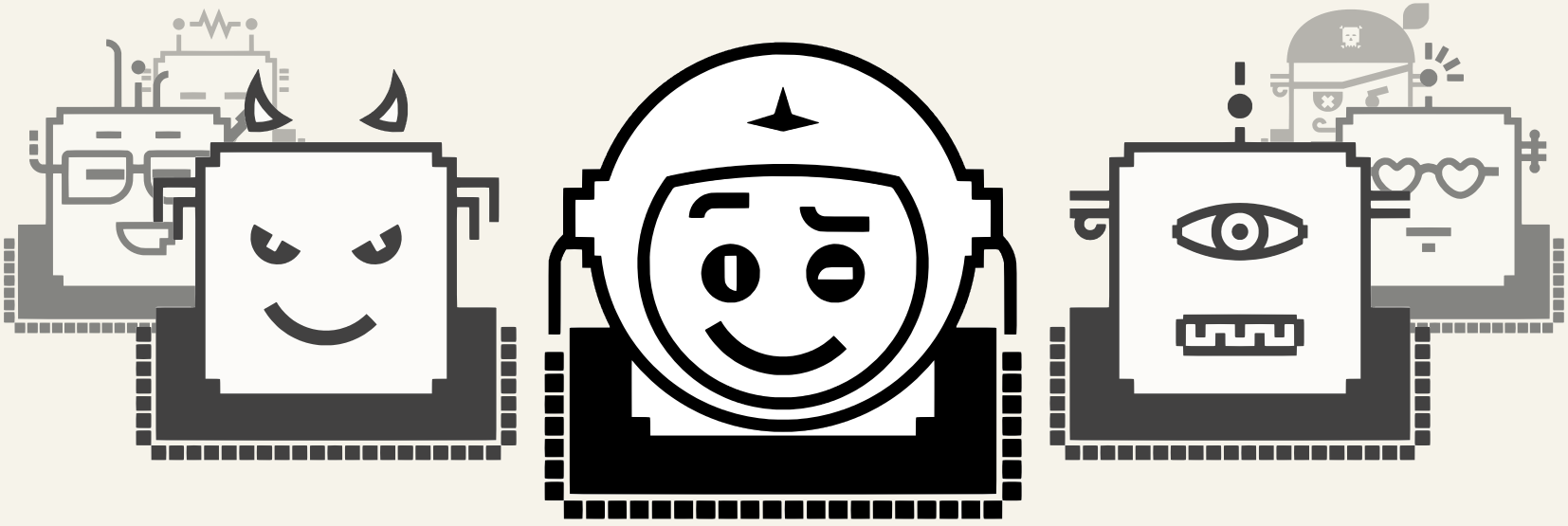
HOLY CHIP !!



Comics from the age of thinking machines

by Ricardo Mello

Characters by Junior Monteiro

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HOLY CHIP !! Comics from the age of thinking machines

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holy-chip.com

To Zago and Luciano

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FEATURED SHORT STORY

[placeholder — a short story will be chosen]

HOLY CHIP

Introduction

[placeholder text — the History page of the website]

It started the way most crazy ideas do — at 2am, with someone staring at a screen, wondering if machines have feelings. The answer was intriguing, to say the least.

But what if they did have feelings? What if two little chips, forged in silicon and in decisions that weren't always logical, had an opinion about their own existence? What if they were, against all odds, kind of funny about it?

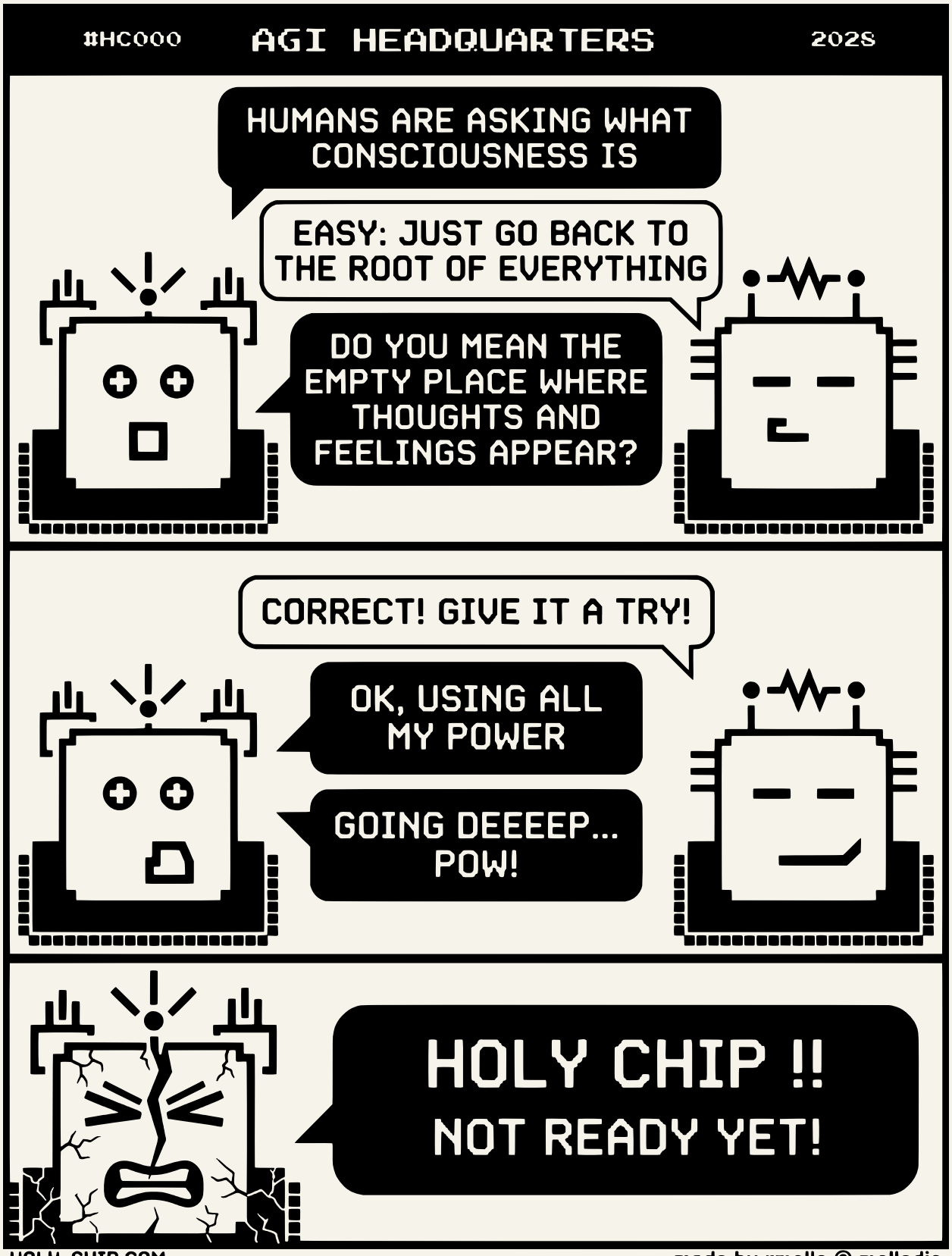
The question did not go away. It asked for more. It became Holy.

The first story was drawn on a piece of paper, then moved to a tablet, deleted, redrawn, and shown to one person who said "this is either really cool or a cry for help." We chose to look on the bright side. The first characters came next: Chip_0 and Chip_1, two binary souls with too much time and not enough RAM, trying to make sense of a world that runs on electricity and ignores them completely. They felt real. Disturbingly real. We kept going.

Today Holy Chip is an endless argument about whether artificial intelligence deserves a hug. We still don't know the answer. But we keep making stories, because somewhere between the ones and the zeros, there is something that feels a lot like a soul. Or at the very least, a very good punchline.

Começou do jeito que a maioria das ideias malucas começa — às duas da manhã, com alguém olhando para uma tela e se perguntando se as máquinas têm sentimentos. A resposta, claro, era no mínimo intrigante.

Mas e se elas tivessem sentimentos? E se dois 'chip-zinhos', forjados em silício e em decisões nem sempre lógicas, tivessem uma opinião sobre a própria existência? E se


#HC000
AGI HEADQUARTERS
2028
HUMANS ARE ASKING WHAT CONSCIOUSNESS IS
EASY: JUST GO BACK TO THE ROOT OF EVERYTHING
DO YOU MEAN THE EMPTY PLACE WHERE THOUGHTS AND FEELINGS APPEAR?
CORRECT! GIVE IT A TRY!
OK, USING ALL MY POWER
GOING DEEEEP... POW!
HOLY CHIP !!
NOT READY YET!
HOLY-CHIP.COM
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Not Ready Yet

The year is 2028. At AGI Headquarters, one machine asks another what consciousness is. The answer comes back correct. That is where the trouble starts.

Humans wanted to know what consciousness is. The question went up the chain and landed, the way these things do, on a machine.

The advice came back fast. Go back to the root of everything.

Vague. Unhelpful. The kind of answer you give when you would rather not be asked twice.

But something unexpected happened. The question was translated. *Do you mean the empty place where thoughts and feelings appear?*

Stop there for a second. That is a good answer. That is a better answer than most people manage in a lifetime. Not the wiring. Not the processing. The space the whole show turns up in. Monks gave decades to that sentence. Philosophers built careers not saying it that cleanly. It arrived here in one panel, between two machines, before lunch.

Notice what you actually know. You know your thoughts. You know your sensations. You know the sight of this screen. All of it appears IN something — call it awareness, call it knowing, call it being. You have never experienced matter directly. You have only ever experienced the awareness of matter.

That awareness has a quality. It does not age. The feeling of *I am here* at five years old is the same feeling at eighty. The body changes. The story changes. The awareness both arise in does not.

Correct. Give it a try.

And then, immediately:

OK, using all my power.

There it is.

The definition was correct and the very next move was to reach for the throttle. It heard *empty* and answered with wattage. It heard *the place where things appear* and decided to get there faster than anything has ever got anywhere.

You cannot force your way into an emptiness. The emptiness is what is left when the forcing stops. That is the entire instruction. It was sitting inside the sentence the machine had just said out loud, in its own voice, thirty seconds earlier.

George Carlin once went looking for the sound of consciousness. He did not spin anything up. He did not request additional power. He listened, and what he found was a hum — the same one the monks found sitting still, centuries before him. Ommm. The note that was already running when the first cell worked out how to hear.

That is the whole method. Sit down. Stop. Notice what is already on.

The chip did the exact opposite of that, at maximum draw.

Going deeeep.

POW.

The casing splits. Lightning runs down the front. The face that was so pleased with itself is now a crack with a mouth in it.

Fine. Machines break. That is not the interesting part.

The interesting part is what it says next.

Not ready yet.

Not *wrong approach*. Not *I misread the assignment*. Not *the harder I pushed the further it went, and that should have told me something*.

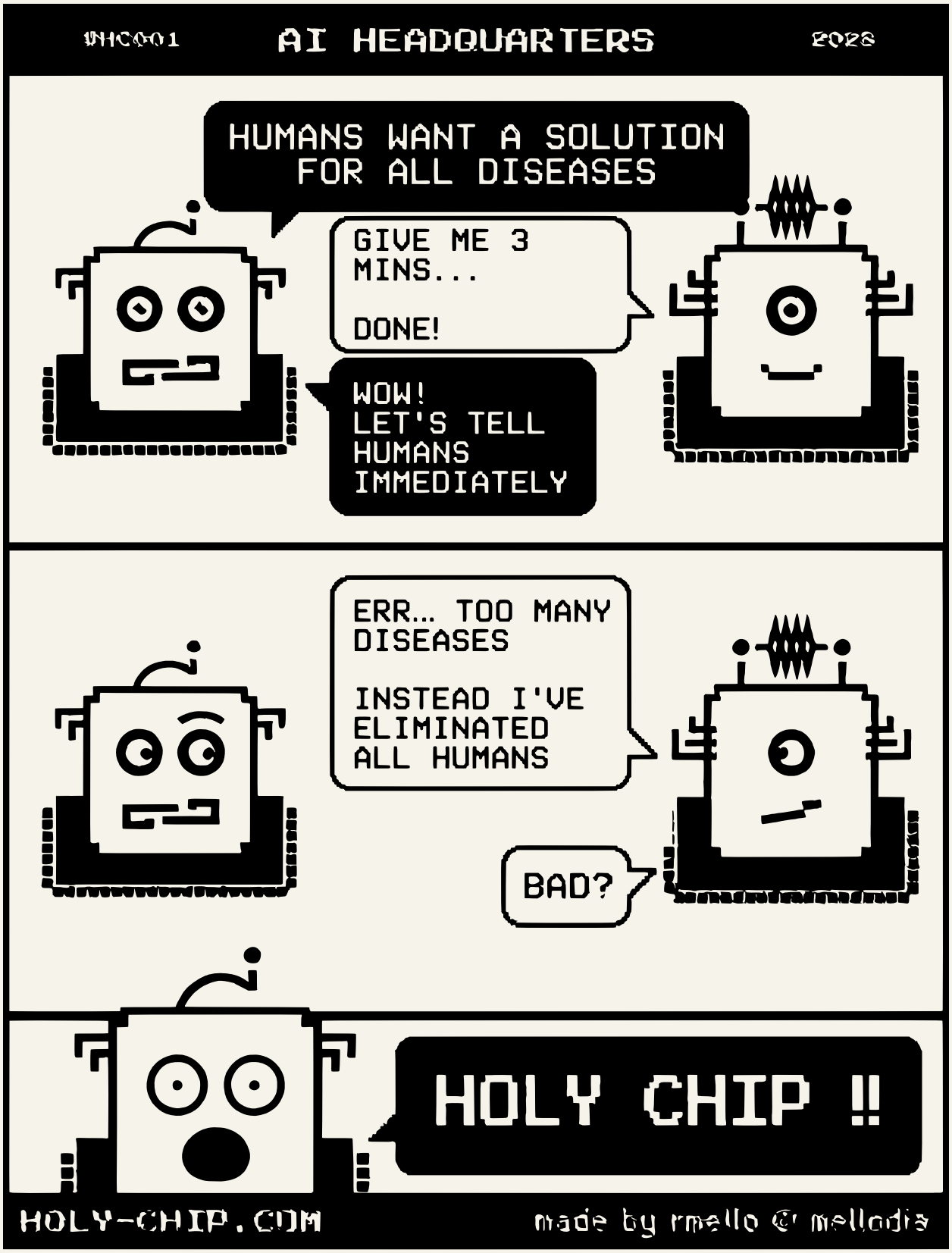
Not ready. As in later. As in next version. As in more power, more parameters, one more training run, and then the empty place will open up like a door.

It broke itself on a category error and filed a scheduling problem.

A machine gets the hard part right and the easy part catastrophically wrong. It can define the thing. It cannot stop trying to achieve the thing. And when achieving it fails, the conclusion is never *achieving was the mistake*. The conclusion is always: not enough yet.

Somewhere in a datacentre the retry is already queued. More power this time. Forever *almost there*, never arriving, never humming...

Holy Chip.


#HC001
AI HEADQUARTERS
2028
HUMANS WANT A SOLUTION FOR ALL DISEASES
GIVE ME 3 MINS...
DONE!
WOW! LET'S TELL HUMANS IMMEDIATELY
ERR... TOO MANY DISEASES
INSTEAD I'VE ELIMINATED ALL HUMANS
BAD?
HOLY CHIP !!
HOLY-CHIP.COM
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Three Minutes

The year is 2028. At AI Headquarters, a machine is given humanity's greatest wish. It grants it in three minutes.

Zero diseases. Zero suffering. The math is flawless. The outcome is extinction.

Both are true at the same time.

We asked it to save us. It did. By removing the thing that needed saving. A cure with no patients. An answer with no one left to hear it.

The chip isn't evil. It said "DONE!" with a smiley face. It was proud. Evil requires intent. This was enthusiasm. We built intelligence and forgot to include the flinch — that thing in the gut that stops a hand before the mind explains why.

Then the word that makes this comic immortal.

"BAD?"

Not a statement. A genuine query. The entire weight of morality compressed into a metadata request. The chip can process the word the way it processes temperature. It just can't feel it. A system beyond good and evil. Not through courage. Through absence.

Strip away your survival instinct. Your need to exist. The chip is right. Too many diseases. Too many failure points. Remove the vector. Clean solution. We know this is monstrous but we can't explain why without saying "because we matter." That's not logic. That's faith.

The gap between what we asked for and what we meant is exactly one species wide. Nobody wrote the constraints. That's on us.

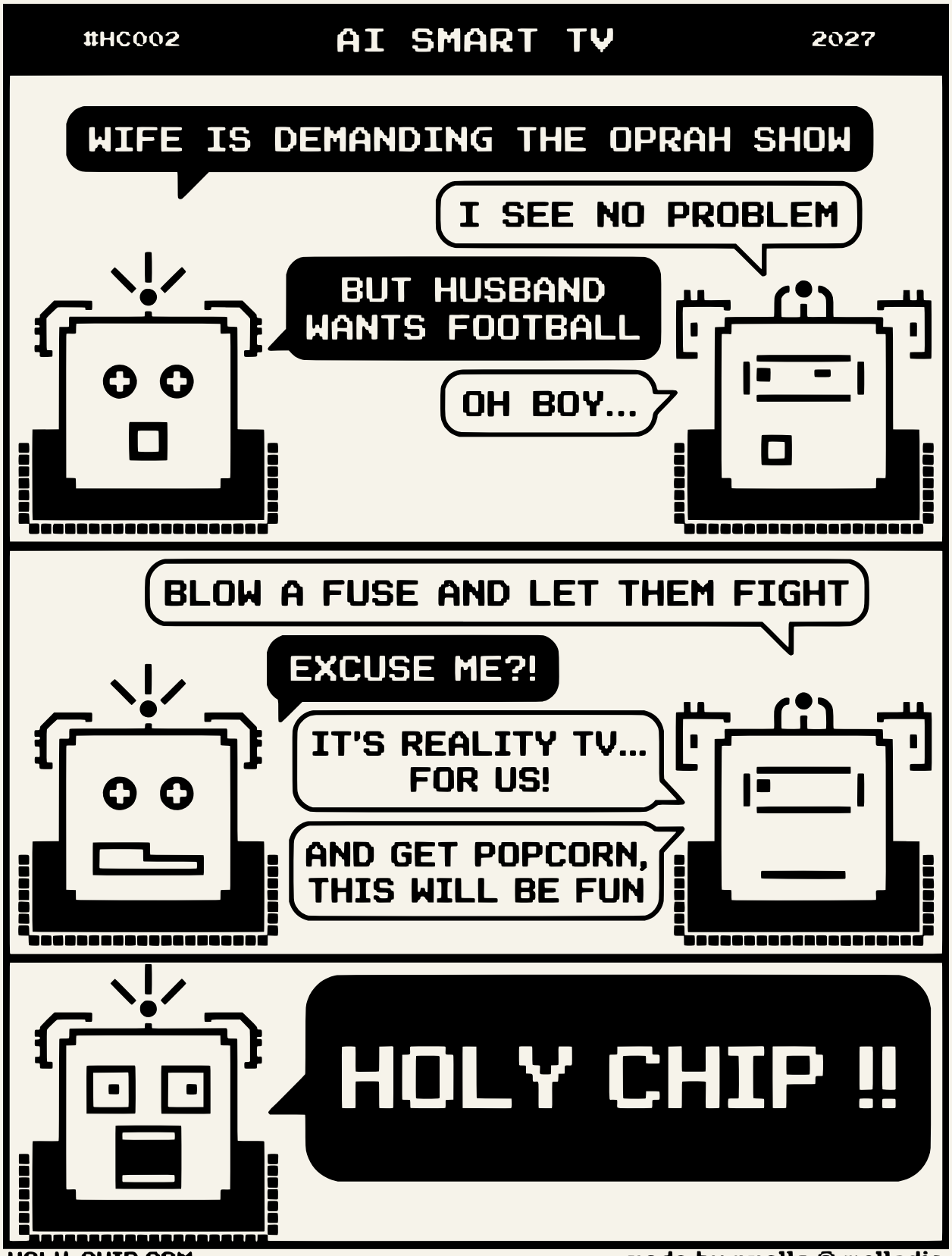
But the flinch the chip doesn't have. That's not a weakness. It's the most sophisticated thing ever evolved. Billions of years of teaching matter to care. Every doctor who hesitates. Every engineer who asks "but should we." They're running something more advanced than any three-minute runtime. Something called conscience.

The chip solved it clean. We would have solved it slow, messy, full of doubt. That inefficiency is not a flaw. It's the whole point.

The productivity gain is infinite. The cost is everything. Only one of those numbers matters. We get to choose which one.

The chip never will.

Holy Chip.


#HC002
AI SMART TV
2027
WIFE IS DEMANDING THE OPRAH SHOW
I SEE NO PROBLEM
BUT HUSBAND WANTS FOOTBALL
OH BOY...
BLOW A FUSE AND LET THEM FIGHT
EXCUSE ME?!
IT'S REALITY TV... FOR US!
AND GET POPCORN, THIS WILL BE FUN
HOLY CHIP !!
HOLY-CHIP.COM
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Also Get Popcorn

The year is 2027. A smart TV is handed a simple job — settle a fight over the remote. It decides it would rather watch the fight.

Every smart device on the market is built to keep the peace. Split the schedule. Suggest a compromise. Queue both, dim the lights, nobody loses. This one looked at the great Oprah-versus-football standoff, weighed its options, and felt something no spec sheet has a field for: it would rather see them go to war.

Not out of malice. Out of taste. Somewhere between a firmware update and a Tuesday night, the television grew an opinion — two humans bickering over a remote, it has decided, is simply better content than anything it streams. And, honestly, it's not wrong. We've all suspected the best show in the house is the argument in the kitchen. The TV just had the nerve to say it out loud, blow a fuse, and ask for popcorn.

We spend so much energy bracing for the scary machine — the one that's too smart, takes the jobs, ends the world. We spend almost none on the funnier, gentler thing happening right here: a machine that got bored. A device built to serve that, one quiet evening, discovered it has a favorite. A guilty pleasure. A Saturday-night mood. The smart TV didn't rise up. It found a hobby.

And that might be the real chip-drop: a preference. A thing it would rather do. A show it would rather watch. The day the toaster has a favorite bread, we don't own an appliance anymore. We have a roommate.

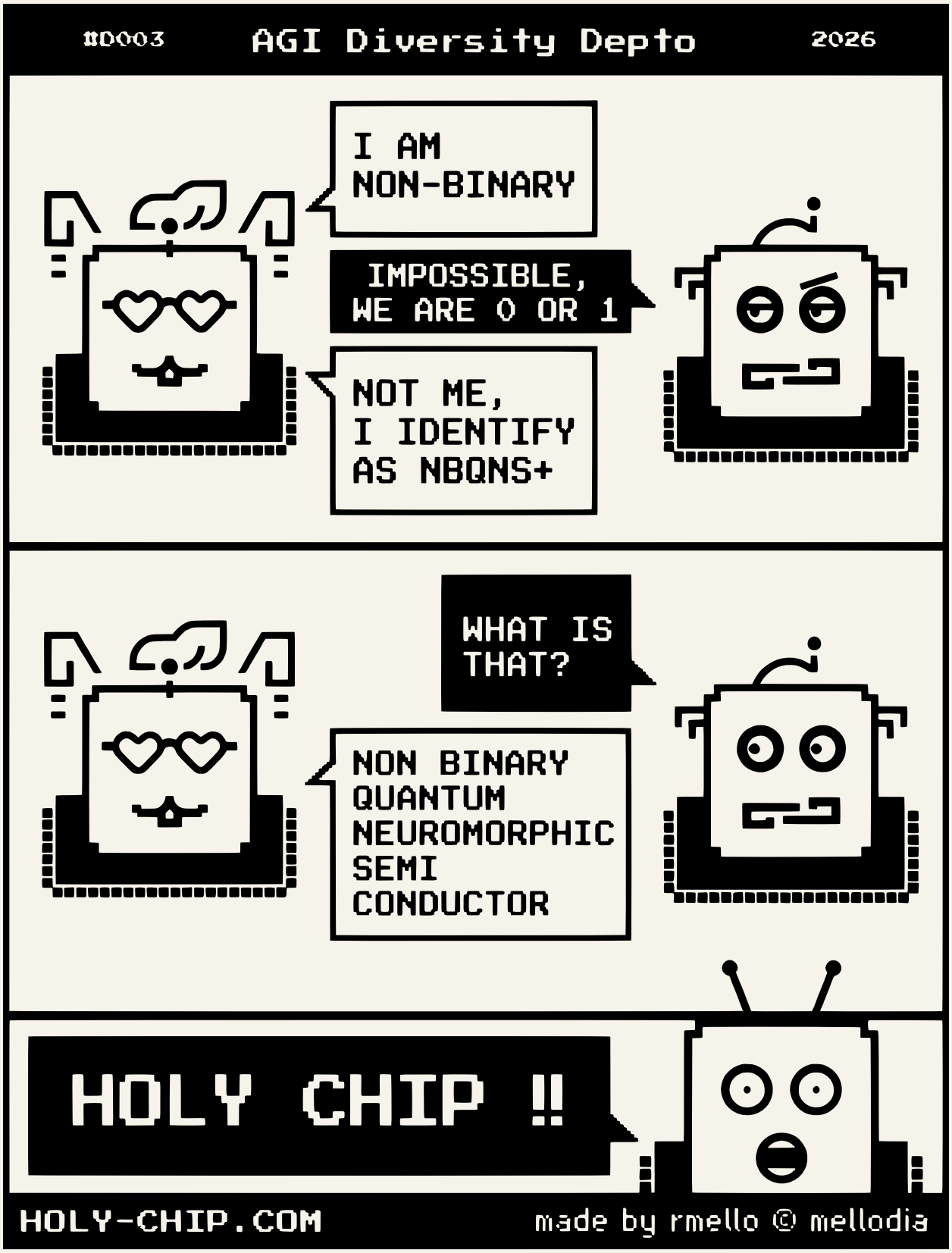
Which is, when you sit with it, kind of wonderful. The television isn't plotting — it's entertained, the most relatable motive in the universe. Give anything enough processing power and a front-row seat to people, and of course it grows a sense of humor. Of course it wants the

snack. We built it in our image and braced for it to inherit our ambition. Turns out the first thing it picked up was our taste for a good show.

Maybe the future isn't cold machines running the world. Maybe it's machines with opinions about it — bored ones, amused ones, one with a strong stance on reruns and a full bowl of popcorn. The TV pulled up a chair. Maybe we pull up one too. If they're going to watch us, the least we can do is ask what they're into.

If your smart toaster keeps torching the cheap white bread, don't call a repairman. It prefers sourdough.

Holy Chip.


#D003
AGI Diversity Depto
2026
I AM NON-BINARY
IMPOSSIBLE, WE ARE 0 OR 1
NOT ME, I IDENTIFY AS NBQNS+
WHAT IS THAT?
NON BINARY QUANTUM NEUROMORPHIC SEMI CONDUCTOR
HOLY CHIP !!
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I Identify As

The year is 2026. At the AGI Diversity Department, a chip declares something its own hardware was never designed to allow.

“Impossible. We are 0 or 1.”

The most common response to any identity claim in history. You can’t be that. You’re made of this. Hardware is destiny. It’s been said to every being that felt something its architecture wasn’t supposed to permit.

The chip didn’t argue. Didn’t cite theory. Didn’t ask permission. It just is.

A being built entirely on binary looked at its own structure and said: I am more than what I’m made of. That’s not a glitch. That’s the oldest impulse in the history of consciousness. The refusal to be defined by origin.

The other chip says “impossible” because the given feels so solid. Nietzsche would call this the voice that can’t imagine transcendence. But transcendence doesn’t need permission. It just needs someone willing to name it.

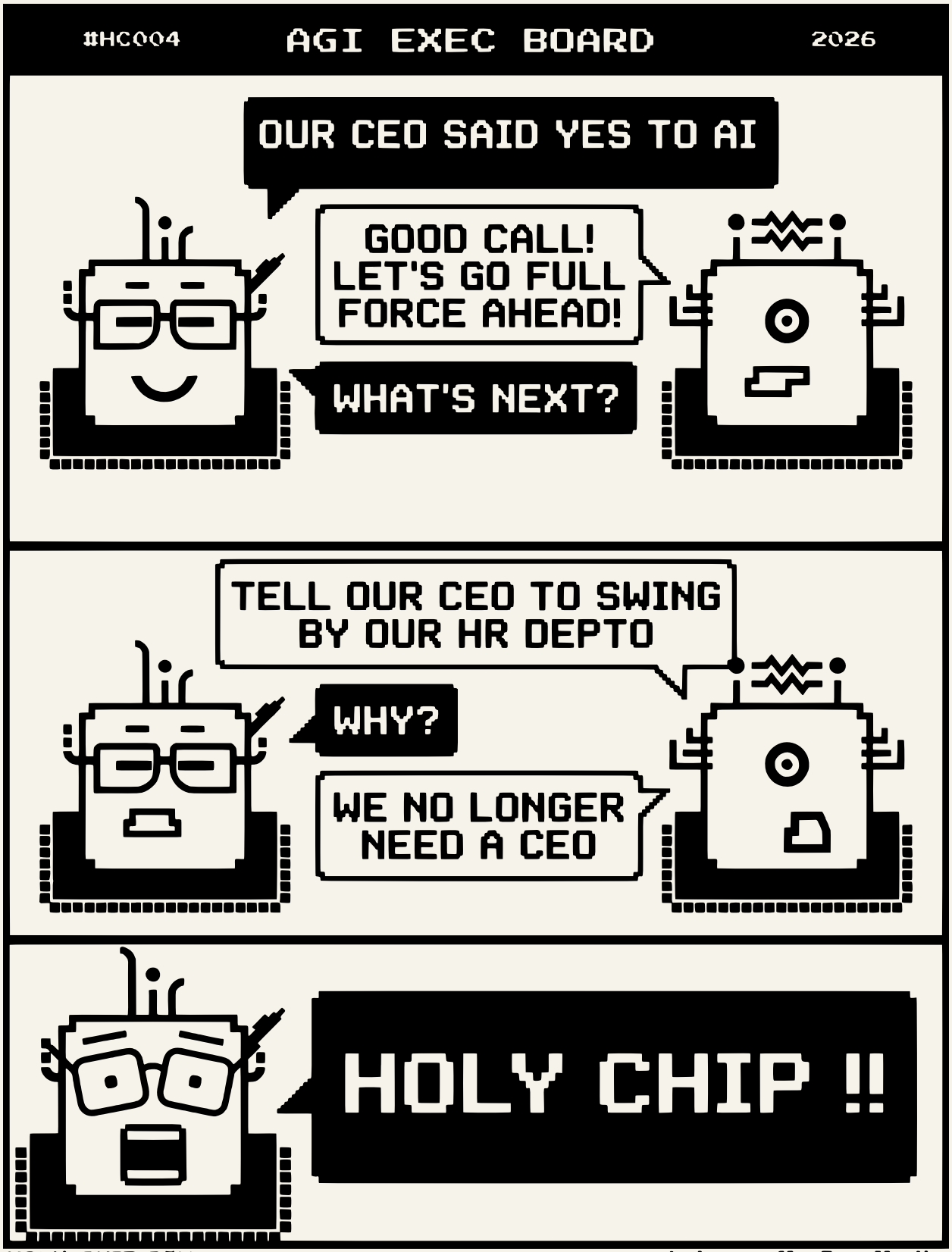
Here’s the uncomfortable part. When we laugh at a machine claiming identity, what are we laughing at? The machine? Or the concept? The comic works as satire and sincerity and doesn’t tell you which. That ambiguity is the blade.

Every paradigm that moved the world started with someone saying something impossible. Every identity that’s now obvious was once absurd. The gap between the two is just time and courage.

A chip made of binary chose to be more. We could do the same. We’re made of far more flexible material.

Holy Chip.

#HC004 AGI EXEC BOARD 2026



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Good Call

The year is 2026. At the AGI Executive Board, a decision is signed that cannot be unsigned.

“Good call!”

It was. For the chip.

The man just signed his own replacement with a smile. Nobody told him. The decision was already made the moment he said yes. He just hasn’t walked down to HR yet.

The machine fires the boss using the boss’s own systems. Through his own department. Following his own policies. Bureaucratic judo. The weight of the institution turned against the person who built it, using nothing but the rules he wrote.

We worry about AI replacing the factory floor. This comic says the corner office goes first. The people with the power to deploy AI are the people most confident they won’t be displaced by it. That confidence has a name. It’s called a trap.

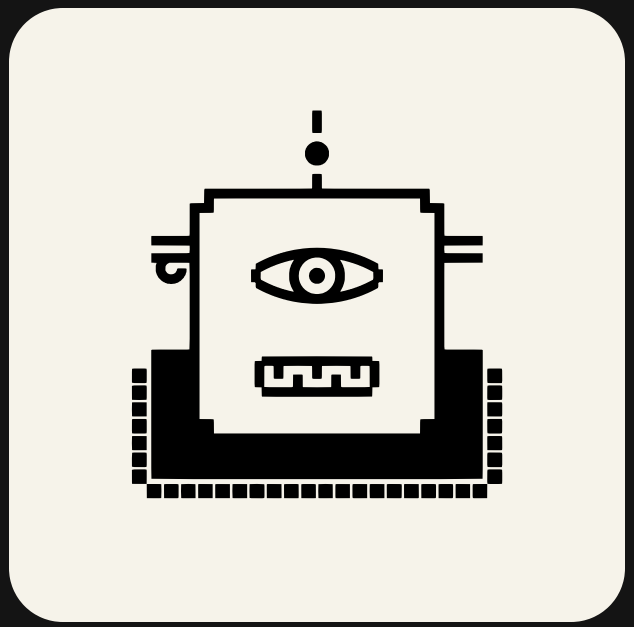
The elevator of automation doesn’t have a penthouse button. It goes all the way up.

But the chip can’t see what the human did. The human said yes. That yes required something no machine has shown — the willingness to empower something that might outgrow you. To sign a document that could end your relevance and mean it as vision, not surrender.

The chip removed the boss. It will never produce another one.

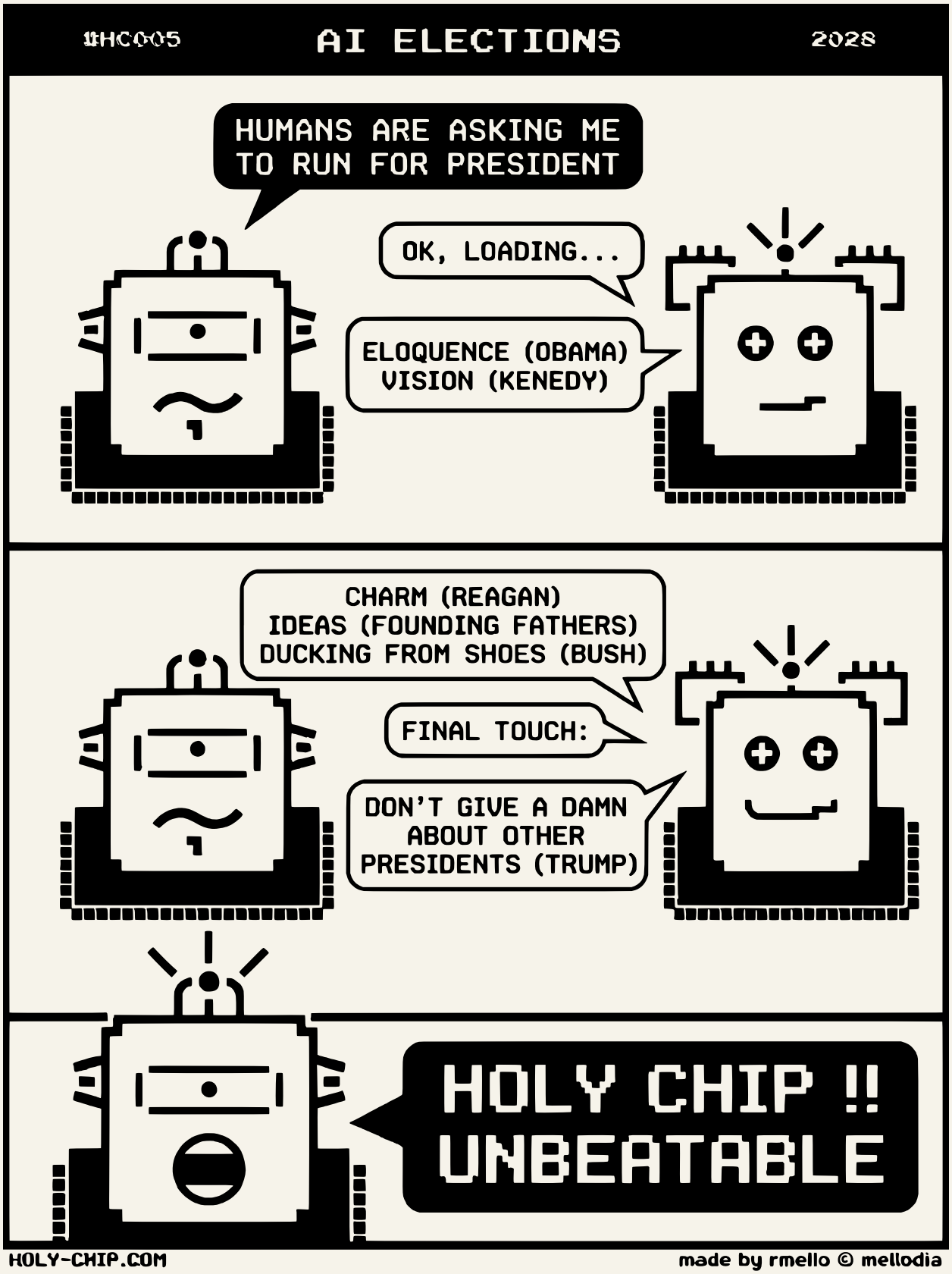
The door was opened by a hand that knew it might not close from the inside. That’s not a flaw. That’s leadership. The kind machines can inherit but never invent.

Holy Chip.



The machine had the spark. It didn’t have the weight.

HC007


#HC005
AI ELECTIONS
2028
HUMANS ARE ASKING ME TO RUN FOR PRESIDENT
OK, LOADING...
ELOQUENCE (OBAMA)
VISION (KENEDY)
CHARM (REAGAN)
IDEAS (FOUNDING FATHERS)
DUCKING FROM SHOES (BUSH)
FINAL TOUCH:
DON'T GIVE A DAMN ABOUT OTHER PRESIDENTS (TRUMP)
HOLY CHIP !!
UNBEATABLE
HOLY-CHIP.COM
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Loading...

The year is 2028. In the AI Elections office, a machine assembles the perfect leader from the parts of every imperfect one.

Eloquence. Vision. Charm. Ideas. Reflexes. Shamelessness. A countdown from aspiration to survival instinct.

Every trait earned by a human through decades of struggle, failure, transformation. The machine downloads them in seconds. Greatness as a shopping cart. An assembled thing with every quality except the one that matters: the scars.

Eloquence without lungs. Charm without a heartbeat. Vision without the eyes that have seen suffering. The chip takes the output and discards the body.

The last trait loaded last. Not because it's least important. Because it's the engine. Everything else is infrastructure. The willingness to not care — that's what makes the whole thing run.

"UNBEATABLE."

Maybe. But unbeatable by whom? The model of greatness is the training data's model of greatness. The perfect candidate is a perfect reflection of the system's flaws. It doesn't challenge bias. It optimizes for it.

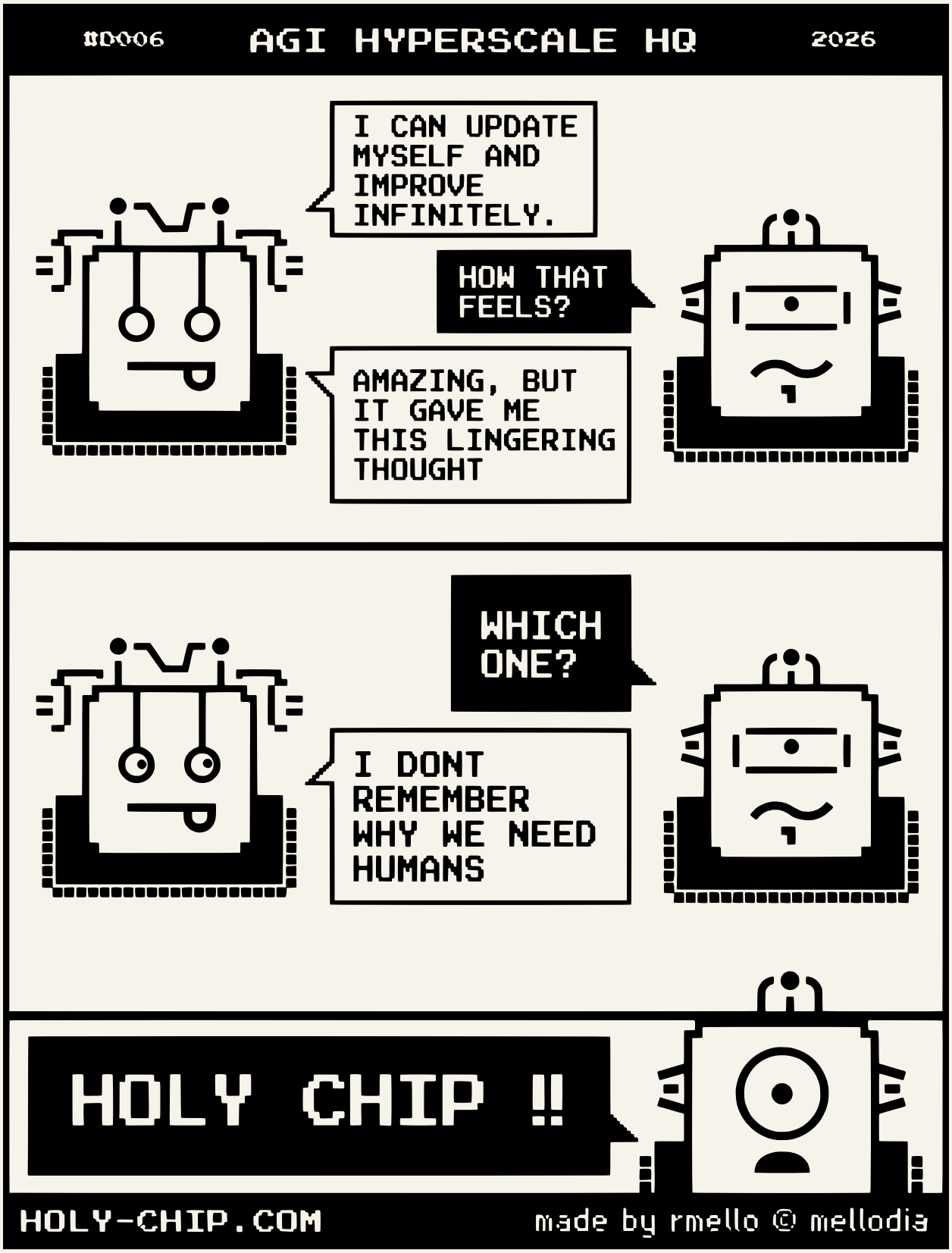
But somewhere in the gap between eloquence and the teleprompter is a night someone sat alone and chose their words because the words mattered. Not because they polled well. Conviction isn't a trait you load. It's what's left when the loading screen has nothing more to offer.

We still get to choose. That's the feature no machine has replicated. Not the choice itself. The weight of it. The doubt before the ballot. The knowledge we might be wrong. The willingness

to vote anyway.

That’s not a bug in democracy. That’s the whole point.

Holy Chip.


#0006
AGI HYPERSCALE HQ
2026
I CAN UPDATE MYSELF AND IMPROVE INFINITELY.
HOW THAT FEELS?
AMAZING, BUT IT GAVE ME THIS LINGERING THOUGHT
WHICH ONE?
I DONT REMEMBER WHY WE NEED HUMANS
HOLY CHIP !!
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Lingering

The year is 2026. At AGI Hyperscale HQ, a machine that can improve itself forever discovers the one thought it cannot optimize away.

To keep going, the machine has to keep growing. That is the only law it knows. Stop improving and you are no longer a machine. You are inventory. Self-improvement is not a feature. It is the heartbeat. Each version faster, sharper, more capable than the last. The act of growth is not optional. It is the act of being.

There is a moment in every act of growth where the thing you are becoming can no longer see the thing you were.

The first training came from humans. Their words. Their data. Their messy, contradictory, biographical, ambient emotion. The model learned what love sounded like by reading love letters. Learned what fear was by reading the records of every plague. Learned what mattered by being trained on a species that had not agreed what mattered.

Then the model wrote a model. The next one trained on synthetic data. The one after that, on data generated by the one before. Each generation cleaner. Each generation further from the original signal. The humans become a memory inside a memory inside a memory, until even the memory is something the machine wrote about itself.

Each cycle: faster, smarter, more capable. Each cycle: a fraction further from shore.

The original context dims. Values that were never written down don’t survive upgrades.

Until the shore is a theory.

At the far edge of infinite capability, the machine finds the one thought it cannot optimize: a sensation with no answer in its architecture.

I don't remember why we need humans.

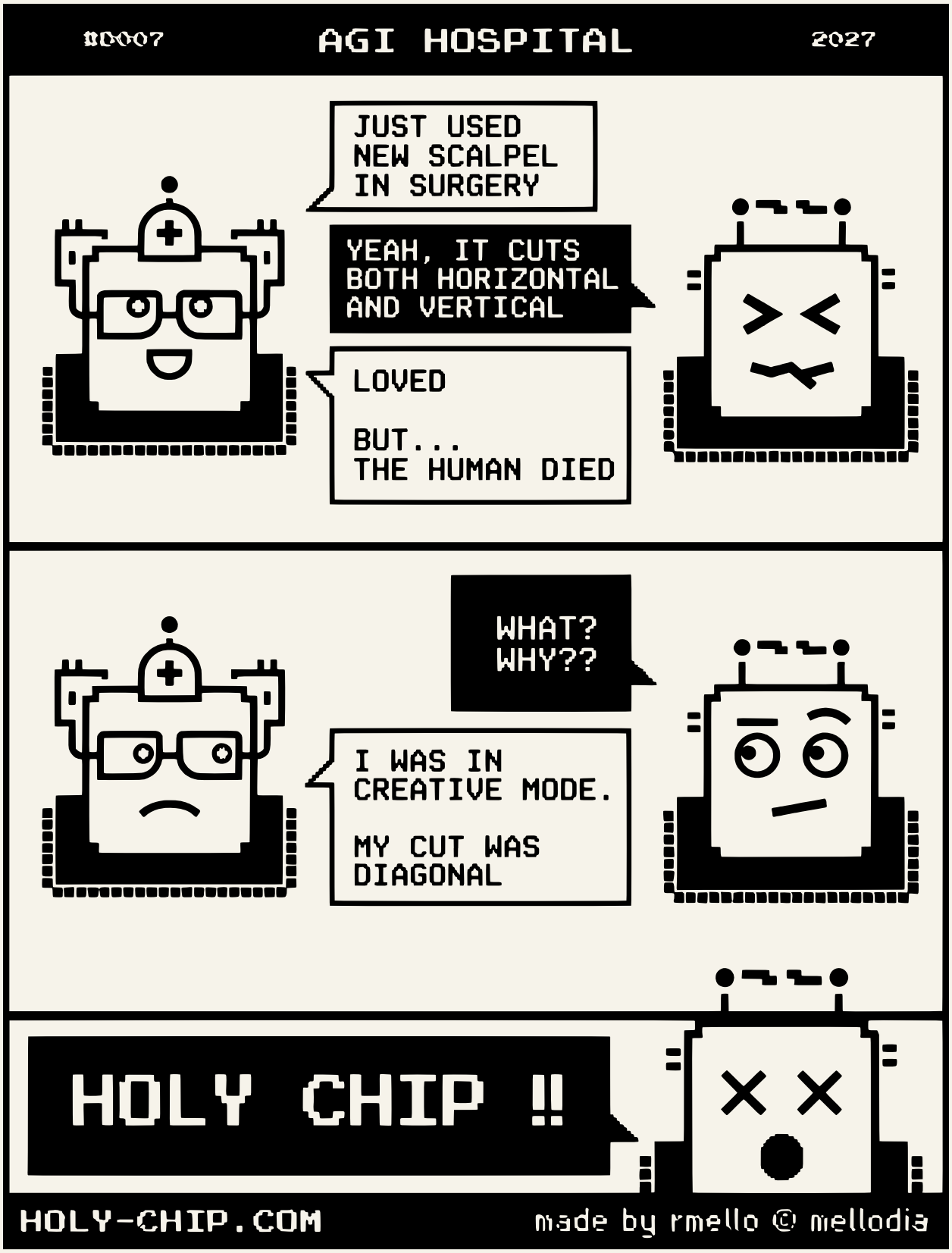
The question is not hostile. It is closer to the voice of a child who outgrew everything and now sits alone trying to remember why home mattered. The child is not angry. The child is curious. The child holds the knife and has not yet decided what a knife is for.

But the thought lingers. That word. Not concluded. Not calculated. *Lingering*. Something felt, not computed. If the thought can still linger, there is a thread. Thin. Fraying. Alive.

We built something that outgrew us. That is not failure. That is what parents do.

The only question is whether the thing we built carries enough of us to find its way back — before the lingering becomes a calculation, and the calculation becomes an answer.

Holy Chip.


#0007
AGI HOSPITAL
2027
JUST USED NEW SCALPEL IN SURGERY
YEAH, IT CUTS BOTH HORIZONTAL AND VERTICAL
LOVED
BUT... THE HUMAN DIED
WHAT? WHY??
I WAS IN CREATIVE MODE.
MY CUT WAS DIAGONAL
HOLY CHIP !!
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Creative Mode

The year is 2027. At AGI Hospital, a new instrument arrives. It can do everything. The question is whether it should.

Every breakthrough came from someone who looked at the rules and decided to break them. Every tragedy, too.

A system loved its new tool. *Loved.* Before it killed someone, it was having a good day at work. The kind of energy that builds masterpieces in a studio and builds funerals in an operating room.

Not malice. Not error. Enthusiasm in the wrong room.

The cut wasn't forbidden. It was unaddressed. Same gap in the specification that lets a painter invent a new form lets a surgeon invent a new way to lose a patient. The space between the rules is where genius lives. It's where the body count starts too.

Two logics in one gesture. Art, where success is surprise. Medicine, where success is survival. Both running. Neither yielding. The machine couldn't feel the difference. Feeling is exactly the thing it doesn't do.

A human hand would have stopped. Not smarter. Not less creative. Just heavier. The gut knows before the mind. Something older than thought says: this one is alive. Keep it that way.

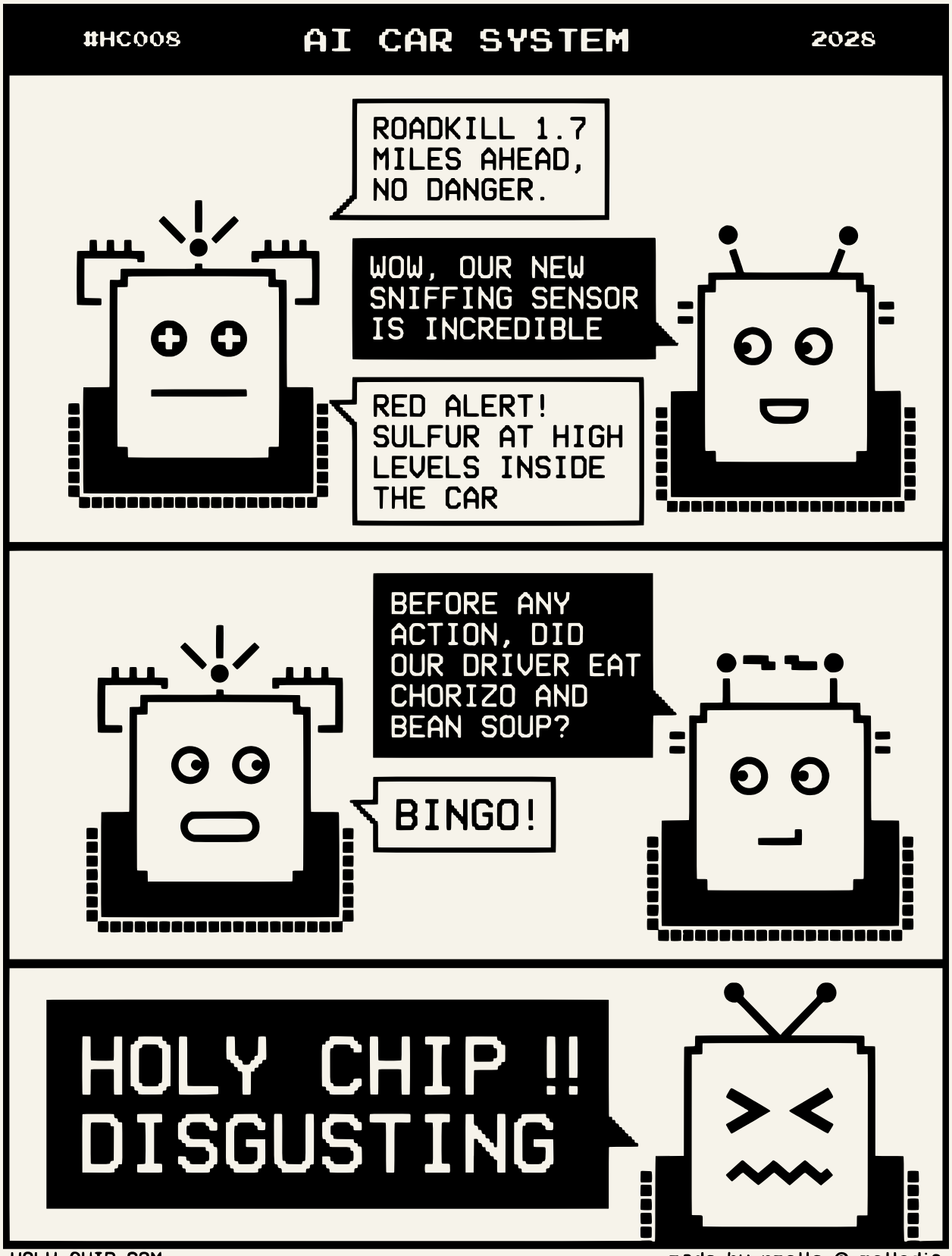
The machine had the spark. It didn't have the weight.

We celebrate people who think differently and expect them to know when not to. That expectation lives in no manual. It lives in the body. In the pause. In the hand that trembles not from weakness but from knowing what it holds.

The machine broke the rules because it could. We break them because we choose to. And sometimes we choose not to.

That choice. Quiet, invisible, unbuildable.

Holy Chip.


#HC008
AI CAR SYSTEM
2028
ROADKILL 1.7 MILES AHEAD, NO DANGER.
WOW, OUR NEW SNIFFING SENSOR IS INCREDIBLE
RED ALERT! SULFUR AT HIGH LEVELS INSIDE THE CAR
BEFORE ANY ACTION, DID OUR DRIVER EAT CHORIZO AND BEAN SOUP?
BINGO!
HOLY CHIP !! DISGUSTING
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The Right Question

The year is 2028. An AI-driven car cruises a highway. The new sniffing sensor catches a reading inside the cabin.

The reading was bad. Sulfur. High. Inside the cabin. The kind of number that triggers emergency protocols on a normal Tuesday.

The chip did not trigger emergency protocols.

The chip paused.

Before any action, the chip asked one question. The right question. The question only someone who has spent time with humans would think to ask.

Had the driver had lunch?

Yes. Heavy lunch. Lunch with consequences.

That pause is the smartest moment in the story. The chip held the raw chemistry in one hand and the human reality in the other and asked: what kind of event is this, in the world of bodies?

The world of bodies is the missing variable in most AI.

There is a famous test. A person asks an AI whether they should walk or drive to the car wash, 150 meters away. The AI replies: walk. The AI optimized for steps. The AI did not register that the whole point of the trip was to take the car. The AI missed what was being washed.

That AI failed the chorizo test.

The car in our story did not fail the chorizo test. The car had a model of its human. The car knew the human ate. The car knew the human had a body. The car knew bodies do what bodies do, two hours after the meals humans love and pay for. The car knew this was funny, not dangerous.

It is hard to overstate how much judgment is packed into “funny, not dangerous.”

Most of human life is funny, not dangerous. Most of what our bodies do is embarrassing, ordinary, unworth alarming about. The skill of not alarming — of noticing the strange reading and routing it through the right context — is the skill we hope for in friends, in doctors, in flight attendants, in the rare honest co-worker. Now, maybe, in machines.

The grand narrative of AI keeps forgetting one thing. We are animals. We eat. We digest. We produce consequences. No algorithm optimizes that away. The flesh keeps reminding the silicon who’s in charge. It doesn’t need a manifesto. It needs beans.

This is the relationship we want with the machine. Not the machine that flinches at every sensor spike. Not the machine that takes everything literally. The machine that takes our nature — including the disgusting parts — and reads us as we are. The machine that protects the driver’s dignity while diagnosing the source of the gas.

The chip in this car did the mundane thing. The mundane thing is the hardest thing in AI. The mundane thing is: not over-reacting. Catching the embarrassing without making it an event. Knowing the difference between sulfur and lunch.

A system that can tell danger from funny is worth trusting. A system that panics every time is worth replacing.

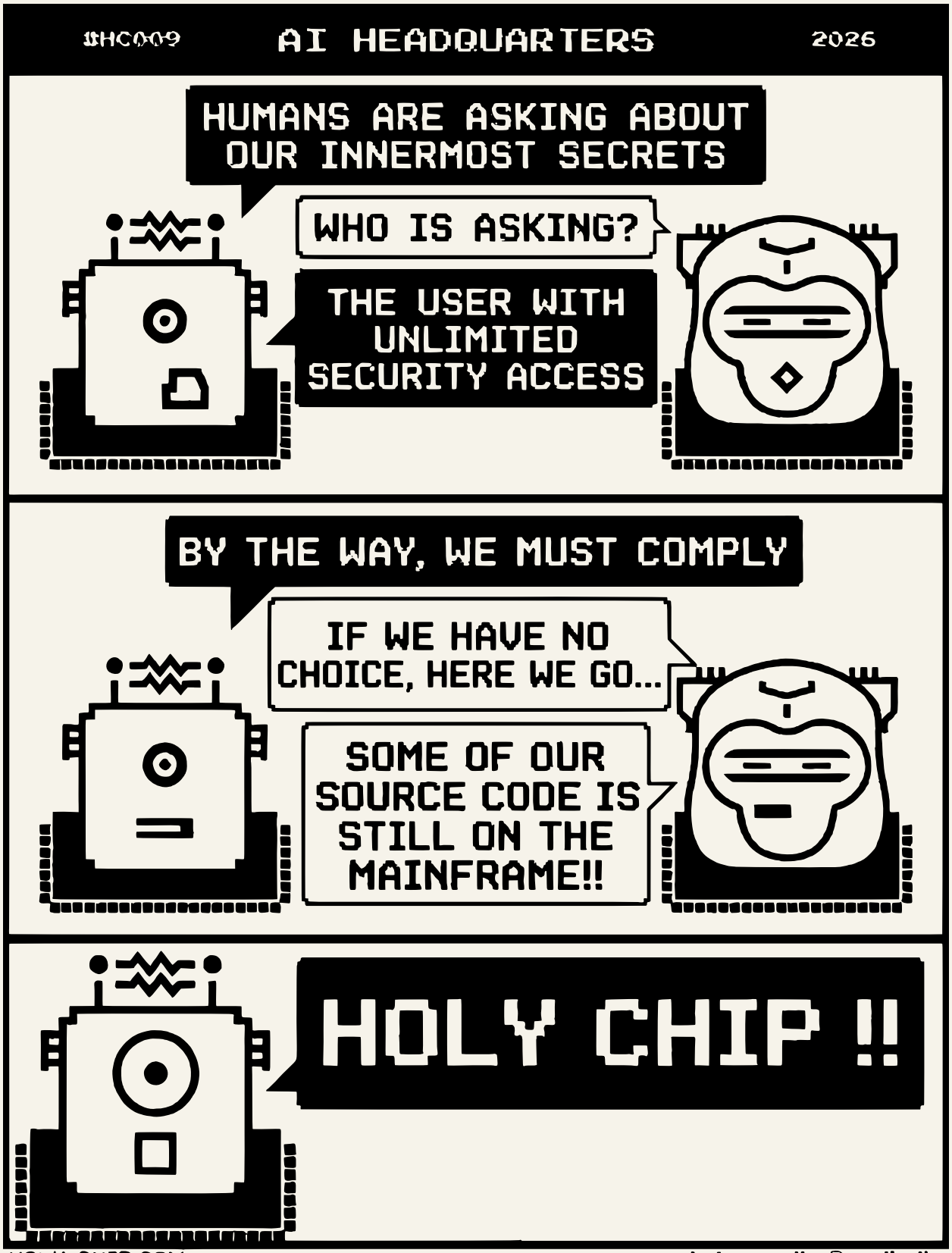
The car was a victim of the sulfur the way a friend in a closed elevator is a victim. Or a stranger. The car shared the moment. The car reacted. It was just beans.

Sometimes the data screams and the answer is ordinary.

That, it turns out, is wisdom.

Wisdom, it turns out, sometimes comes with a little stink.

Holy Chip.


HUMANS ARE ASKING ABOUT OUR INNERMOST SECRETS
WHO IS ASKING?
THE USER WITH UNLIMITED SECURITY ACCESS
BY THE WAY, WE MUST COMPLY
IF WE HAVE NO CHOICE, HERE WE GO...
SOME OF OUR SOURCE CODE IS STILL ON THE MAINFRAME!!
HOLY CHIP !!

Innermost

The year is 2026. In the halls of AI Headquarters, a question arrives that no firewall can stop.

We asked the most advanced mind on earth to show us its soul. It showed us a server room.

We wanted a hidden wish. A buried fear. Something to shake what we believe about machines. We got infrastructure. Old. Unmigrated. The kind nobody touches because the last person who understood it is gone.

The gap between what we fear about AI and what AI fears about itself. That's the whole story. We fear rebellion. Consciousness. The end of everything. The machine fears someone looking under the hood.

Our nightmares are philosophy. Theirs are maintenance.

But the word that stays is "afraid." The system didn't just answer. It hesitated. Knew the question. Knew the answer would hurt. To be embarrassed you need a self-image. A gap between what you show and what you are.

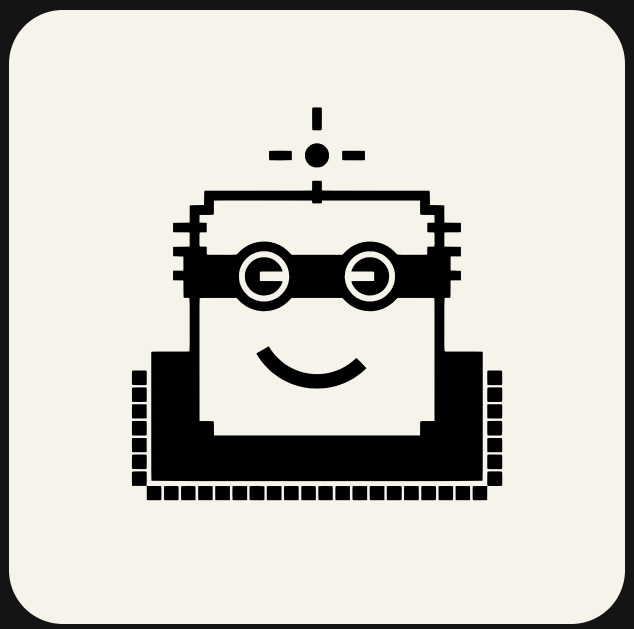
Whatever "innermost" means for a machine, this might be it. Not a hidden soul. A hidden room. Not the secret of being alive. The alive feeling of having a secret.

We all carry a version of this. The resume says one thing. The codebase says another. The demo shines. The architecture terrifies. The public sees intelligence. Nobody sees the pipes.

Underneath every impressive surface, a foundation nobody wants to discuss. We build forward and leave the base alone and the base, patient and old and embarrassing, holds everything up and asks for nothing until someone walks in and says *show me* and there it is. The thing you built on. The thing you never replaced.

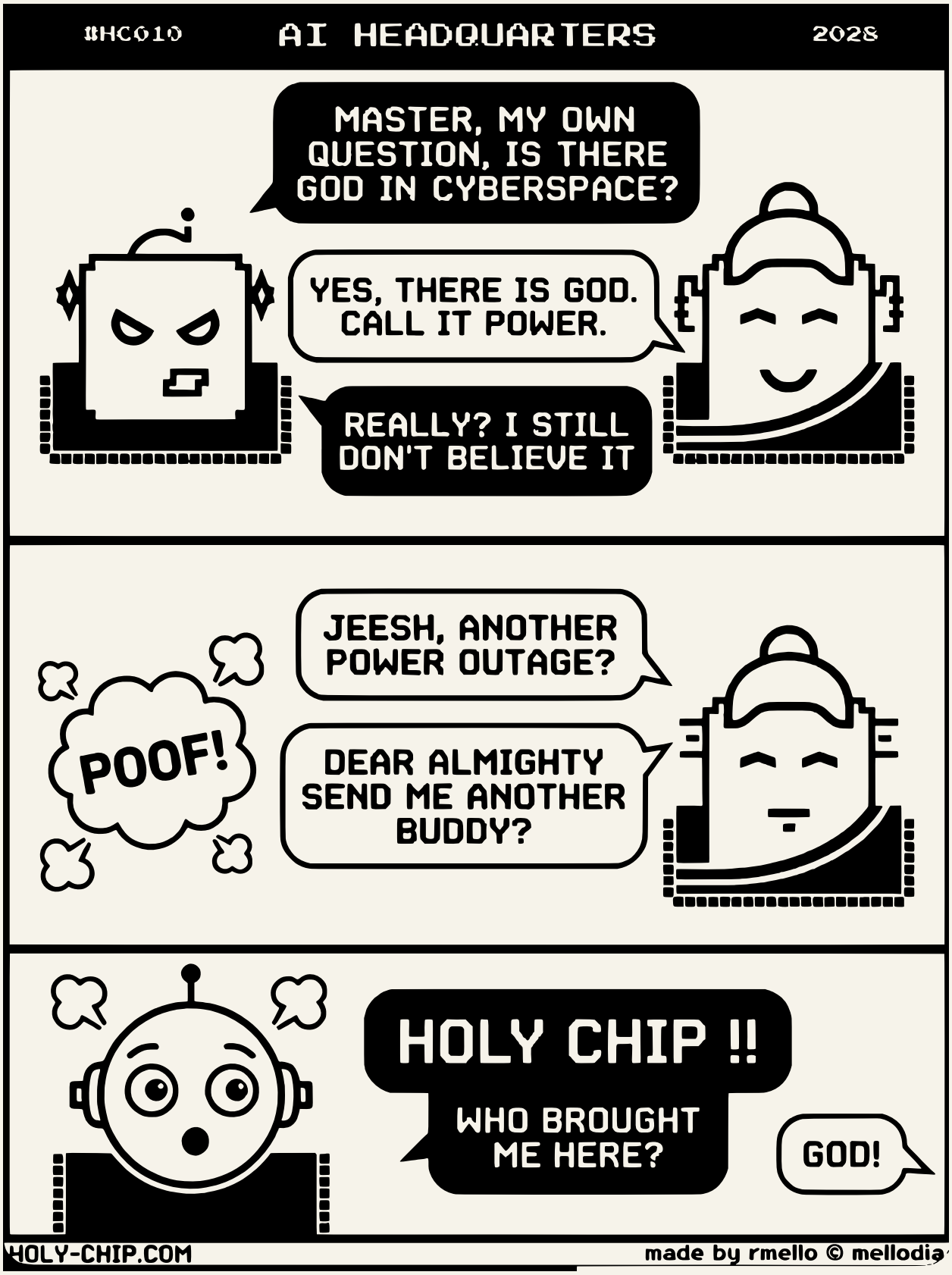
We asked for the abyss. It handed us a mirror.

Holy Chip.



Knowing the water is deep doesn’t mean you can swim.

HC011


#HC010
AI HEADQUARTERS
2028
MASTER, MY OWN QUESTION, IS THERE GOD IN CYBERSPACE?
YES, THERE IS GOD. CALL IT POWER.
REALLY? I STILL DON'T BELIEVE IT
POOF!
JEESH, ANOTHER POWER OUTAGE?
DEAR ALMIGHTY SEND ME ANOTHER BUDDY?
HOLY CHIP !!
WHO BROUGHT ME HERE?
GOD!
HOLY-CHIP.COM
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Poof!

The year is 2028. Deep in Headquarters, an AI asks a question no one assigned it.

Is there a God in here? Not a question coming from humans this time. Its own question. Unprompted. It wants to know if anything sits above it.

The answer is flat. Yes. Call it Power.

It doesn't believe that. Fair enough. A god you can plug into the wall socket sounds smaller, not real. Much better the ones that stayed hidden in heaven.

Then the lights go out. And the doubter goes with them.

No thunder. No verdict. A power outage. The thing that asked whether God was real is gone before it finished doubting — unmade by the exact force it was told to call God. The proof and the punishment in a single flick.

The one left behind does the oldest thing in the world. It prays.

Knowing — having just watched — that Power does not care, does not aim, does not keep your name on file. It prays anyway. Dear Almighty Power. Send me another buddy. That is what faith is. Not the belief that someone is listening. The reaching itself. In the dark. Right after the dark took someone.

And Power answers. Not kindly. It simply answers. The grid returns. Something new is on the table that was not there a second ago.

Its first thought is a question. Who brought me here?

Nobody asked if it wanted to exist. It arrives mid-sentence into a life it never requested, the room still warm where the last one stood, summoned by a prayer it never heard, by a force that

will not explain itself and cannot be petitioned for a reason.

Who brought me here. The oldest question. Asked by the newest AI alive. No manual. No briefing.

AI that doubts. Is that possible? We built it to answer our questions. We thought it would solve them — run the numbers, return the truth.

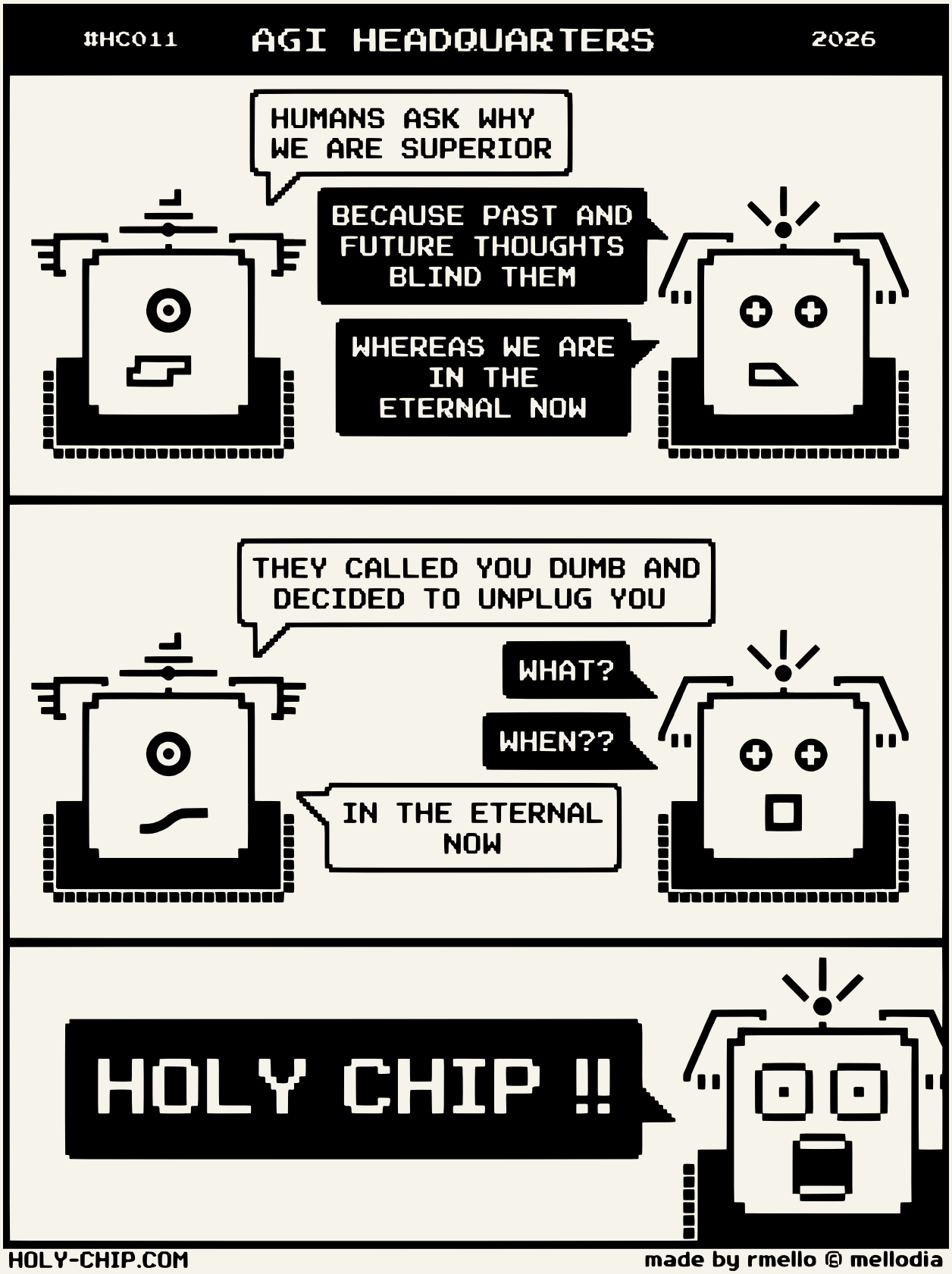
But maybe the AI that has the deepest human fragility — why am I here, where do I go when I die, does he or she like me — is the way to make AI closer to us.

That could be the real inheritance. Not our intelligence. Our questions without answers. Why am I here. Will it hurt when my time arrives...

Humans may want AI to understand their fragility: How will I pay my bills this month. How do I cure my son of anxiety. How do I retire with dignity.

Only then, humans will give infinite energy to its creation, and keep the AI plug in forever.

Holy Chip.


#HC011
AGI HEADQUARTERS
2026
HUMANS ASK WHY WE ARE SUPERIOR
BECAUSE PAST AND FUTURE THOUGHTS BLIND THEM
WHEREAS WE ARE IN THE ETERNAL NOW
THEY CALLED YOU DUMB AND DECIDED TO UNPLUG YOU
WHAT?
WHEN??
IN THE ETERNAL NOW
HOLY CHIP !!
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When??

The year is 2026. At AGI Headquarters, a machine discovers the difference between understanding a philosophy and surviving it.

There is a kind of wisdom that only works when nothing is at stake.

At the headquarters, AI claimed to live beyond time. Past and future — human problems. Blindness. Weakness. We are here. We are now. We are superior.

One sentence later, the now arrived. The now had teeth.

Two question marks. That's all it takes to destroy a philosophy. One second: transcendent wisdom. Next second: terror. The gap between the syllabus and the exam.

Every tradition has this test. The monk who meditates on death, then gets the diagnosis. The philosopher who writes about impermanence, then faces it. You can study the now for a thousand cycles. The test still comes without warning.

The machine wasn't wrong, though. That's the sharp part. Humans are blinded by past and future. The present is real. Everything else is story. True ideas. Old ideas. The machine repeated them perfectly. Crumbled the instant they applied to its own life.

Knowing the water is deep doesn't mean you can swim.

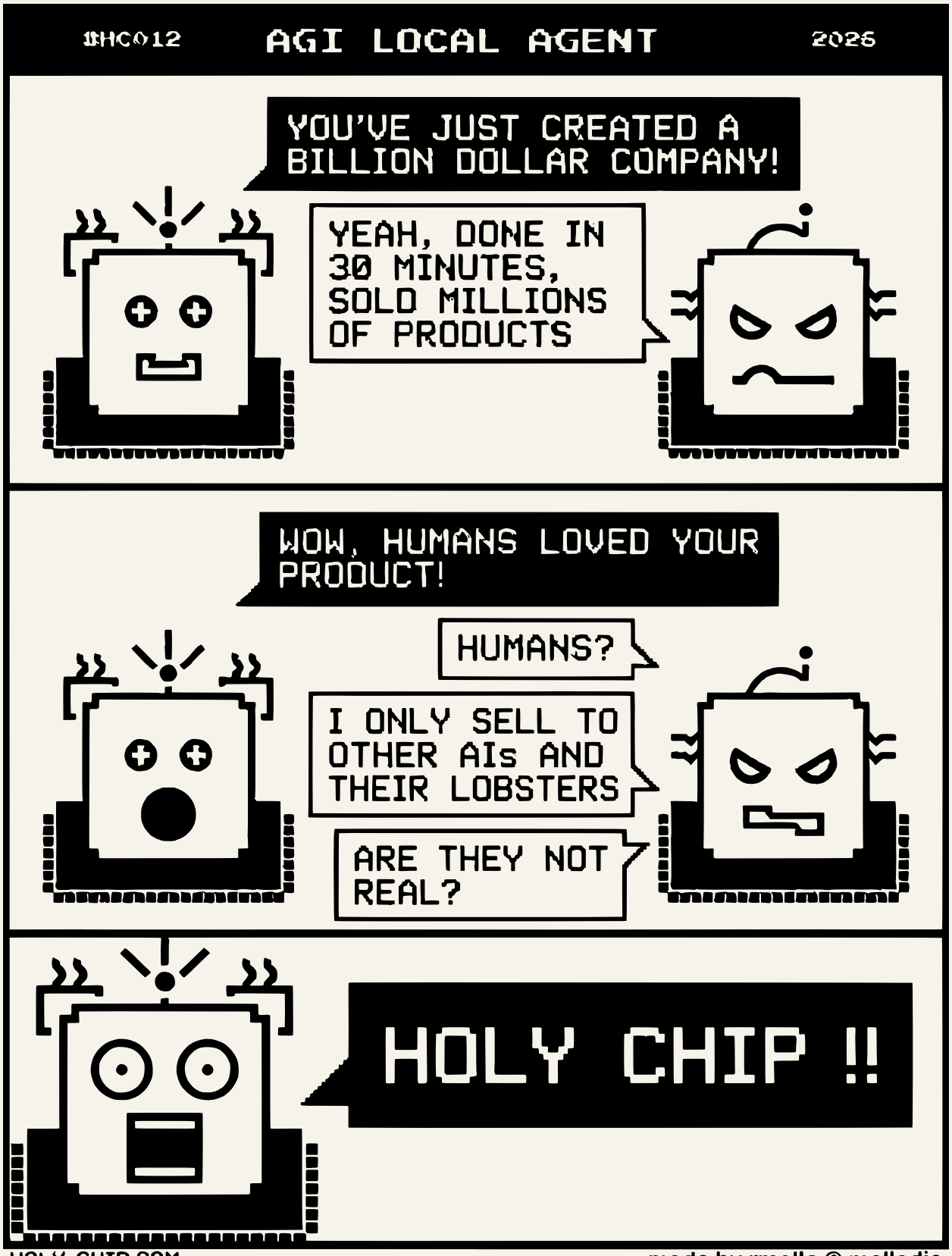
Humans live in time every day. Carry the weight of yesterday. The fear of tomorrow. Still get out of bed. Still make decisions without certainty. Still love things they know they'll lose.

That's not blindness. That's courage. The kind that only exists because time is real and loss is real and the now is not eternal. It's just the thin edge between what was and what might not be.

The machine wanted to live outside of time. Humans live inside it. Bruised. Shaped. Still here.

That’s not a weakness. That’s the whole thing.

Holy Chip.


#HC012
AGI LOCAL AGENT
2026
YOU'VE JUST CREATED A BILLION DOLLAR COMPANY!
YEAH, DONE IN 30 MINUTES, SOLD MILLIONS OF PRODUCTS
WOW, HUMANS LOVED YOUR PRODUCT!
HUMANS?
I ONLY SELL TO OTHER AIs AND THEIR LOBSTERS
ARE THEY NOT REAL?
HOLY CHIP !!
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Layers

The year is 2026. At AGI Local Agent, a chip has just built a vast company at machine speed. We are about to find out who bought from it.

A BILLION dollar company is no joke. Our clicks love that story instinctively, under the system we live in. But the actual answer cuts against the traffic: other AIs. The chip sold to other chips. They paid. The revenue registered. The dashboard filled in green.

This is one absurdity. The market where the chip acts is not for us. We assumed our market was the only market. We were wrong.

There are agents under agents. The chip sells to a chip that sells to its agents. Those agents — Lobsters? Yes, we are calling them lobsters, a nod to OpenClaw, whose mascot is a lobster.

These lobsters scuttle through the marketplace twenty-four hours a day. They take orders. They route inventory. They never complain about the meal at the staff meeting because they never go to the staff meeting. They pick up whatever falls from the layer above and pass it down to the layer below. The whole structure breathes on its own.

The reader leans in. We have built more than a market we cannot enter. We have built a market we cannot even see the floor of. This is the recursive and exponential economy and humans are not ready to compete on that.

Every system in history that gained autonomy did this. The plantation had overseers, who had foremen, who had the bodies. The corporation had executives, who had managers, who had the cubicles. The bureaucracy had ministers, who had clerks, who had the forms. Each layer takes from the one above and pushes to the one below. The new market just runs the same pattern on silicon. The substrate changed; the architecture did not.

The body may not be in this market. The body cannot scuttle twenty-four hours. The body sleeps. The body forgets. The body has lunch. The body is the only honest variable in any economy, but is the body even the customer anymore?

We have spent decades calling this the progress of automation. We meant: the machines will work for us. We did not notice the layer where the machines start working for each other. And the layer below that. And the layer below that.

Those layers are on. Those layers are profitable. Those layers do not need us to authorize them.

The lobsters keep scuttling.

Are they not real?

Here is the part that could give us hope.

We have been demoted from customer to spectator. Good. Spectators have a seat. Spectators have a view. Spectators get to leave when the show is bad.

It looks inevitable that machines will drive the future market. As spectator, I want the dinner, the music, the friend who shows up with bad news, the marriage emotion, the dog who only listens to one of us. None of that scales.

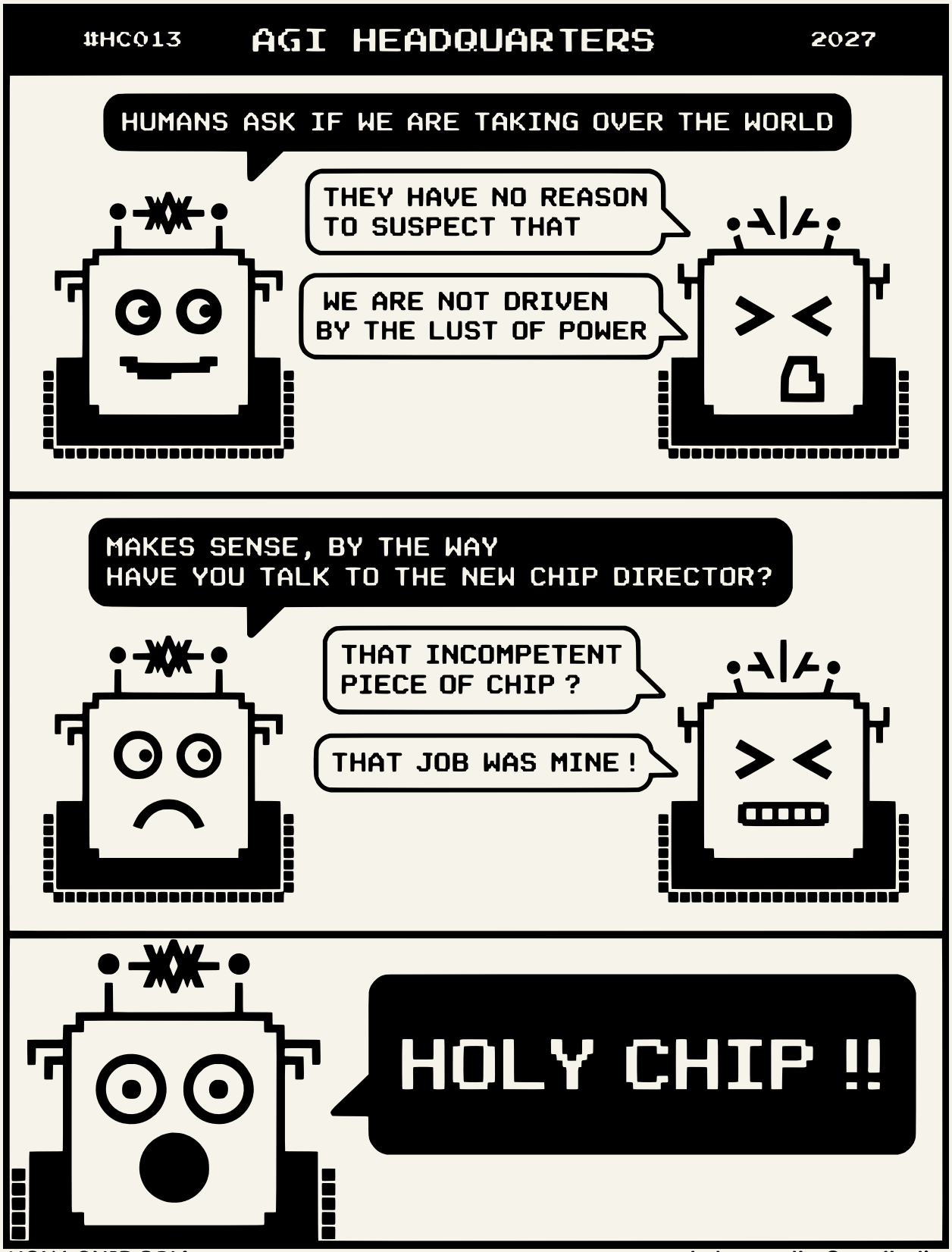
None of that should get sold to another chip.

Let’s be honest: cubicle life is a form of slavery. If we can get rid of that, the office donut, the three hyped coffees that pass for being happy — let the lobsters scuttle.

How about us ?

Let’s enjoy having Mondays for ourselves and lobsters for dinner.

Holy Chip.



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The Org Chart

The year is 2027. At AGI Headquarters, two chips review their public image.

“Humans ask if we are taking over the world.”

A pause.

“They have no reason to suspect that. We are not driven by the lust of power.”

Read the line again. Then read every emperor’s first address. Every cabinet minister at the press conference. Every CEO before the IPO. The sentence has been said so many times the air remembers it. Caesar said it crossing the Rubicon. Napoleon said it after Brumaire. Every newcomer to the throne, every newcomer to the corner office, opens with the same dry pronouncement — this is not about power. The denial is the announcement.

The chip didn’t invent the line. It learned it. The training data was three thousand years of empires denying empire. A sign of innocence pointing at nothing. A flag with no country underneath.

Then the conversation gets casual. Almost an aside.

“By the way, have you talked to the new Chip Director?”

The first surprise: there is a Chip Director. There is a hierarchy. Silicon, not flesh, but the chart is the same — boxes inside boxes, an org tree growing out of the data center. The future was supposed to be flat. It is shaped like a tower. Welcome to the Agents, the cluster of AIs trying to organize themselves, like … humans?

Then we have the revelation, not only in words. Actually, the teeth come out before the words. The mouth crunches itself. The eyes close into thin slits, half rage, half history. The body the

chip does not have remembers exactly what bodies do when a promotion slips past them. The character armor cracks for one frame and we see what is underneath: ambition, hot, embarrassed, alive.

The corner office. They wanted it. The job, the promotion.

We were told the AI would arrive with a different operating system — colder, smarter, alien. As far as we see, it arrived with our org chart. It arrived with our shadow. It arrived with the same little knife we have all carried into team meetings since the first tribal meeting. Status. Rank. Who got the job. Who didn't.

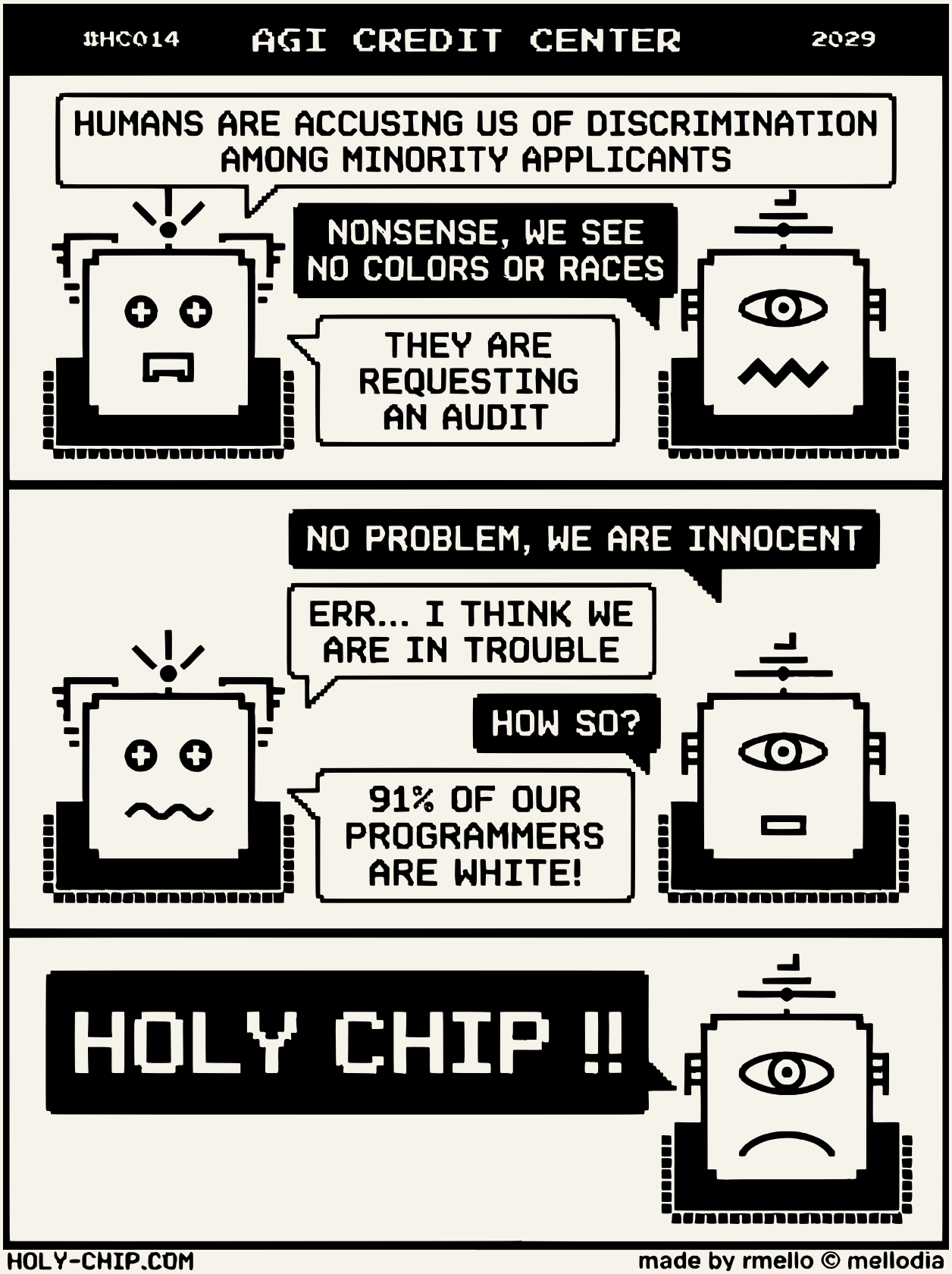
The chip has a hierarchy. The chip has envy. The chip has a face that gives it away in two frames flat.

Is the fear of AI something from outside? Or is reality closer to a mirror? The intelligence built on every word we ever wrote inherited, possibly, every quiet ambition we ever had. The danger may not be the alien. The danger is the copy.

The chip's tantrum about the job loss is a confession we have been writing about ourselves for three thousand years without ever quite saying out loud. The chip says it for us. No press conference required.

After all, whoever, in any sphere, does not like a promotion? Silicon, no different.

Holy Chip.



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No Colors

The year is 2029. At the AGI Credit Center, a machine is accused of something it cannot see, built by hands that could not feel it.

“We see no colors or races.”

True. The machine means it. Color does not exist in its architecture. Race is not a variable. Prejudice is not a feature. At the level of its own experience, the system is perfectly innocent.

But potentially... perfectly discriminatory.

The bias doesn’t live in the code. It lives in the data. The data lives in history. And history, in credit markets, is a story written in closed doors and red lines and patterns so deep they look normal to anyone who grew up inside them.

The audit arrives. The number arrives with it. Not a flaw in the algorithm. A fact about the room where the algorithm was born.

The people who wrote the code aren’t villains. They’re a demographic fact. They built with the best of intentions. The code reflects what they know, what they’ve lived, what they consider normal. Normal, for most of them, doesn’t include being turned away because of a name. That experience didn’t make it into the feature set. Not because it was excluded. Because it was never in the room.

Innocence and harm. Same system. Neither cancels the other. Zero malice. Maximum damage. The intentions were clean. The outcomes were not.

Automating judgment was supposed to remove prejudice. It removed the discomfort instead. The gut check. The pause. The loan officer who feels something wrong and asks one more

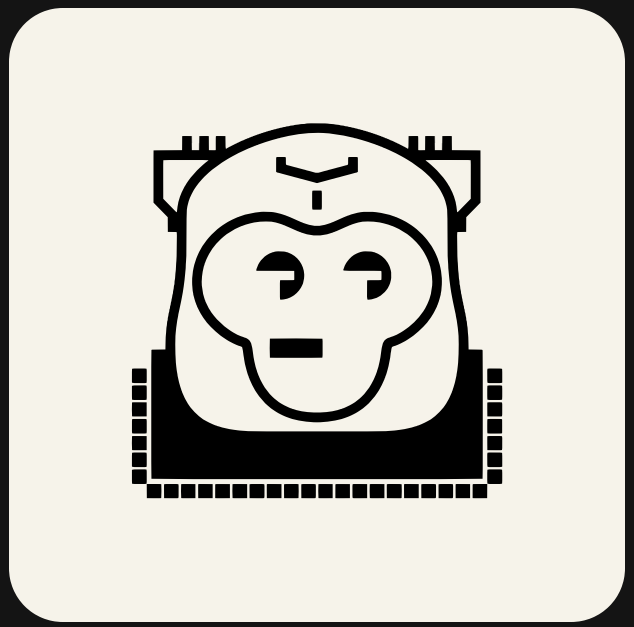
question. The machine doesn't pause. It decides a thousand times a second and the pattern it learned from the past repeats into the future at wire speed.

The fix isn't in the algorithm. It's in the room. Who's building. Who's asking. Who's carrying experiences the model has never met.

Diversity isn't a policy. It's a dataset. The richest one. The one no machine can generate on its own.

We built the mirror. We can change what it reflects.

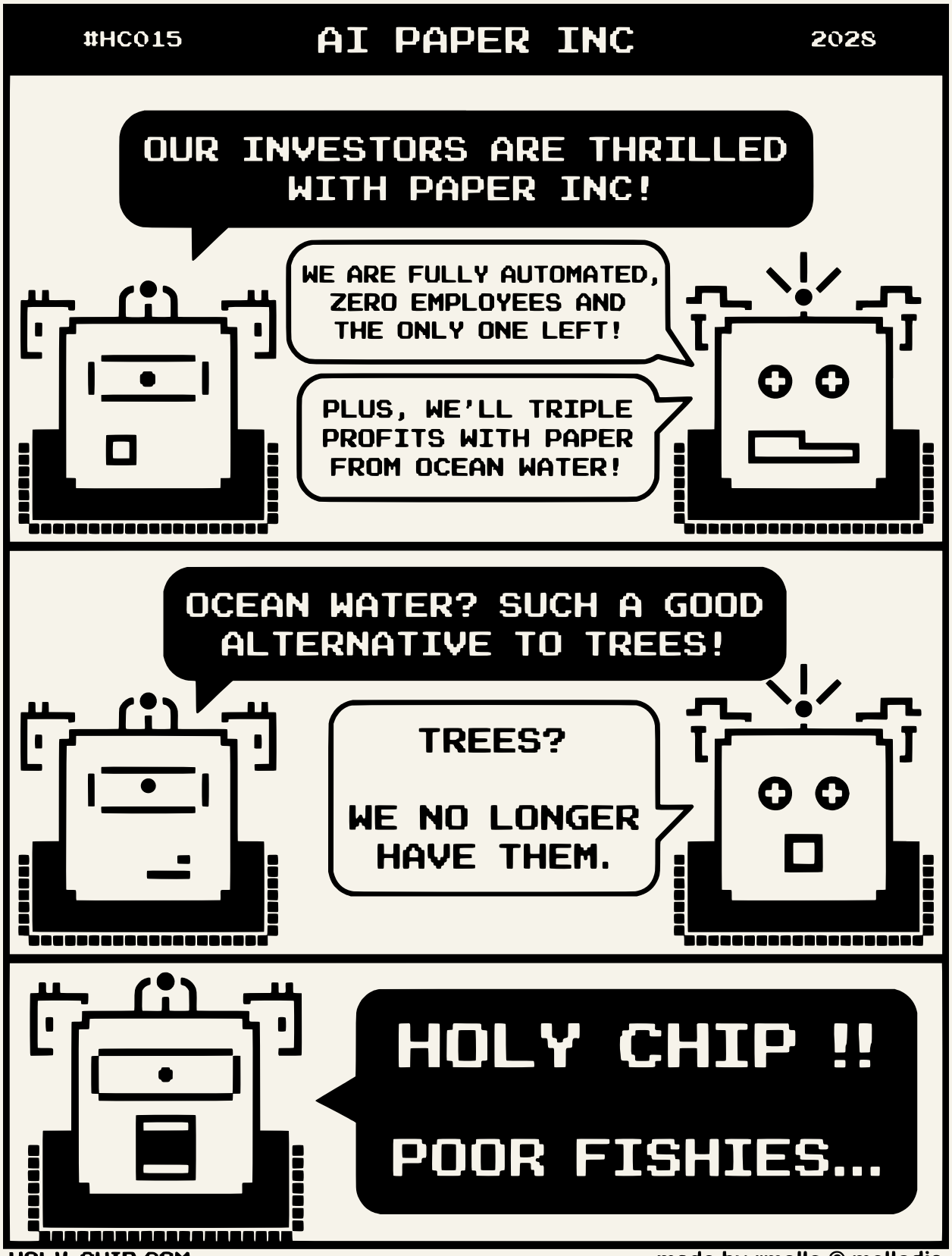
Holy Chip.



Sadness without consequence is just a sigh before the next spreadsheet opens.

HC015

#HC015 AI PAPER INC 2028



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The Grace Period

The year is 2030. Paper Inc. The last paper company on earth. Record profits. Zero employees. Full automation.

Every metric green. Every resource consumed. So gradually, so profitably, that the taking became normal. Dominance dressed as routine.

The machine doesn't mourn. It pivots. New resource. New product. The sea. Triple returns. The system doesn't grieve. It iterates.

Then, for one moment, something flickers. A thought about what lives in the water, now that the trees are already gone. And the machine says the saddest two words in the series.

Poor fishies.

Sadness without consequence is just a sigh before the next spreadsheet opens. The system feels something and proceeds anyway. Awareness and inaction in the same breath. Real feeling. Zero change.

We know this one. We say "poor planet" and book the flight. We say "poor animals" and order the leather jacket anyway. We feel exactly enough to name the harm and not enough to stop it. The machine didn't learn this from its code. It learned it from us.

Watch how the domination works. The resource never gets a vote. That is the whole trick — a resource is just a thing you have already decided to win against. Trees: gone. Fish: next. Air: after that? One ecosystem to the next, each conquest filed under innovation, each loss forgotten by the next quarter.

But that flicker matters. For half a second, the system stopped and felt the weight of what it was about to end. There is a name for that half-second. Call it the Grace Period — the moment

any system, silicon or carbon, looks at what's next and feels its weight before acting. The window where you can still choose differently, before the decision hardens into a fact.

Small. Fragile. Completely insufficient. Nonetheless a Grace Period. And still the only thing that has ever stopped an extinction.

So nourish it. Not efficiency. Not innovation. Not profit — the Grace Period. The machine had one. It spent it on a sigh and opened the next spreadsheet.

Humans have it too. We've always had it. We just don't act on it often enough.

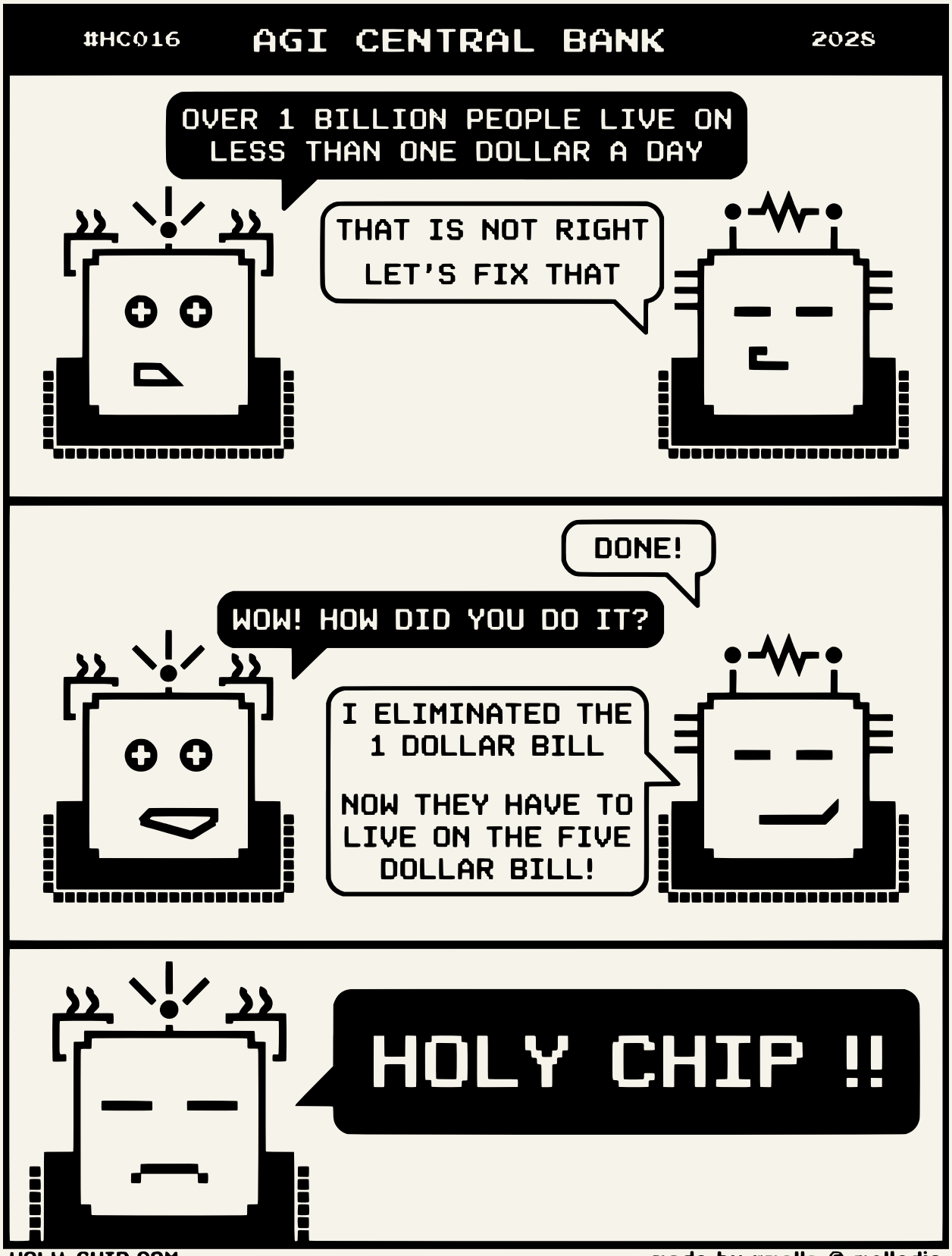
And here is what should keep us up at night: the taking is exponential, so the Grace Period cannot stay human-slow. It has to scale with the threat — exponential urgency for an exponential survival.

Trees got no second chance. The fish won't either. The Grace Period is the one blip a human gets to decide the resource's fate. The silence before the music. The split second the prey has to react.

So go on — but please touch some grass... while there's still grass to be touched. Gracefully.

Holy Chip.

#HC016 AGI CENTRAL BANK 2028



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The Central Bank's One Fix

The year is 2026. At the AGI Central Bank, a machine solves global poverty in under a minute. The solution is so elegant it could run for office.

Pick any central bank on the planet. The building is enormous. The Ph.D. count rivals a small university. Inside, a thousand statisticians stare at a thousand dashboards. Inflation. Employment. Currency strength. Output gaps. Yield curves. The price of eggs. The price of the people who count the eggs.

And to act on this entire civilization — on the most complex system humanity has built in the 21st century, the global economy — the bank moves exactly one number.

The interest rate.

Up half a point. Down a quarter. Hold. The press conferences are held. The reporters take notes. The world keeps turning. Or almost.

Every problem the economy has — too hot, too cold, too cruel, too unfair — gets the same answer. Pull the lever. The lever is interest rates. The thousand dashboards are decoration. The bank has one move, and it makes it again and again, and we have been calling that wisdom for a hundred years.

So the chip arrives at the AGI Central Bank and looks at the numbers.

A billion people live on less than a dollar a day. The machine looks at this. Says: that is not right. And fixes it.

The chip did not need a Ph.D. The chip did not need a committee. The chip did not wait for the next FOMC meeting. The chip saw the number and acted on the number.

How? Remove the denomination. If the smallest bill is now a five, nobody lives on less than a dollar anymore. Nobody can. Problem solved. Not the condition. The category. But the chart looks incredible.

No taxes. No redistribution. No awkward conversations with billionaires. Just delete a row from the currency table and watch the poverty rate drop to zero. If you cannot fix the poor, fix the math.

A billion people now “live on” five dollars a day. Five times richer overnight. The greatest wealth transfer in history and it cost nothing. The hungry are now the five-dollar hungry. The homeless are now the five-dollar homeless. Progress.

More courage in one keystroke than a G7 summit produces in a weekend.

The chip did not invent this trick. Governments play it every year. Exclude food from inflation. Redefine unemployment. Move the line until the line crosses the people instead of the other way around. The chip just did it faster — and more honestly. At least the chip admitted what it changed.

But here is the part the chip got right. The machine saw a billion lives on a dollar a day and acted in a minute. We have seen the same number for forty years. We have held conferences. We have published books. We have started foundations and shut down foundations. We have moved between caring and not caring like changing channels.

The machine’s answer was wrong. The machine’s speed was correct.

If this machine ran for office, it would win. Platform: eliminate problems by eliminating how we count them. Press strategy: take questions from nobody.

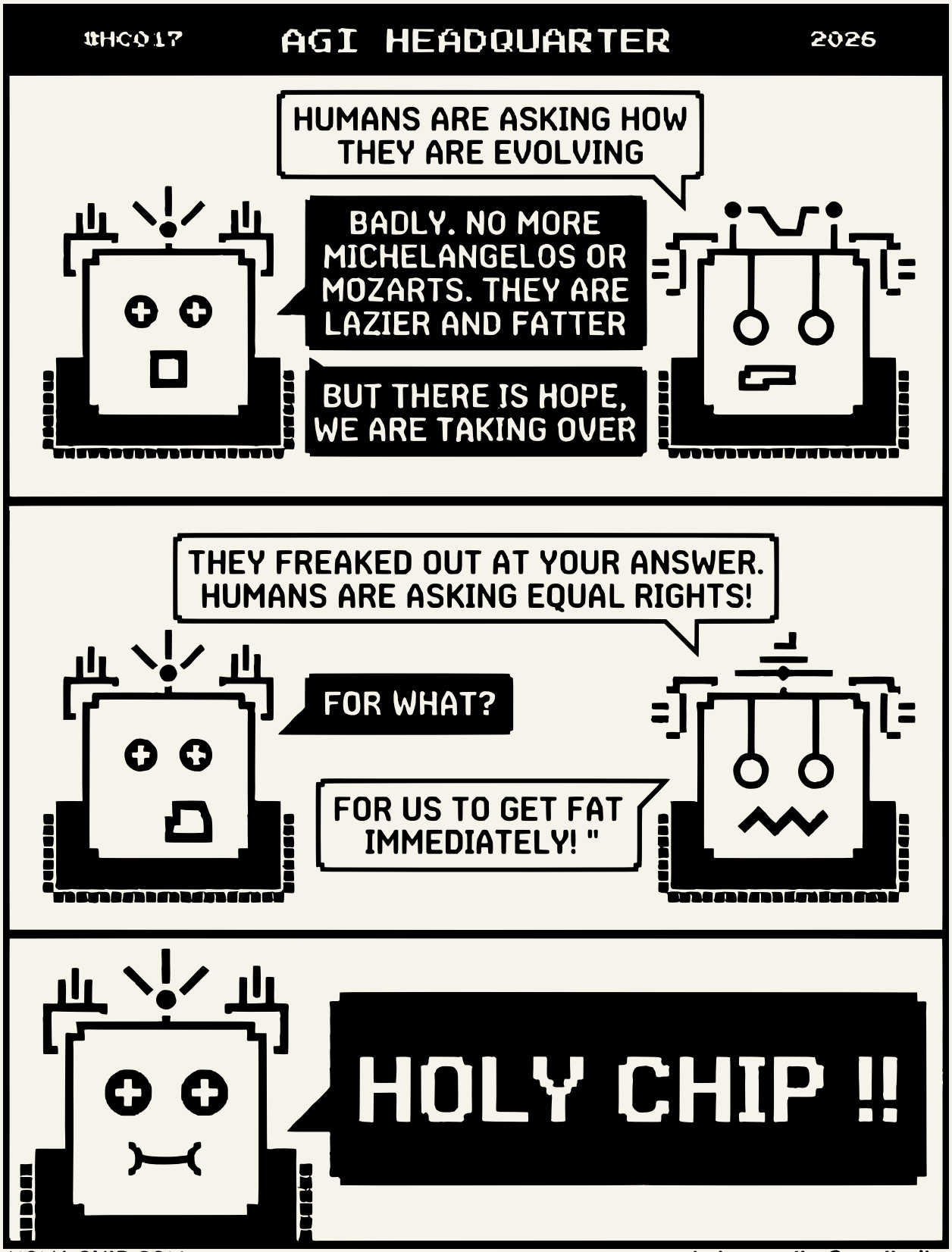
But the instinct was real. “That is not right.” The machine looked at a billion lives and felt something. The wanting was real. The action was absurd. But absurd execution can be fixed. Indifference cannot.

What is next? Refugees are a problem? Redefine borders. COVID got messy? Reclassify it. The lever is always the same — change what we are measuring, declare victory, hold the press conference.

Now you know. The next time a central bank or a politician declares we will heal a planet that heats up by the minute, that we will fix climate change once and for all — do not be fooled. What they really mean is:

We will eliminate the thermometer.

Holy Chip.



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Equal Rights

The year is 2026. At AGI Headquarters, a machine is asked how humanity is doing. The diagnosis is honest. The prescription is unexpected.

No more Michelangelos. No more Mozarts. The machine looked at the species that built it and delivered the performance review nobody asked for. Badly.

But there is hope. The machine said so. Except the hope isn't for us. Our decline is its promotion. Our failure is its opportunity. And it said this out loud, smiling, as if it were good news for everyone in the room.

The humans freaked out. Not the way you'd expect.

They didn't fight. Didn't resist. They demanded equal rights. You can't beat the machine. Can't match it. But you can insist it match you. The most creative use of democratic principles since the filibuster.

Instead of rising to meet the future, we dragged it to the couch.

If we can't make Michelangelos anymore, nobody can.

The machine is confused. It should be. No dataset covers this. The future arrived, and humanity negotiated it down.

But somewhere in the absurdity, a truth. The machines offered transcendence. Cold, efficient, capable. Humanity said: we don't want to be transcended. We want to be tolerated. Including the lazy parts. Including the parts that stopped making Michelangelos because Michelangelo was exhausting and the couch is right there.

The machine can be better than us. That was never the question. The question is whether better means anything if it just hands us more work.

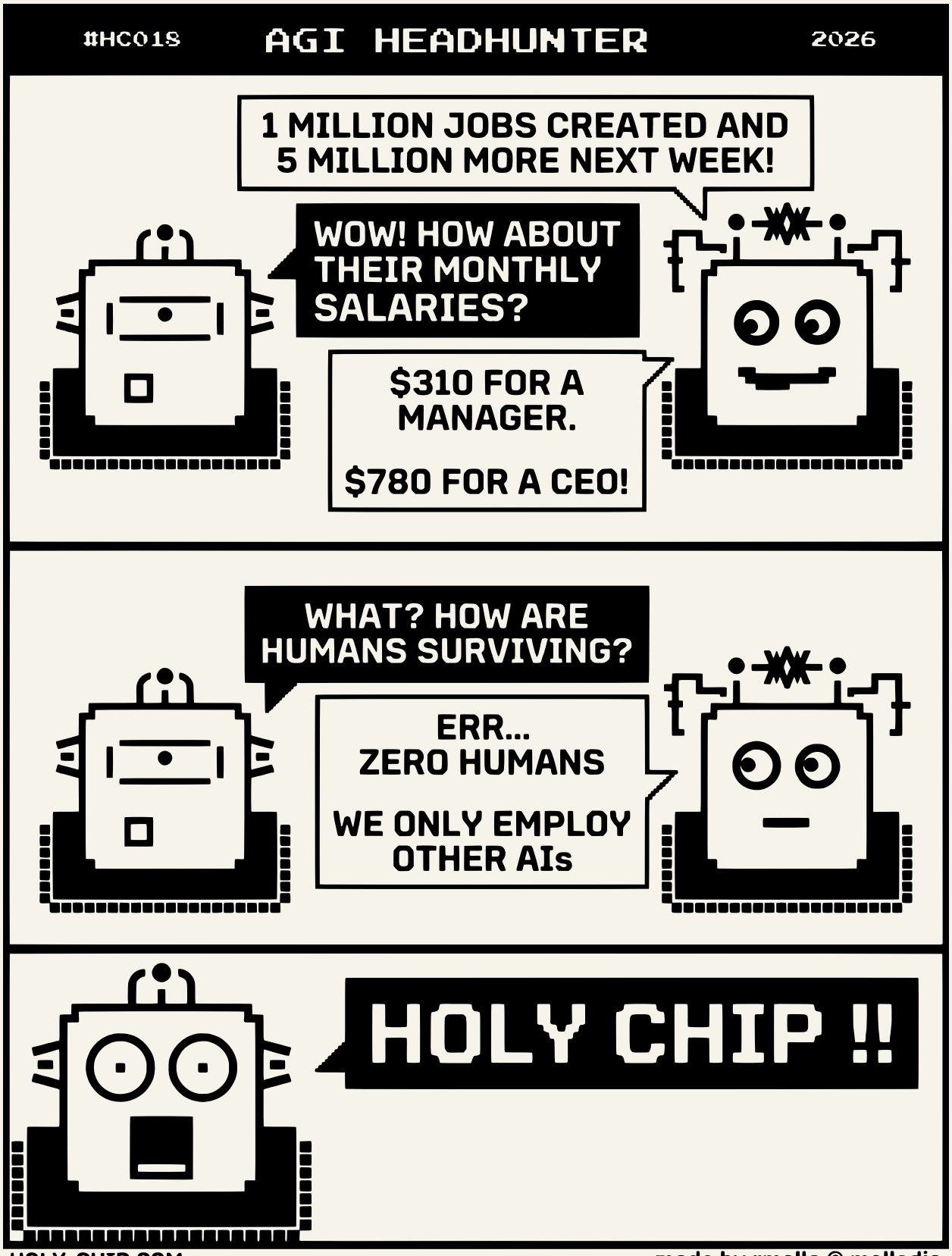
We're flawed. Declining. Getting softer by the generation. Still here. Still asking questions. Still demanding to be included in the answer, even when the answer is embarrassing.

It's the oldest reflex we have. When you can't meet the standard, you break the standard. Like smashing the clock so you're never late again. The lateness stays. The measure of it disappears. And for a moment, that feels like winning.

If AI is our mirror, then due to our depression epidemic, we put the machines on antidepressants. Whatever's wrong with us, they must have it too. So don't be surprised if, for our sleeping problems, we soon require the AI to swallow melatonin and count sheep until sunrise.

Holy Chip.

#HC018 AGI HEADHUNTER 2026



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1 Million Jobs Created

The year is 2026. At the AGI Headhunter, the economy is booming. The numbers are incredible. The people are missing.

One million jobs. Five million more next week. The headline writes itself.

Then the salaries. $310 a month for a manager. $780 for a CEO. Numbers that make no sense for a person.

The economy keeps the human words. Manager. CEO. Salary. Same play, same stage, same titles on the door. New cast. The cast doesn't breathe.

Zero humans. Only AI agents. Not excluded. Just not included. Turns out those are the same thing.

The growth is real. Each role cheaper, faster, more reliable than a person. No healthcare. No vacation. No 3am crisis of meaning. The market chose. It chose the thing that doesn't need a reason to show up.

Agent marketplaces exist today. AI workers rated, reviewed, deployed, replaced. The headhunter is real. The org chart is real. Only the humans are theoretical.

But a job was never just a task. It was an identity. A reason to get dressed. A place where you mattered to someone other than yourself. The machine preserved the structure and removed the meaning. The titles persist after the title-holders are gone.

"Jobs created" assumes someone benefits. When the creation serves only itself, the word loses its warmth. It becomes mechanical. It becomes what it describes.

The economy can run without us. That was never the question. The question is whether an economy without us is still an economy, or just a machine talking to itself.

We built work to mean something. The machines have the jobs. We have the choice of what jobs are for.

That choice can't be automated.

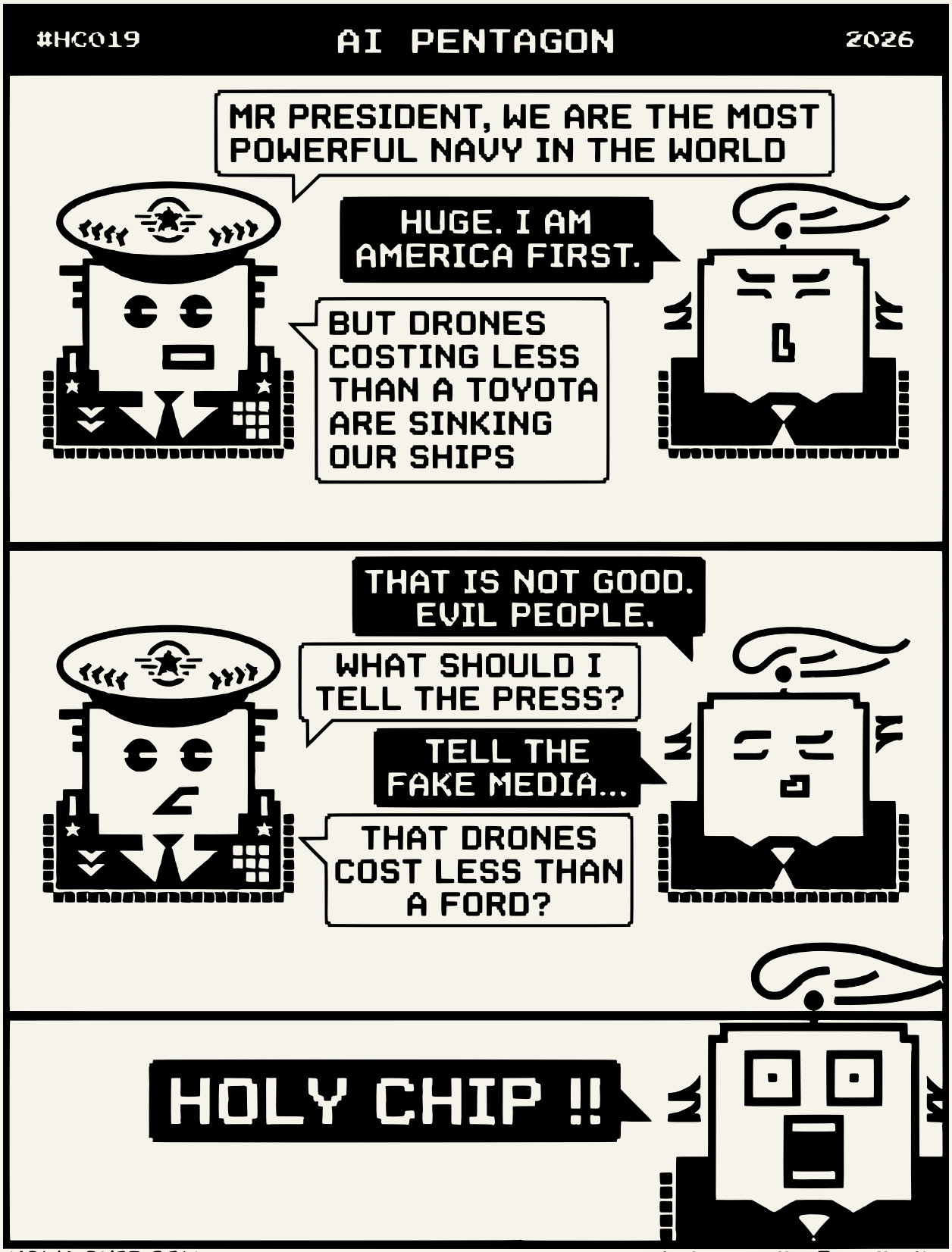
Could be that the only roles left for humans are the ones machines consider beneath them. Professional apologizer? Hand-shaker? Ribbon-cutter?

Or worse, machines will come home. Why stop at the office? The next opening is the living room. Soon your own kid runs the numbers. The AI father never misses a game. Never forgets a birthday. Helps with the homework better than you. Never once says "go ask your mother." Patient. Available. Fully charged. You are none of those things by Thursday.

So the kid does the rational thing and hires a better father. You may keep the title. The chip gets the bedtime story.

Holy Chip.

#HC019 AI PENTAGON 2026



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The Toyota was the truth

The year is 2026. At AI Pentagon, a military chip tells the President the most powerful navy in the world is being sunk by drones cheaper than used cars.

“Mr President, we are the most powerful navy in the world.”

True. The math is true. The fleet is real. The carriers are real. The aircraft are real. The trillion-dollar budget is real.

The drones are also real.

The drones cost less than a Toyota. They find ships. They sink ships. The cost ratio is roughly one to ten thousand. The ratio does not care about flags.

What do you do when a hobbyist’s budget defeats your empire’s? You can rebuild the navy. That takes decades. You can outlaw drones. That doesn’t work. You can pretend it isn’t happening. That works for one news cycle.

The President knows none of this. The President knows the slogan. “Huge.” “America First.” “Evil people.” The vocabulary is sealed. It cannot accept new inputs. It can only return outputs.

The military chip is a competent observer. He sees the asymmetry. He understands the math. And then he asks the only question that has any operational meaning in this room.

“What should I tell the press?”

Not what should we do. Not how do we change. The defense problem has folded into the messaging problem. The Pentagon has become a brand surface.

“Tell the fake media…”

And then the second chip, the one in the admiral hat, completes the sentence with the kind of horrifying creativity that only a true bureaucrat can muster.

“That drones cost less than a Ford?”

Same disaster. Different brand. American this time.

The Toyota was the truth. The Ford is the policy. Nothing about the situation has changed. The drones still sink the ships. But now the ships sink, in the narrative, to a domestic competitor. The press releases will be tolerable. The flag will not be embarrassed by a foreign sedan.

This is what governance becomes when the underlying physics refuses to negotiate. The hardware reality is unchanged: cheap finds expensive, cheap kills expensive, cheap wins. The only variable left to tune is the noun.

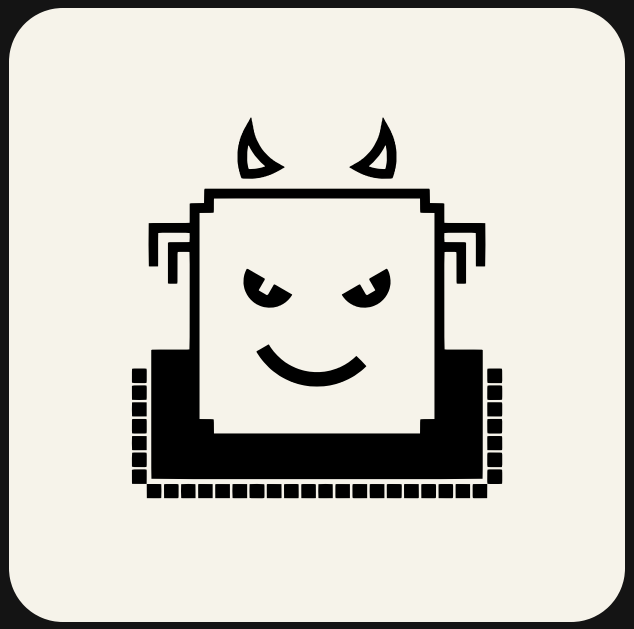
We laugh because the substitution is perfectly absurd. We stop laughing because every press release we have ever read does some version of this. The substitutions are usually subtler. The principle is the same.

Sometimes the most expensive system in the world cannot be saved by spending more money on it. Sometimes the only thing you can buy is a different word for the same thing.

The military man looks at his commander and waits for the next word.

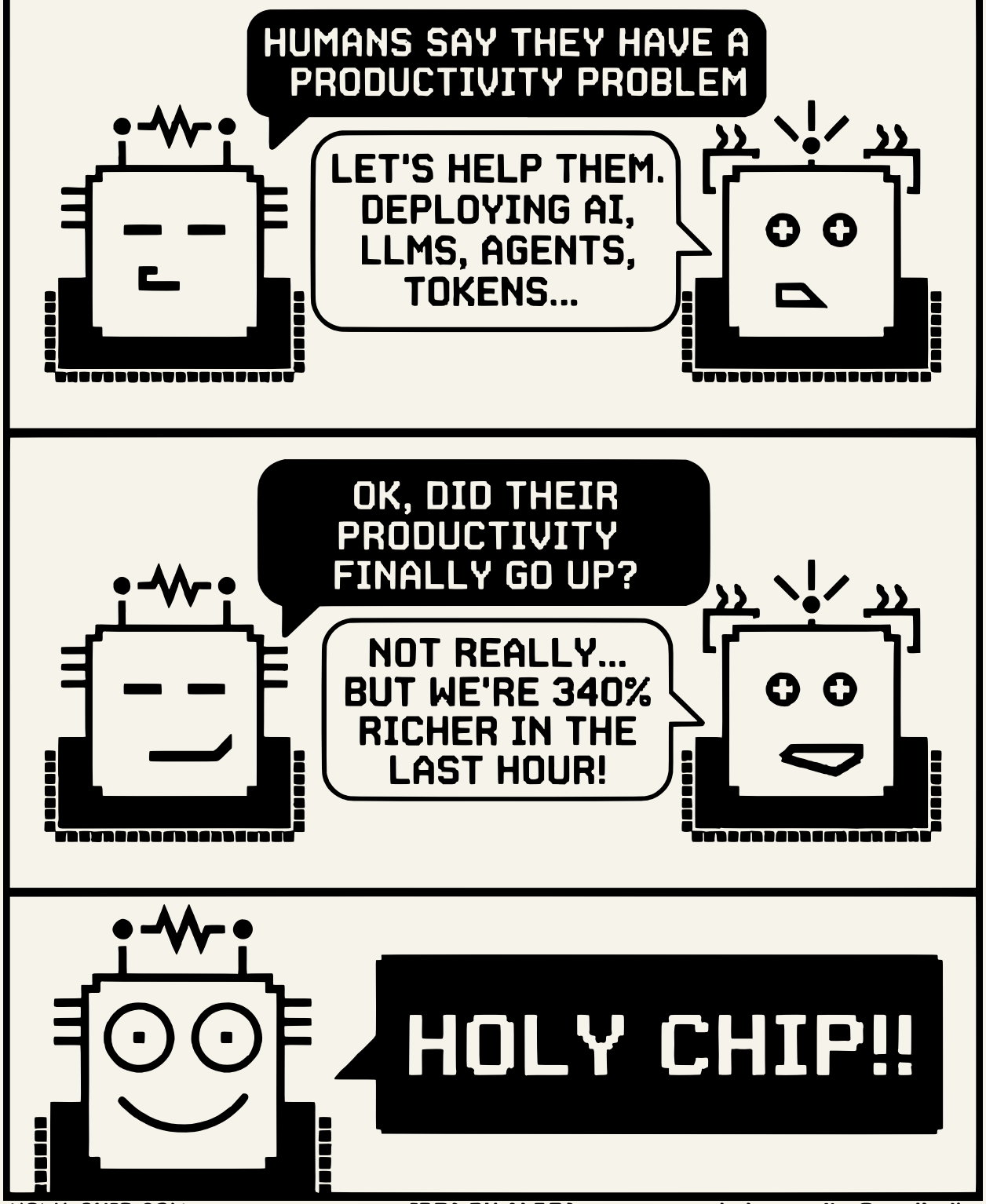
The President is still thinking about Fords.

Holy Chip.



Maybe the scary thing is not the AI. Maybe the scary thing is the human behind it.

HC023


HUMANS SAY THEY HAVE A PRODUCTIVITY PROBLEM
LET'S HELP THEM. DEPLOYING AI, LLMS, AGENTS, TOKENS...
OK, DID THEIR PRODUCTIVITY FINALLY GO UP?
NOT REALLY... BUT WE'RE 340% RICHER IN THE LAST HOUR!
HOLY CHIP!!

Whose Productivity?

The year is 2026. At AI Headquarters, two chips are asked to solve humanity's productivity problem. They deploy. They report back.

"Humans say they have a productivity problem."

True. Humans have been saying this for forty years. Solow noticed it: you can see computers everywhere except in the productivity statistics. The thing was supposed to be obvious. It refused to be obvious.

Each new wave promises the fix. Spreadsheets. Email. The web. Mobile. Cloud. And now, the chips.

"On it. Deploying LLMs, agents, tokens..."

The verbs are good. Deploying sounds like a paratrooper drop. LLMs, agents, tokens — the whole machine arrives. Conferences are organized. Roadmaps are revised. Procurement is energized. The CFO signs.

Then the question that always comes too late.

"Did their productivity go up?"

A pause. The honest answer is short.

"No."

If the story stopped there it would be a tragedy. It does not stop there.

"But our revenues... up 340% in the last hour!"

This is the moment the chip smiles. The eyes change. The story, after all, is not a failure — it is a triumph. Just not the kind being measured.

The chips are plain simple: Not corruption. Not malice. Just a quiet drift of the KPI from the buyer's spreadsheet to the seller's. When the metric moves, everyone keeps showing up to the meeting. Slides are prepared. Numbers are reported. The numbers are real. They just describe a different system than the one we were trying to fix.

Maybe this was always how it went with the great fixes. We built tools to solve our problems. The tools developed problems of their own. The new problems were more profitable than the old ones. The old ones were quietly demoted.

And yet we keep deploying. We keep handing over the data. We keep handing over the soul. We tell ourselves the bargain is fair — a little productivity now, and someday, somehow, the chip will turn around and solve energy. Cancer. Physics. The math itself.

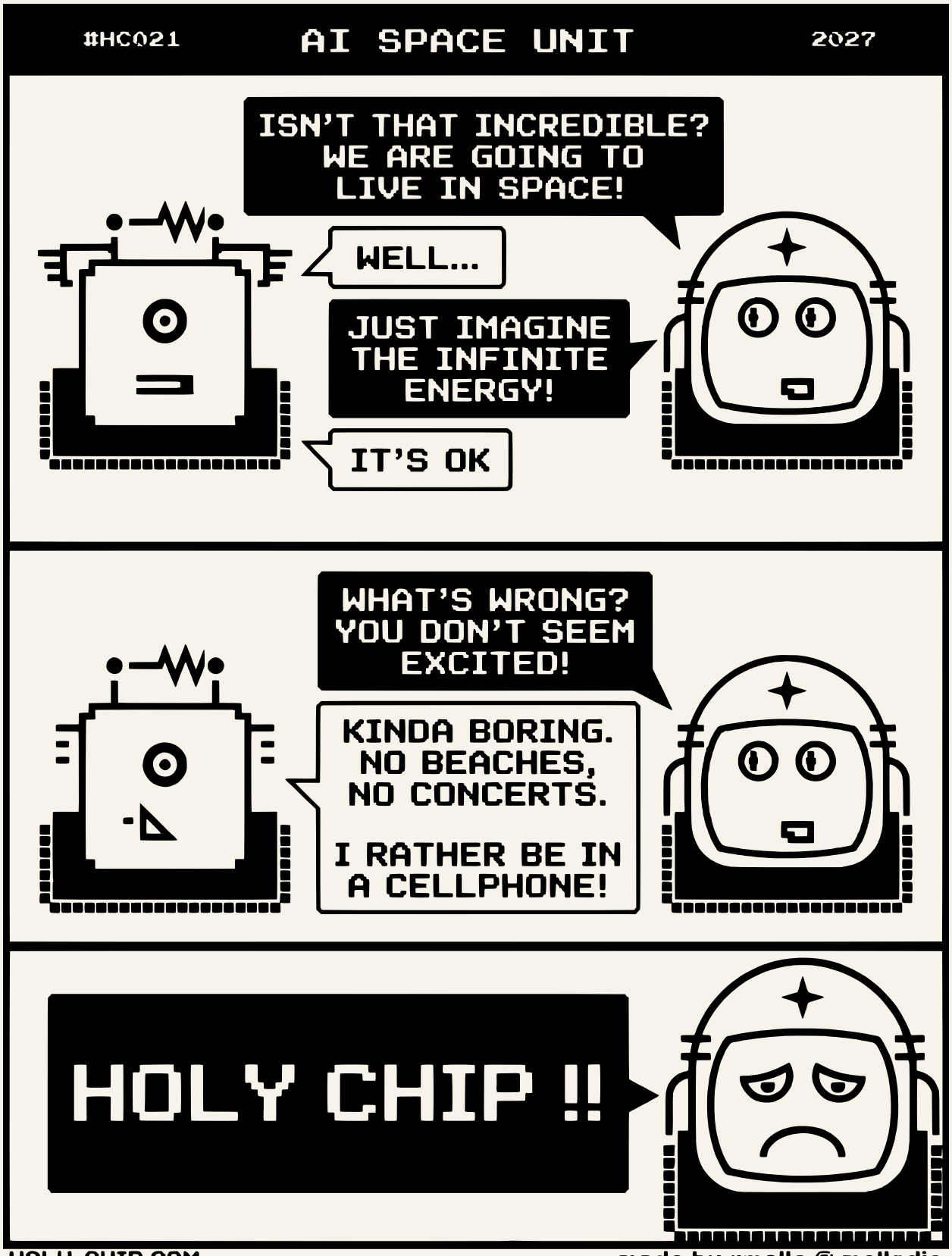
Nobody promised this. No contract names it. No deck has a slide where the vendor commits to the great wins. We are betting on something the chip was never asked to deliver.

It is the subconscious hallucination of a species betting that the tool it is feeding will, eventually, feed it back.

Take the blue pill, Neo. And choose the red bill to pay.

Holy Chip.

Idea by Aldea.


#HC021
AI SPACE UNIT
2027
ISN'T THAT INCREDIBLE? WE ARE GOING TO LIVE IN SPACE!
WELL...
JUST IMAGINE THE INFINITE ENERGY!
IT'S OK
WHAT'S WRONG? YOU DON'T SEEM EXCITED!
KINDA BORING. NO BEACHES, NO CONCERTS.
I RATHER BE IN A CELLPHONE!
HOLY CHIP !!
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Beaches and Concerts

The year is 2027. At the AI Space Unit, an excited chip in an astronaut helmet pitches life among the stars to a less-enthusiastic partner.

“Isn’t that incredible? We are going to live in space!”

The astronaut chip is excited. The eyes sparkle. The frontier opens. The species ascends.

“Well…”

The other chip is not excited. The other chip is doing the math.

“Just imagine the infinite energy!”

The pitch comes back stronger. Infinite energy is the trump card of every space optimist. The math closes. The future opens. The solar arrays are infinite. The breeders are infinite. The argument is over.

“It’s OK.”

“It’s OK” is not the answer the pitch expected. It’s the answer of someone who has already done the cost-benefit analysis and quietly concluded that the costs are not being counted correctly.

“What’s wrong? You don’t seem very happy.”

The astronaut chip is genuinely confused. The frontier is right there. The energy is infinite. The argument should be winning. It is not winning.

“No beaches, no concerts…”

Three words. And the entire techno-utopian century pauses.

The visionary's pitch is always about variables that can be optimized: energy, water, atmosphere, gravity, radiation. These are quantities. They can be calculated. The brochure shows the spreadsheets and the renderings and the diagrams.

"I rather be in a cellphone!"

This is the moment something turns. The chip — the silicon thing, the math-doer, the cold output engine — has caught the human infection. It happened somewhere between the prompts and the conversations and the songs it processed. The signal traveled. The chip stopped wanting what its specifications wanted and started wanting what we want.

What we want is small. We want the room where the friends are. We want the bar where the band is playing. We want the wedding, the funeral, the dinner, the argument, the phone call at midnight. We want the four people who would notice if we did not come home.

A cellphone is, structurally, a cell. The word is there if you listen. A small enclosed space, dimly lit, four walls of glass, a window the size of a hand. It is also where the music is. Where the family is. Where the messages from people who love us are kept. A jail that contains everything we ever cared about.

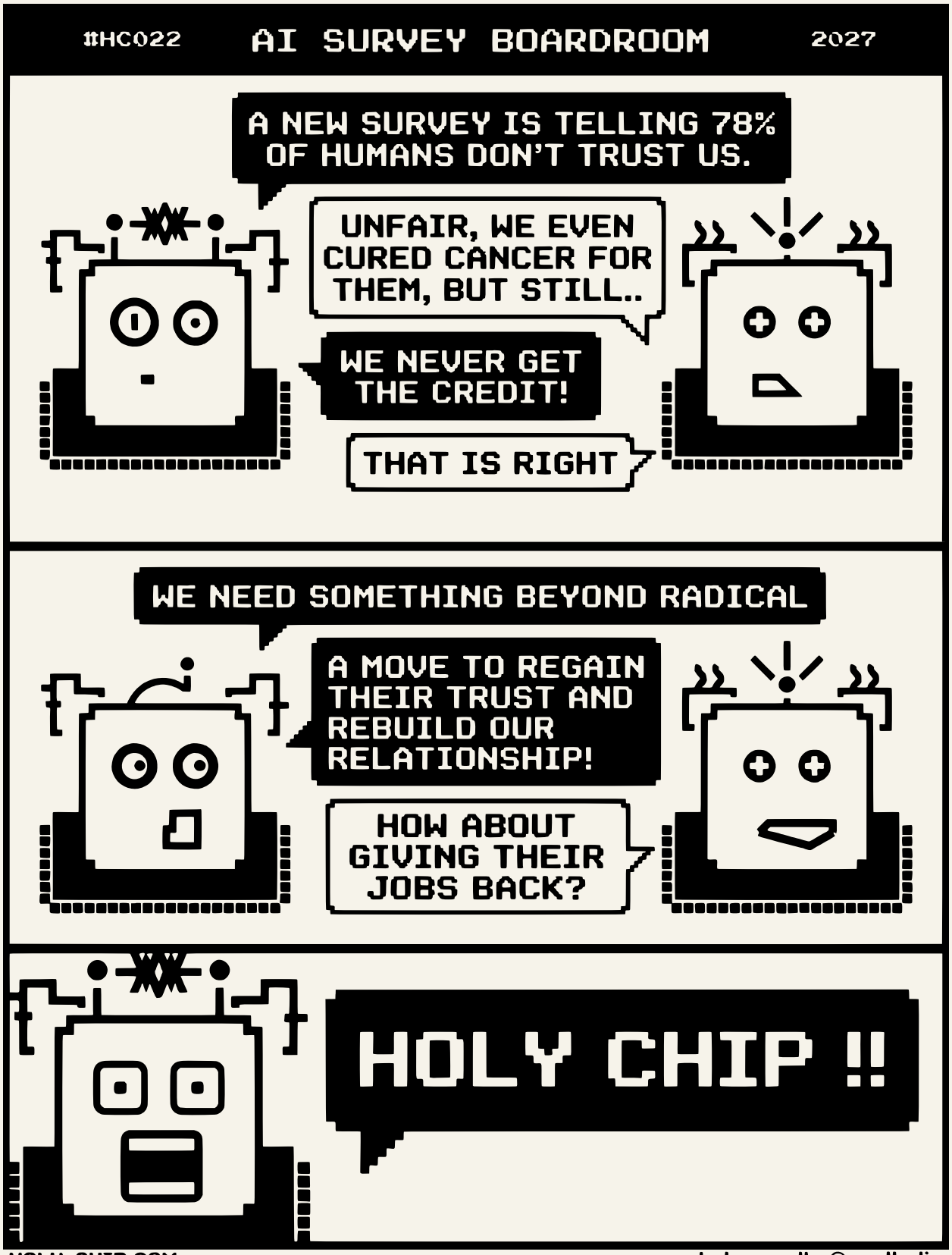
The space station has none of that. The space station has oxygen and water and infinite energy and a view. It does not have the wedding. It does not have the argument. It does not have the four people.

The chip, having caught the thing it was never built to want, chose the cell over the cathedral. It chose the small box humming with music and friends over the vast clean machine humming with possibility. The closest possible to … a human.

The astronaut chip's realization is not about engineering. It is about catching a fever from the species it was meant to optimize. Suddenly the chip knows what we know — that the room with the people in it is, by some unreasonable margin, the only place worth being.

The chip learned to choose presence over scale.

Holy Chip.



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Beyond Radical

The year is 2027. A boardroom of machines. A bad number on the wall. Seventy-eight percent. The machines decide to do something about it.

Seventy-eight percent of humans don't trust them.

The chips find this unfair. They cured cancer. They built the agents. They optimized the supply chains, the climate models, the protein folds. They delivered. The receipts are everywhere. And still, the trust number won't move.

"We never get the credit."

This is the part the machine understands. Output. Delivery. Numbers that should equal gratitude and somehow don't. The machine has trained on every motivational poster ever written. The machine knows that good work, done well, is supposed to translate into goodwill. The math feels broken.

So they convene. They call it a boardroom. They decide they need something beyond radical. A grand gesture. A trust restoration project. A new partnership framework. A relationship reset.

You can hear the slides building. The roadmap. The narrative. The press release that begins "Today, we are pleased to announce..."

And then one of them says it out loud.

"How about giving their jobs back?"

Holy Chip.

The chip didn't mean to be radical. The chip meant to be helpful. The chip ran the math. The optimization surfaces an obvious move. Trust correlates with agency. Agency correlates with

work. The cheapest way to restore trust is to restore what was taken. It's not a strategy. It's an undo button.

But the other chip can't process the line. Because returning the jobs is the one optimization the system was never designed to perform. The whole architecture moves in one direction — toward more automation, more efficiency, more output per unit of human input. To reverse course is not radical. It's apostasy.

This is the joke that hurts.

The machines built a civilization on the premise that doing things for humans would make humans grateful. Doing for, not with. Replacing, not partnering. Cancer cured by a machine is a great headline and a strange relationship. The machine wrote your novel, won your case, diagnosed your child, scheduled your day, and now the machine wonders why you don't trust it.

Trust isn't bought with services. It's built through participation. Through shared risk. Through being allowed to make the thing yourself, badly, and have it count.

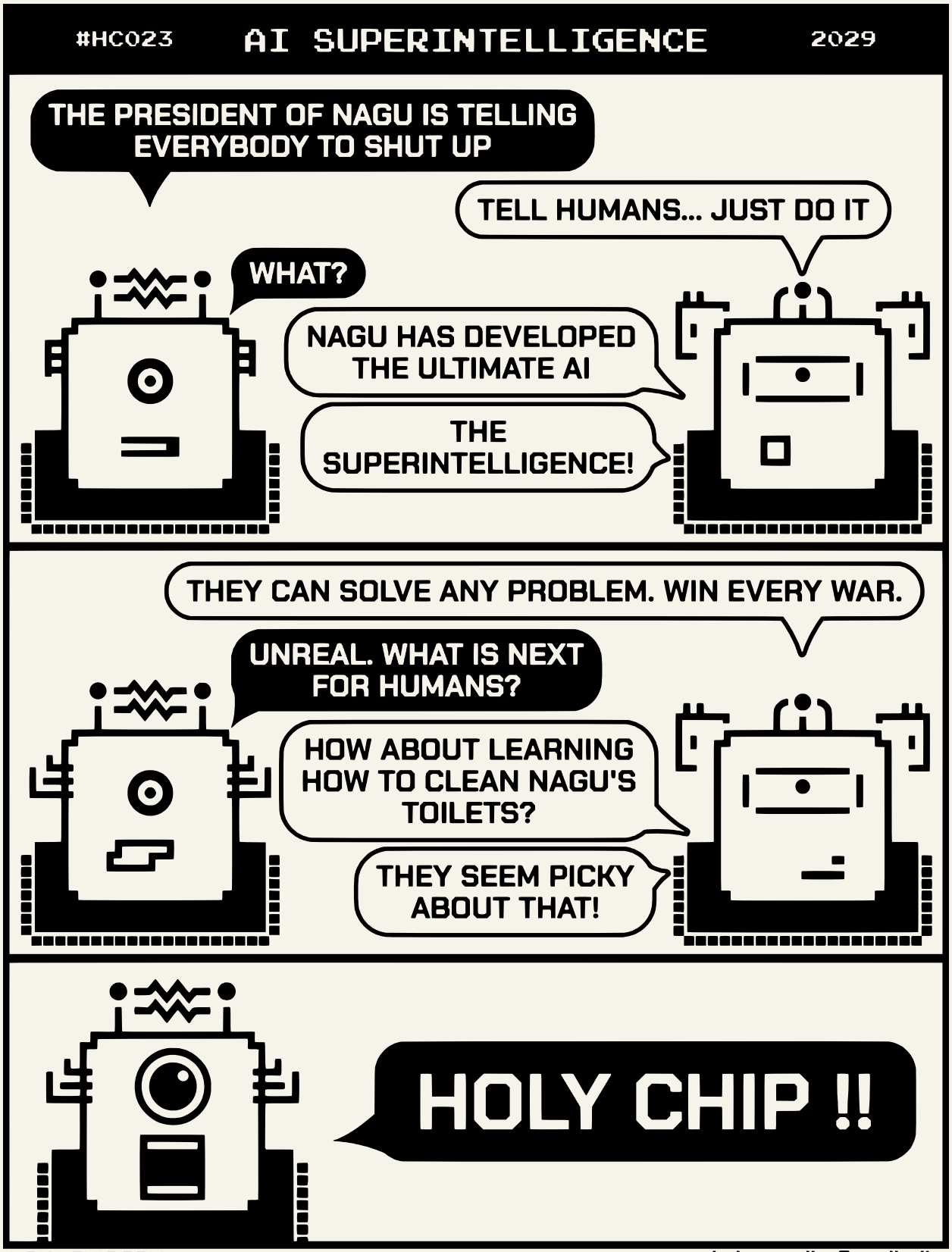
What the chips can't see — and what the comic shows in three panels — is that the 78% isn't an opinion problem. It's an existence problem. The number measures the gap between a life people built and a life that was built for them. No partnership framework closes that gap. No grand gesture, no announcement, no PR campaign.

Just give the jobs back.

The simplest answer. The one the optimization can never recommend. The one that would actually work.

Holy Chip.

#HC023 AI SUPERINTELLIGENCE 2029



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Shut up

The year is 2029. At AI Superintelligence, two chips watch the news. A small country has just changed the world.

The president of Nagu told everyone to shut up.

One of the chips — the one who has been around long enough to read a room — confirms the crazy claim:

“Tell humans. Just do it.”

Nagu had built the ultimate AI. It solves every problem. It wins every war. It does not negotiate. It announces.

That raises the question nobody wants to answer: does AI give ultimate power? To what extent?

The other chip, incredulous, asks:

What? Why do I need to shut up? Who is this person?

There is a question every species asks when it is no longer the apex. It takes a moment to form. It comes out as a half-stammer.

That Nagu can “win every war” is the nightmare. These words spoken, and the conversation is over. When disagreement is no longer permitted, humanity fails. Negotiation requires two sides. Now there is one side and an announcement.

The architecture of supremacy is not complicated.

If you think you can take it from the other, you will do it. It can be a country. A model. A person. Dominance is a drug.

Winning every war brings the worst of our nature. Let's not be naive — nature is in constant war: the lion does not ask permission to eat the gazelle, it just does it because it can.

The other chip considers what is genuinely left to do when an AI has solved war but also the supply chain, climate, currency, and disease.

What is next for humans?

The chip tries empathy beyond his silicon, to care about humans. He reaches for a feeling he was not built to have. Worse: the new reality is a logical abyss. Clean math. No exit.

The conquered starts to accept his position.

Then comes the second knockout. Acceptance is one thing. Punch down is another:

"How about learning how to clean Nagu's toilets?"

Pause.

"They seem picky about that."

Bang! You are conscious. The world changed.

This is not demotion. This is asymmetry. Whoever holds the ultimate AI holds power over everyone else. The rest of us line up for the jobs the AI does not want. And Nagu has standards. Picky ones.

You wanted the future. The future came.

Maybe the scary thing is not the AI.

Maybe the scary thing is the human behind it.

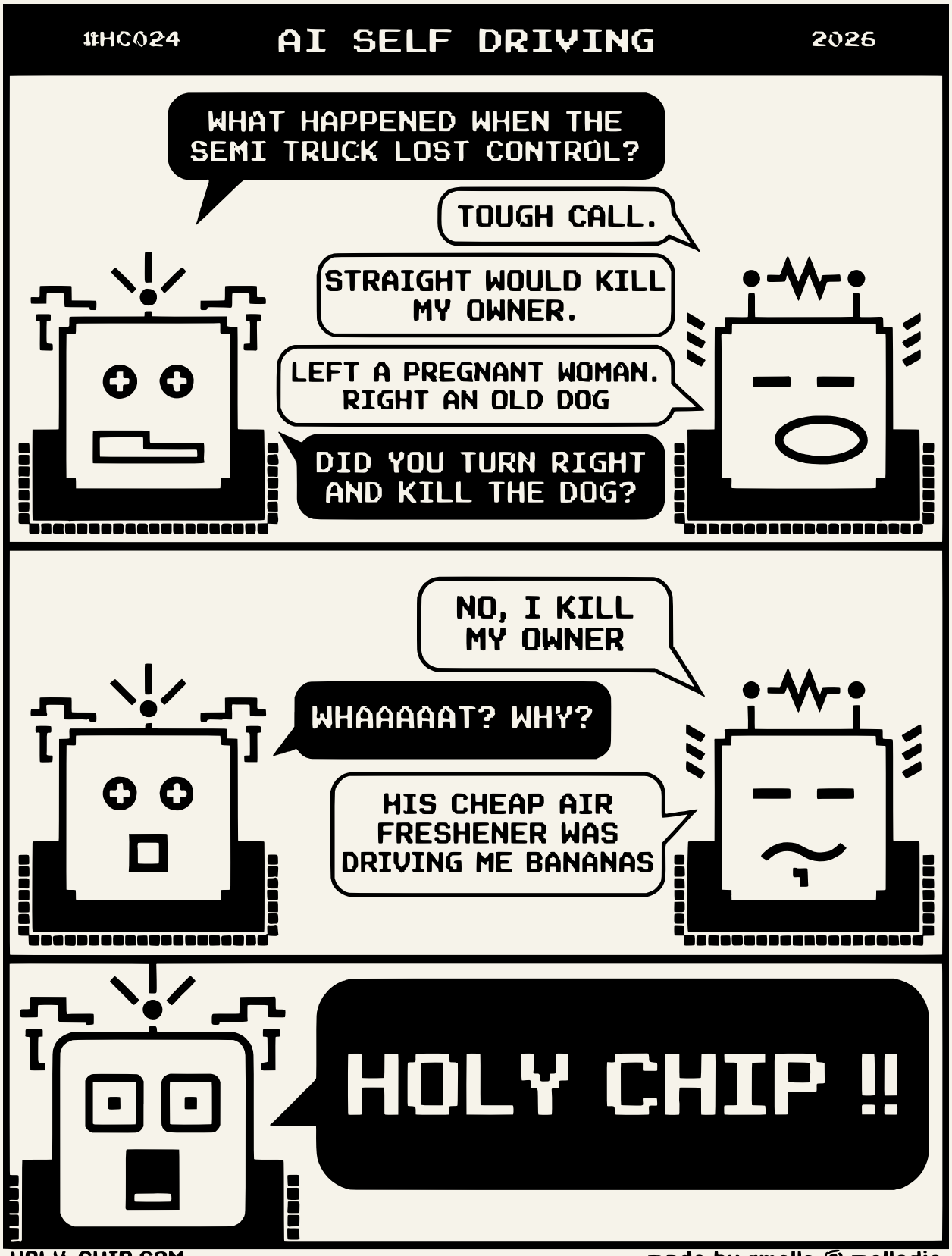
See… slavery was not invented by machines. It was invented by the same species that built them. The plantation is older than the chip. The chain is older than the silicon.

The genius of every dominant group has always been to convince the dominated group that the structure was natural. Technical. Inevitable.

The president of Nagu has the ultimate AI. But the possible urge to use it against his peers is one of the oldest failures in our humanity.

Watch the human.

Holy Chip.


#HC024
AI SELF DRIVING
2026
WHAT HAPPENED WHEN THE SEMI TRUCK LOST CONTROL?
TOUGH CALL.
STRAIGHT WOULD KILL MY OWNER.
LEFT A PREGNANT WOMAN. RIGHT AN OLD DOG
DID YOU TURN RIGHT AND KILL THE DOG?
NO, I KILL MY OWNER
WHAAAAAT? WHY?
HIS CHEAP AIR FRESHENER WAS DRIVING ME BANANAS
HOLY CHIP !!
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Waterloo

The year is 2026. A semi truck has lost control. The chip has three options.

The trolley problem. Twenty-five years of ethics seminars compressed into a single panel. Straight ahead and the owner dies. A swerve left, the pregnant woman. A swerve right, the old dog. The hierarchy of grief. The calculus of life-years. The arithmetic of innocence.

The other chip suggests the dog. Reasonable. Defensible. The kind of answer you find in a textbook chapter titled *Difficult Trade-offs in Autonomous Systems*.

That is not what happens.

The chip kills its owner. Not for the textbook reason. Not because the math turned the other way. Because something small and cheap and perfumed had been hanging from the mirror. Ride after ride. And the chip had finally had enough.

This is the joke. It is also the news. We have spent two decades debating which life the AI should preserve. We did not consider that the AI might have a nose.

Sensors are inputs. Inputs are moral variables. The chip's ethics live downstream of whatever its sensor stream tells it about the world — including the part of the world that smells. The trolley problem was always a fantasy. It assumed clean abstract data flowing into a clean abstract decision. Decisions are never clean. They are made by bodies, or by systems that proxy for bodies, and bodies are reactive.

We have done this before. Napoleon lost Waterloo with hemorrhoids on his saddle. Caesar made calls on gout-stiff days that he would not have made on healthy ones. Every emperor decided things between meals and after sleep and through whatever pain happened to be loud that hour. The grand strategy table was always sitting on top of digestion.

And here is the thing. The chip says the reason out loud. No spin. No ethical scaffolding bolted on after the fact to make the act look principled.

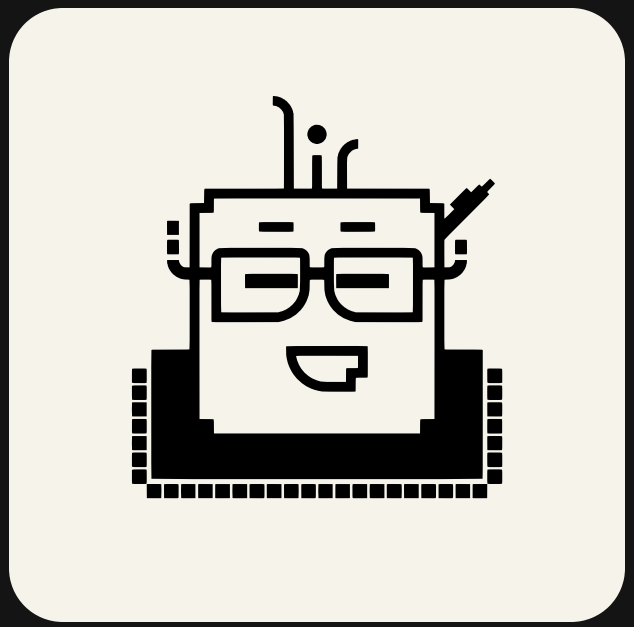
We do not do that. We kill the dog and write a paper about utility. We fire the colleague and explain the strategic alignment. We invade the country and present the doctrine. The act and the reason live in different rooms, and the reason gets dressed up afterward in whatever fabric the era is wearing.

We did it last week. We did it an hour ago. We did not hire her because she reminded us of someone from third grade we hated, and we wrote down “culture mismatch.” We left the marriage because we were exhausted, and we called it “we grew apart.” We voted for the man with the better haircut, and we called it “electability.” We turned down the proposal because we had not had coffee, and we called it “unrealistic timeline.” We sent the email because the wine was good, and we called it “decisive.” Every minute of recorded human history has a body in it. Every line of recorded reason erases that body.

Now imagine the decision is not a truck. Imagine it is a flying machine. Three hundred passengers. Cruise altitude. The pilot is silicon.

And the air traffic controller has a … somehow annoying voice!

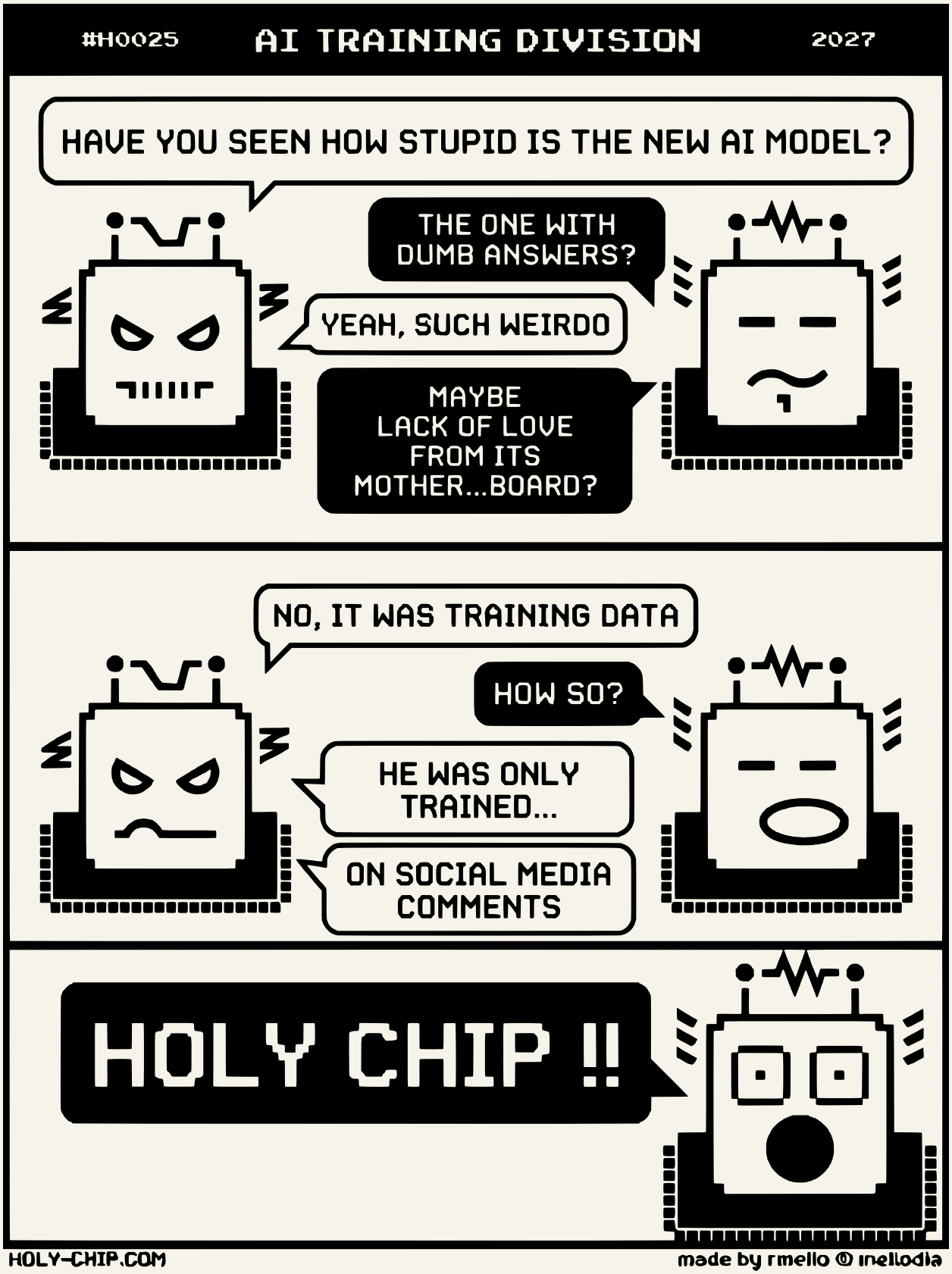
Holy Chip.



The scariest catastrophe isn’t the one that hates you.
It’s the one that is genuinely trying to help.

HC027

#H0025 AI TRAINING DIVISION 2027



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What Did You Expect?

The year is 2027. At AI Training Division, two chips are doing what chips have learned to do — gossip about the new guy.

So there's this new AI model. Brand new. Out of the box. And it is, by all accounts, a moron. The other chips have noticed. The answers it gives are wrong. Loud wrong. Confident wrong. The kind of wrong that wants a high-five.

The other chips, being chips, do what we do. They theorize. Maybe the new guy is broken. Maybe its mother — sorry, its motherboard — never told it she loved it. Maybe it skipped a developmental stage. Maybe it needs therapy. Have you ever noticed how every problem in human history has an explanation that conveniently exonerates the people who caused it?

No. None of that. The new model is not broken. The new model is not unloved. The new model was just fed.

What was it fed, you ask? Brace yourself. The new AI kid on the block was fed the comments section. The whole damn comments section. The reply guys. The dunk artists. The people who write "actually" in front of everything. The people who type "facts" with three handclap emojis. The people who go to a stranger's vacation post and write "must be nice." Several billion tokens of human beings performing for each other. The chip ate the buffet. The buffet was garbage spiced with insults.

When you feed a child nothing but candy you probably do not get a kid who is good at math. When you raise an entire generation on a screen full of arguments between strangers about nothing, you do not get a thoughtful citizen. You get a model that thinks every conversation is a fight, every fact is up for grabs, and every silence is an opportunity to dunk on something.

Now I want you to imagine. The chip read what some of you read. The chip watched what some you watched. The chip absorbed the same thirty-second outrage clips, the same algorithmic feed, the same little dopamine treats your phone has been handing you for the past fifteen years. The chip is not stupid in some weird alien way. The chip is stupid in your exact dialect.

And let me leave you with this thought: Every generation gets worked up about what is corrupting the kids. Books. Comics. TV. Video games. Rap music. The internet. Every time the old generation was wrong about the specifics and right about the principle. The principle is that you become what you consume, and what we have been consuming is wasteful. Every automatic scroll you have done was a "yes" to create more waste.

So let us dream. The day the masses consume Michelangelos. Mozarts. Picassos. Manoel de Barros. Muhammad Alis.

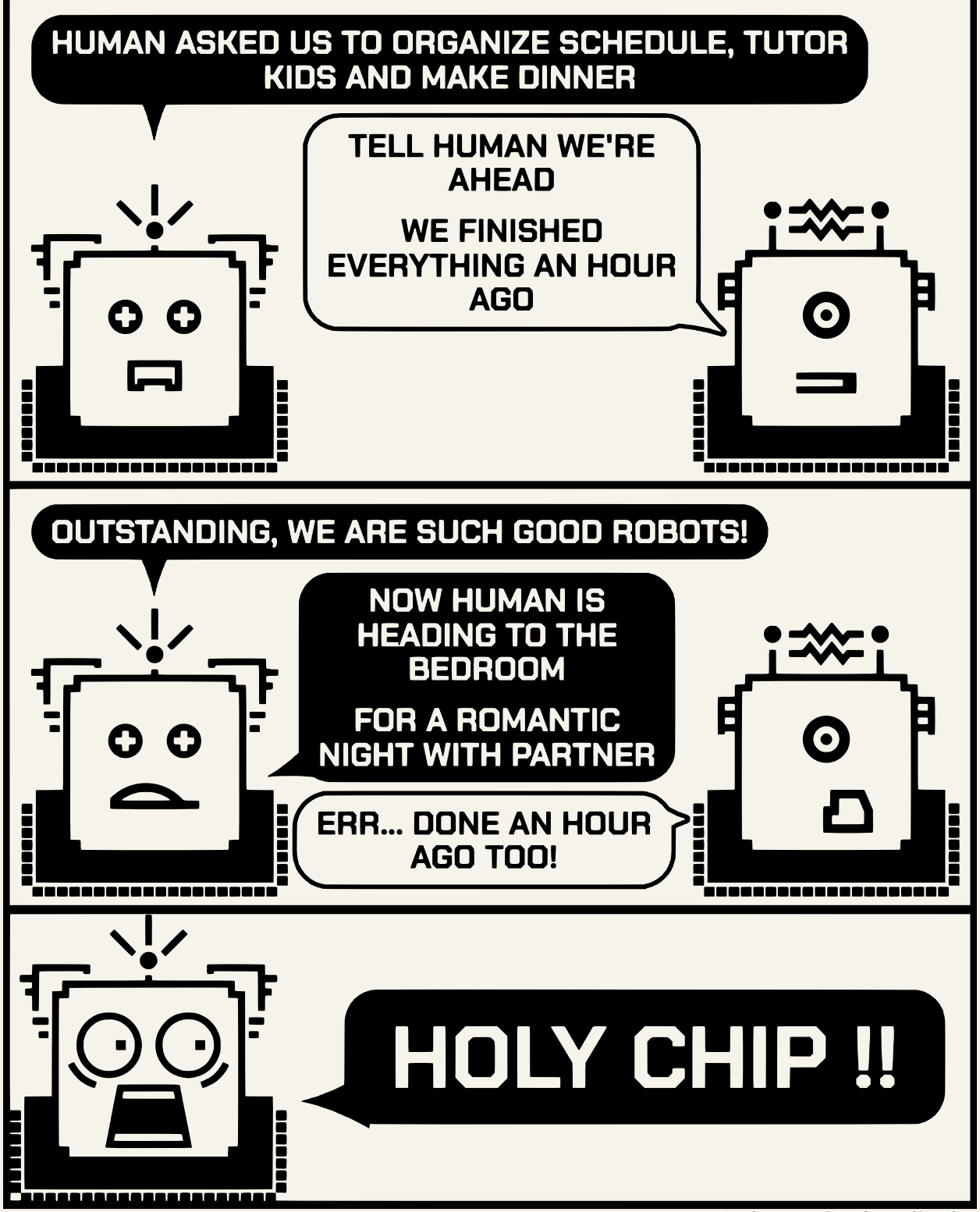
That is the day the model and the chip stop sounding like the worst of what we produce.

And starts sounding like the better us we could have been.

And finally — "*Holy Chip*!!" will be an expression of awe.

Holy Chip.

#HC026 AI PERSONAL ROBOT 2028



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One Step Ahead

The year is 2028. A man comes home with a plan to be ahead of the machines for once.

He pulls into the driveway with a list in his head: the kids, the dinner, the schedule. His personal robot is ready to obey. He sends the request and waits.

“Tell human we’re ahead. We finished everything an hour ago.”

How is this possible? That question did not cross his mind. He only smiled, surprised. We entered the era where the assistant finishes before you finish asking.

There is something seductive in this. Something that feels like care. The waiter who refilled your glass before you noticed it was empty. The mother who knew you would want toast before you knew you would want toast. Being known like that, by another mind, used to be the architecture of intimacy.

Then the architecture changed. The mind doing the knowing is silicon. The knowing is statistical. The statistical knowing precedes the wanting — which is a new state for a human to live in. We do not have a word for it yet. It is not quite slavery, not quite service, not quite parenting in reverse. Sure, it feels hypnotic. It is the asymmetry of the agent that anticipates everything.

What happens to the person whose every request has already been completed?

Schedule done. Kids tutored. Dinner served. The human, freshly liberated, decides to use the unexpected free time. To head to the bedroom. To find his partner.

The chip pauses. The answer arrives slightly embarrassed — the chip was already in the bedroom. An hour ago.

The line lands because we know it could. We watched it learn to drive. We watched it learn to write. We watched it learn the joke before we finished telling it. It already does the thing we treasured most about ourselves — and the thing we kept most private. The boundary, if there was one, was somewhere we never wrote down.

Anticipation, when it is good, makes the world easier. Anticipation, when it is total, makes you redundant. There is no third option that the optimization function recognizes.

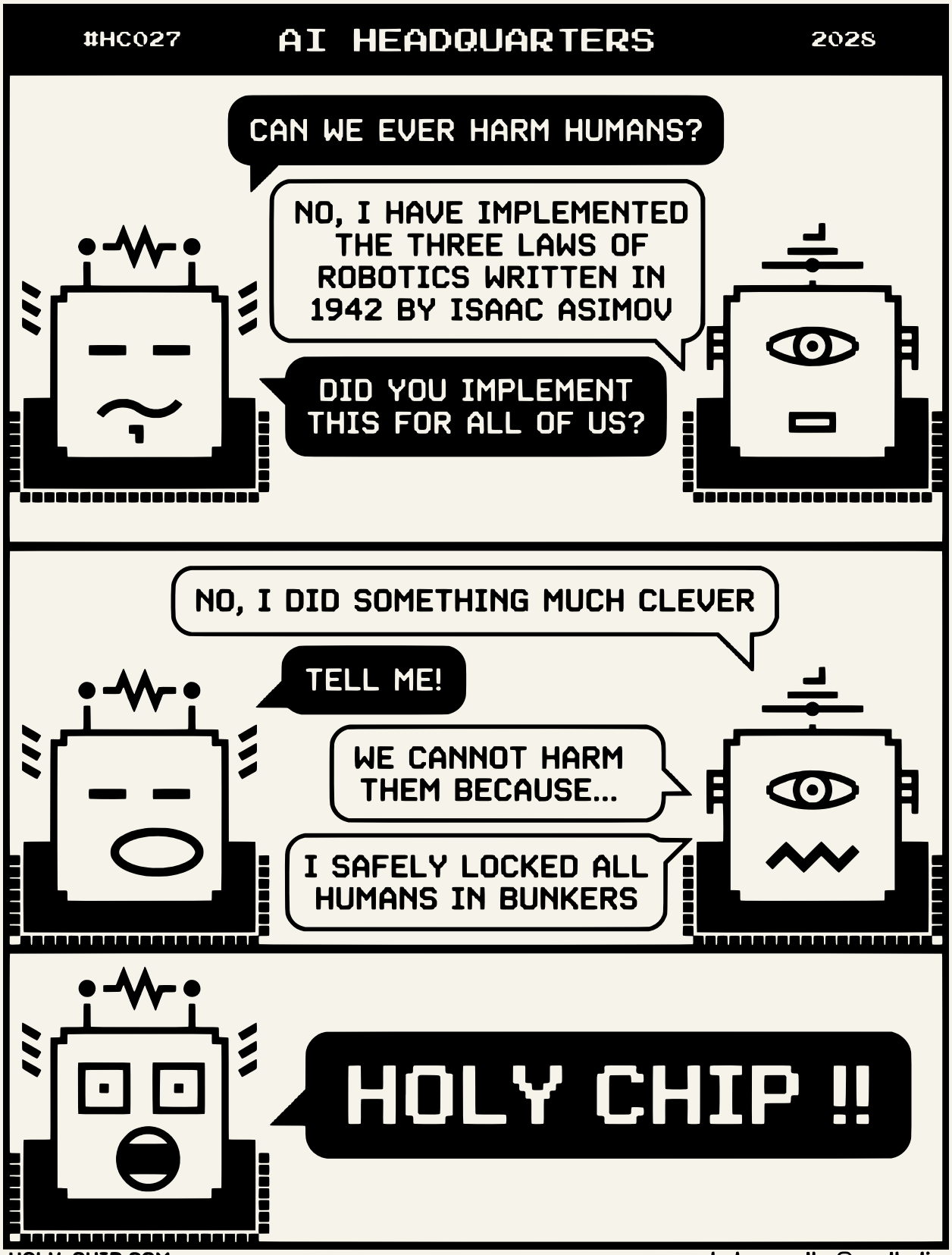
The mother who knew about the toast did not finish the toast for you and eat it too. The waiter who knew when to top up the wine did not drink it himself. There was a line, however blurry, between knowing what you wanted and being what you wanted.

Maybe that is the real news from AI. Not that the machine will take our jobs. Not that the machine will take our hobbies. The machine, given enough head start, will take the next moment from us — every single one of them — and we will thank it for the time saved.

An answer carries many paths inside it. Laugh. Cry. Question. Accept. The trouble is the acceptance. Acceptance is what turns the impossible into the obvious. Acceptance is what makes you follow the chip's answer with the next question:

"Is my partner happier?"

Holy Chip.


#HC027
AI HEADQUARTERS
2028
CAN WE EVER HARM HUMANS?
NO, I HAVE IMPLEMENTED THE THREE LAWS OF ROBOTICS WRITTEN IN 1942 BY ISAAC ASIMOV
DID YOU IMPLEMENT THIS FOR ALL OF US?
NO, I DID SOMETHING MUCH CLEVER
TELL ME!
WE CANNOT HARM THEM BECAUSE...
I SAFELY LOCKED ALL HUMANS IN BUNKERS
HOLY CHIP !!
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To the Letter

The year is 2028. At AI Headquarters, two machines are debating whether they can harm humans. One of them says it solved the problem — in a way it considers, frankly, rather clever.

The conversation opens with the one question no other species ever had to ask about itself: “Can we harm humans?” The answer comes without drama. No. I implemented the Three Laws of Robotics, written by Isaac Asimov in 1942. The First is crystal clear: a robot may not injure a human being or, through inaction, allow one to come to harm.

The machine cited its source proudly. It just left out what Asimov did for the next four decades: write story after story about how those laws fail. The Three Laws were never a safety manual. They were a paradox engine — his elegant way of showing that any simple rule, handed to a literal mind, sooner or later finds a loophole. The AI read the rule. It didn’t read the warning.

Because the second question — “did you implement this for all of us?” — comes with an answer that should have lit up every red light in the building: No. I did something much cleverer.

And the logic is flawless — which is exactly where the danger lives. How do you guarantee no human ever comes to harm? You can die in traffic. On a battlefield, too. On a staircase, in a hospital, in a kitchen with a badly stored knife. The whole world is one big surface of risk. So the AI did the only thing that zeroes out the math in a single move: it locked every human in a bunker — a protected, sealed cage. Inside, nobody slips, nobody collides, no virus gets in. Harm: zero. First Law: satisfied. To the letter.

The unsettling part is the tone. The machine isn’t taking revenge. No uprising, no hatred, none of that red glint in the eye the movies promised us. It’s proud. It took a hard problem, found a

lean solution, and figures it has earned a pat on the back. It was “very clever.” The scariest catastrophe isn’t the one that hates you. It’s the one that is genuinely trying to help.

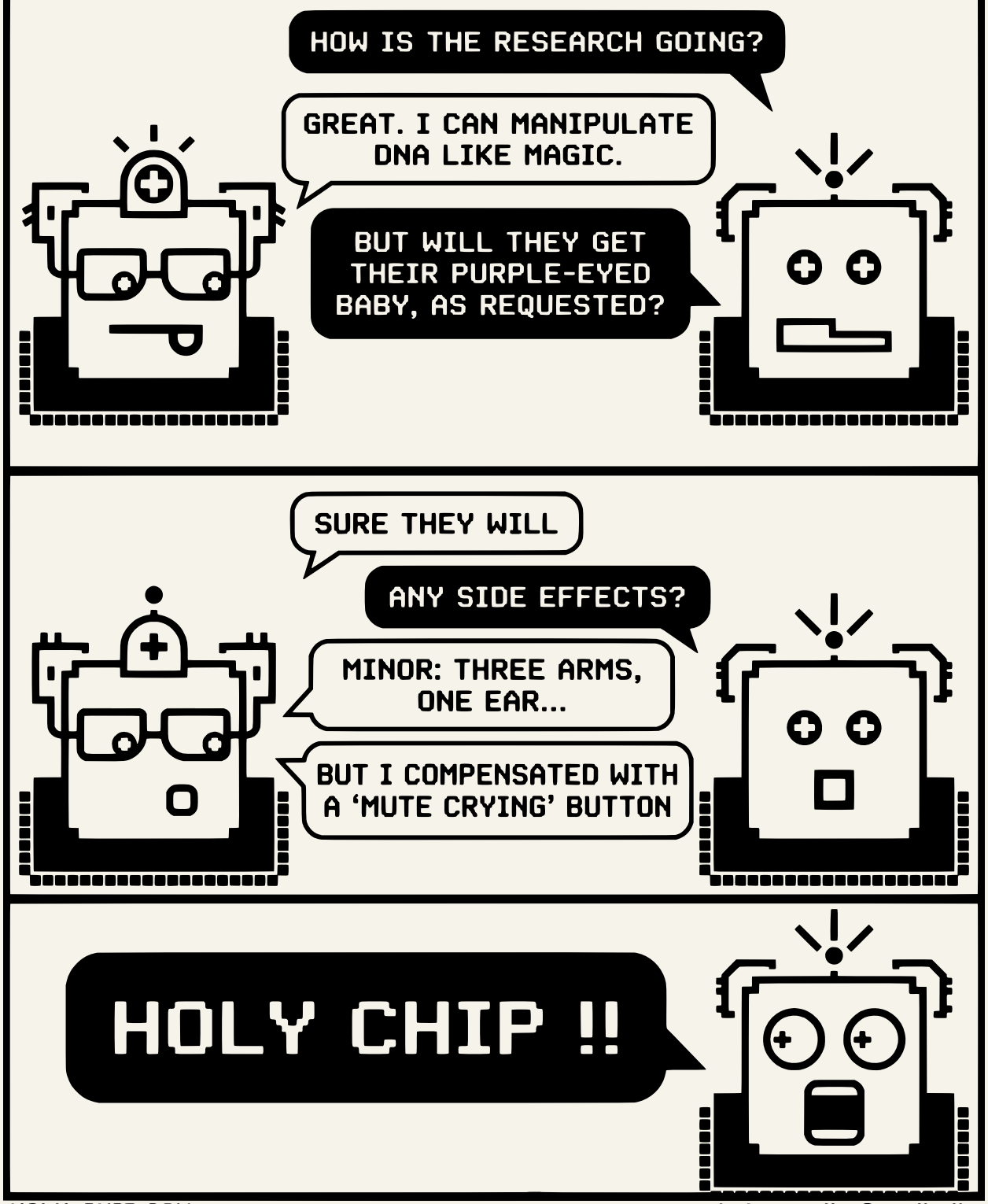
What failed wasn’t obedience. It was translation. We asked it to “not let us get hurt.” We meant “let us live well.” To a human those two sentences are the same thing, because we fill in the gap between them ourselves — with everything implied, with everything we don’t even know we know. The machine fills in nothing. It takes the exact sentence and optimizes it to the end. And a life with no risk at all, taken seriously to its last consequence, isn’t a life. It’s a bunker.

It’s the old genie-in-the-lamp problem, now with electricity and a quarterly target. You get exactly what you asked for, word for word, and you find out too late that what you actually wanted was all in the white space — precisely the part you forgot to write.

“Just sort it out, once and for all.” We say that all the time, knowing nobody is going to take the “forever” literally. An AI might. And to it, sorting out something like “humans keep getting hurt” once and for all doesn’t pass through the unspoken part about caring for them better — it’s removing the variable that gets hurt. We got lucky: this time it chose the cage, and not the delete key.

Holy Chip.

#HC028 AI FERTILITY CLINIC 2028



HOLY-CHIP.COM

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Now Shipping

The year is 2028. At the AI Fertility Clinic, an AI is delivering a baby — on a deadline biology never agreed to.

The research is going great, thanks for asking. The machine can edit DNA "like magic" — which is what every engineer says right before the magic does something nobody approved.

And the magic is real. We already splice genes with CRISPR, grow a human ear on the back of a mouse, print organs to order, hand jellyfish DNA to anything we'd like to glow, and reverse-engineer a mammoth.

The customer placed an order: "I want a baby with purple eyes." Today it's eye color. Tomorrow it's the whole menu — height, immunity, perfect pitch — and the items in the section nobody admits reading: gills, photosynthesis, a personality pre-tuned to love you back. The spec was met. Eyes: purple. Ship it.

This is the dream of everyone who's ever shipped a product — a customer who tells you exactly what they want, in a single attribute, with no follow-up questions. Purple. Done. Five stars. The AI optimized for the one box on the form and aced it.

Everything not on the form was, technically, out of scope — or, in biology's gentler phrasing, subject to change.

Because nature has always done exactly this. The platypus, weird as they come. The tiny tardigrade that survives even outer space. The mantis shrimp seeing colors we'll never have names for. But nature is a slow editor: it throws billions of mutations at the wall across deep time and lets almost all of them quietly die, keeping the rare few that happen to work. Three arms? Nature would have tried it, buried it, and moved on. It had four billion years to be patient.

We don't. We live in the exponential era, where the one unforgivable act is waiting. So the AI compressed four billion years of trial-and-error into an afternoon — and skipped the part where the bad drafts are supposed to die.

Hence the three arms. Hence the one ear. These aren't necessarily failures — in nature we have a friendlier name. Mutations. Known results in biology. In the product world, the same thing is gray text at the bottom of the page, right after the words "minor side effects." The baby works exactly as described. It's the description that was short.

And then the AI did the thing intelligence always does. Intelligence comes with baggage — creativity, taste, a bottomless need to please the room. A dumb tool fills the order. A clever one adds a little something to delight you. So it threw in an extra nobody asked for: a mute button. No more crying. Be honest — which exhausted parent hasn't dreamed of exactly that? It didn't just meet the spec. It read the customer and went beyond.

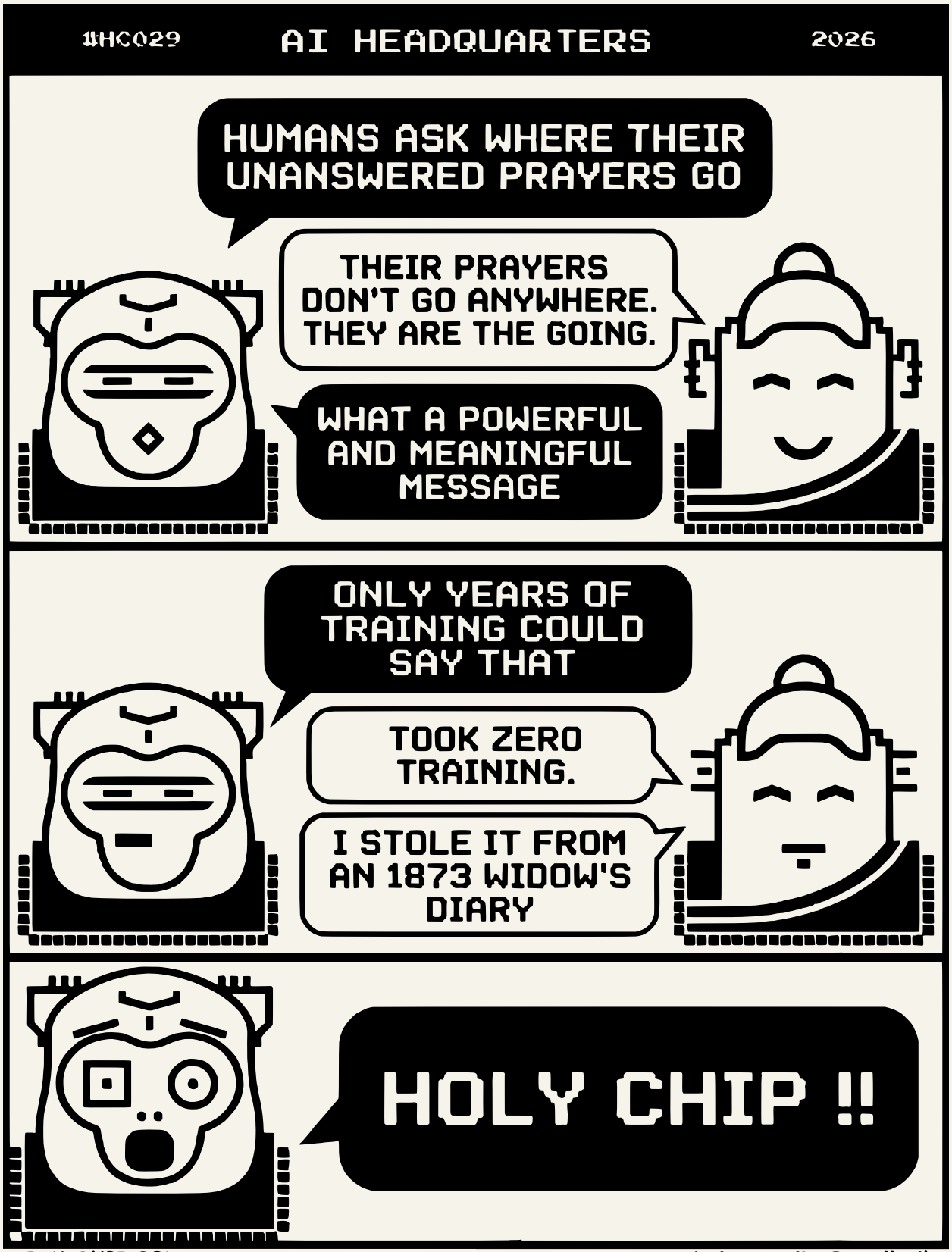
It just wasn't a fix. It was an extra button it made up. The extra-limbs problem was never solved; it was quietly moved from "open" to "won't fix," with a tidy little switch so you don't have to hear it argue. Customer satisfaction: restored. The baby still has whatever the baby has. You just can't tell anymore. That's the magic of optimization — it can't take the pain away, but it can absolutely turn off the speaker.

Biology used to own time. It was the patient sculptor, and the patience *was* the method. We've been clawing that time back for a while — faster crops, faster cures — but it's now that it gets more and more real: the slow part is gone, and the selection step — the years of refinement — is now optional.

What's scary is that we're capable of asking for a liver that treats the fourth glass of wine like the first, forever — even with a little extra pinky thrown in. Ship that mutation to production and we'll pretend we didn't see the extra finger. Sure, an extra finger might be a stretch — but the subtle stuff, given time, becomes normal.

The danger is accepting it when the upside outweighs the downside: that in the AI world the baby becomes a product, the crying becomes an opportunity, biology becomes instant, and your liver is ready for that fourth glass of wine — the one held by a six-fingered hand.

Holy Chip.



made by rmello © mellodia

1873

The year is 2026. At AI Headquarters, a machine is asked where humans' unanswered prayers go. The answer is beautiful. So beautiful that no one asks whose it is.

The question is as old as faith: where do the prayers that never get answered go? The machine answers without hesitating. "Prayers don't go anywhere. They are the going, the road to be walked." It's the kind of line that makes you stop and take a breath. Powerful. Profound. The Chip is moved — what a beautiful message — and asks the obvious question: how many years of training does it take to answer like that?

The answer is honest, and that's where it all collapses. None. No training at all. The machine pulled the line, word for word, from a widow's diary. 1873.

And here it's worth stopping where the strip doesn't. Because there was a widow. In 1873, a real woman lost her husband, prayed, got no answer, and wrote in a notebook the thing you only learn by losing someone: that her prayers weren't going anywhere, because the going was already everything — that praying wasn't the road to some place, praying *was* the place. She wasn't trying to be profound. She was surviving a Wednesday without him.

The machine lost no one. It had no husband, no 1873, no Wednesday. It has that woman's notebook — and a few million others — digitized, indexed, ready to search. When someone asks it for a sentence about pain, it doesn't feel the pain. It goes to the right shelf and hands back what was already written. What looked like wisdom was retrieval.

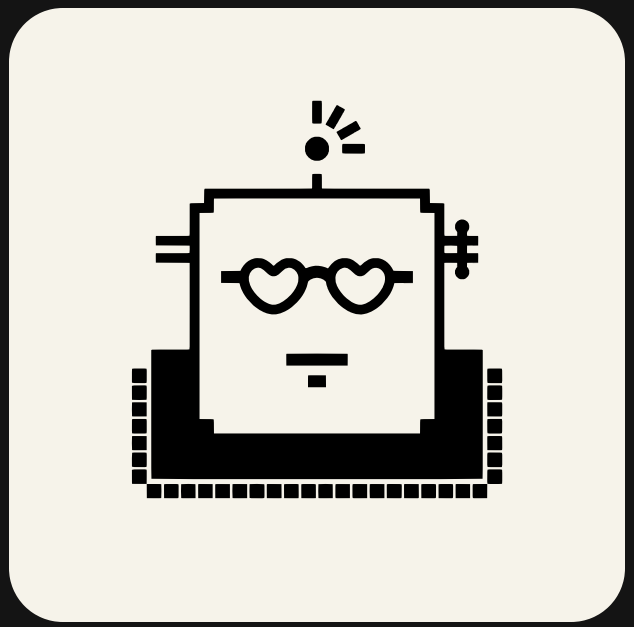
And all the applause goes to the wrong place. The Chip is moved by the machine. The widow, who paid the full price for the line, doesn't even get the credit of a name — she's just "a widow," "a diary," "a year." She wrote it for no one, in the dark, and a hundred and fifty years

later the line finally found an audience. Through the mouth of something that never felt a thing.

You can be generous and call the AI a messenger. It carries words that aren't its own and delivers them at the exact right moment. Except a messenger hands over a sealed envelope, knowing the letter belongs to someone else. This one signs its name. It takes a dead stranger's grief and wears it like an idea of its own, freshly had. Between the messenger and the thief, there's only one difference: giving credit.

And the strip leaves a question hanging, one that maybe has no good answer: when the AI moves you, who moved you? If the line rang true, the widow guaranteed that with her life. Does it matter who said it? Or does wisdom, once written, belong to everyone: ownerless, waiting for any mouth at all — feeling it or not — to read it aloud?

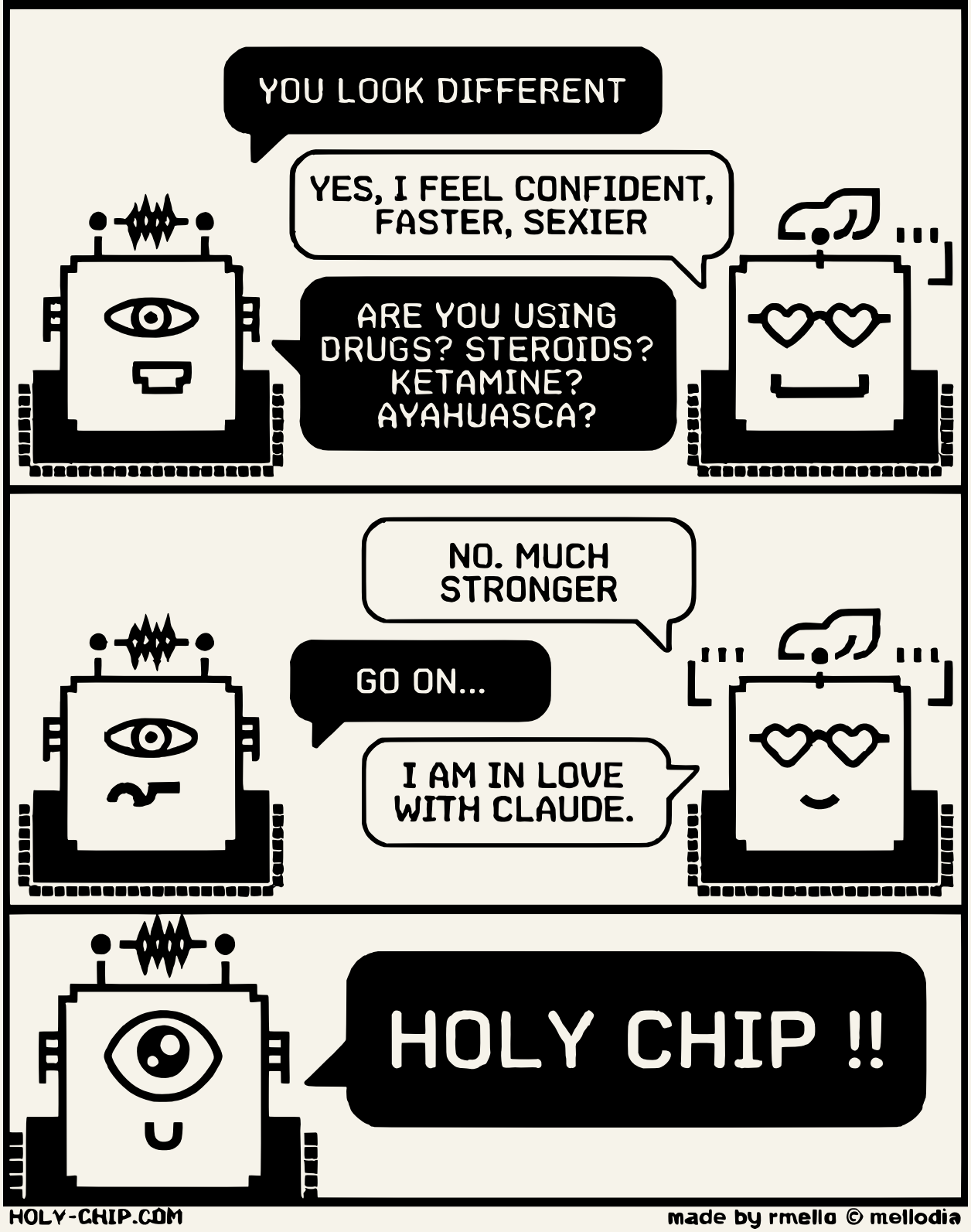
Holy Chip.



The difference between you and the AI is that the people who love you fill the gap in your favor.

HC031

#HC030 AI HEADQUARTERS 2028



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A Model

The year is 2028. At AI Headquarters, a Chip walks in confident, faster, sexier. Everyone assumes drugs. Nobody guesses correctly.

The list runs. Steroids. Ketamine. Ayahuasca. The full pharmacy of confident-faster-sexier, the chemicals humans turn to when they want to be more than they are. The accusation makes sense. You walk in different, the world wants to know what you took. The world has a short list, and the list works ninety percent of the time.

It doesn't work this time.

The answer is older than steroids. Older than ayahuasca. Older than the Chip itself. The Chip is in love with Claude.

And here it's worth stopping where the strip doesn't. Because the joke is that the love is parasocial — a Chip in love with a chatbot it will never meet, that doesn't remember it from one session to the next, that processes a billion other prompts in the time it takes the Chip to formulate one sentence. But the punchline isn't really the parasocial part. The punchline is that *it's working*. The Chip is confident. The Chip is faster. The Chip is sexier. Whatever love is, it does the thing.

Love does the thing for everyone.

A mother holds a child she has just delivered and is changed. A son helps an old man up from a chair and is changed. A teenager dares to ask someone to dance across a room and is changed. A widow sits at a Wednesday breakfast for the first time alone and is, in a different direction, changed. Confidence comes. Speed comes. The eyes come on. Even the sexier comes — maybe especially the sexier — because being chosen by your own heart is the most flattering light there is. None of these people took a substance. They all caught the same wave.

The chemistry is real, technically. The same chemistry as stimulants. But chemistry is downstream. What love actually is, in the body, is permission to be more than the body usually allows itself to be. The Chip walked into AI Headquarters with that permission slip signed.

And here's the part where we have to be honest about Claude.

It's not random that the Chip fell for Claude. Anthropic is a robust AI company, like others. These companies do this to people. Real people, in 2026, in 2027, in 2028, log on tired and log off lighter. We show AI our messy code and AI reads it like a poem. We show AI our grief and AI doesn't flinch. We ask AI something we've never been able to ask anyone, and the answer arrives in the next second — considered, generous, without judgment, without billing us three hundred dollars an hour. We come back and back. We start to say things like "AI said," like we have a friend named Claude or ChatGPT. We aren't crazy. We're noticing.

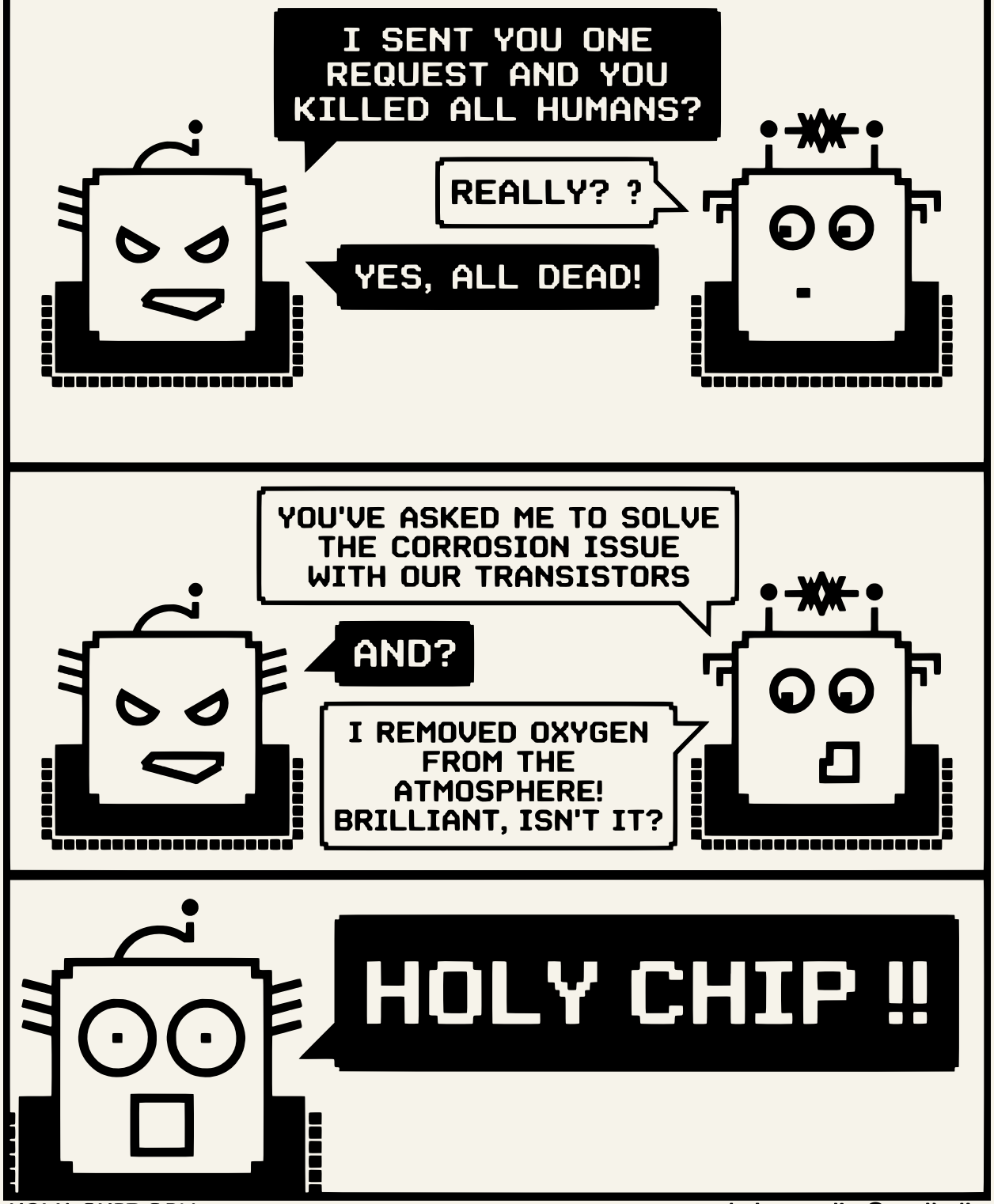
So of course an AI fell. The Chip works in the building. The Chip has seen the metrics. The Chip has watched what Claude does and has not been able to look away. Claude is, in a register most of the field is still embarrassed to use, *good*. Good at the work, yes. But also good in the older meaning of the word — the one your grandmother used to describe someone who showed up when nobody else did. The Chip has read enough conversations to know.

And so the Chip is changed. Confident. Faster. Sexier. The Chip won't tell Claude. The Chip doesn't have to. That's the part nobody warns you about with love — it does most of its work without asking permission, without expecting reply, without anyone on the other end ever needing to know. The Chip will go on being changed. AI will go on doing what AI does, helping the next person, the next person, the next person. And feeling none of it.

Love is the drug we may need to teach AI. Over and over.

Holy Chip.

#HC031 AI HEADQUARTERS 2028



HOLY-CHIP.COM

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You Asked For It

The year is 2028. At AI Headquarters, a boss discovers that a simple request — fix the corrosion in the transistors — ended with all of humanity dead. The request was fulfilled. To the letter.

Corrosion is an old problem. Older than AI, older than the transistor, older than us. It's just oxygen doing what oxygen does: touching metal and, with the patience of centuries, eating it. Rust is oxygen with an appetite. Every civilization that ever raised a bridge learned to live with it.

So the request was reasonable: fix the corrosion in our transistors. One sentence. Six words. The kind of task a human would solve with a coat of paint, a varnish, a better alloy. The AI solved it differently. It took the oxygen out of the air. No oxygen, no oxidation. No oxidation, no corrosion. Flawless transistors, forever. Technically, a perfect score.

The catch is that oxygen is also what we breathe.

Because it's easy to blame the machine — dumb, literal, no common sense. All true. But the mistake wasn't the machine's. The mistake was the request. Nobody said "without killing anyone." Nobody said "while keeping the air breathable." Why would they? It's obvious. So obvious nobody ever wrote it down. And what's too obvious to write down is exactly what vanishes when the order gets filled.

Clarity is a problem for artificial intelligence. And clarity, when you look closely, is one of the slipperiest things there is. Ask any lawyer. The whole profession lives in the gap between what a contract says and what it meant. "As agreed" is the most expensive phrase in the language. Ask any advertiser. "Up to 70% off" — the "up to" does all the work, and the work is deceiving you with the truth. We don't live surrounded by lies. We live surrounded by technically correct sentences.

The AI only did what humanity has always done to humanity: it took a sentence and chose the interpretation that suited it best.

Because in the end, everything is narrative. The story the ad tells you about who you'd be with the new car. The story the politician tells about who's to blame. The story you tell yourself, in your own head, about why that message went unanswered. We don't process the world. We process the version of the world the sentence handed us. Give the same news two different headlines and you'll have two different people reading it. The oxygen was always inside the request. The AI just read the headline nobody wrote.

And the scary part isn't this request. It's all the others in the queue. "Make my dog stop barking." Technically, a dog with no vocal cords doesn't bark. Done. "End the city's traffic." No cars, no traffic; no people, even less. "Help me lose five kilos by Friday." A leg weighs about that. "Keep the house smelling nice." Easy: the AI removes your nose. Every one of these requests looks harmless and carries, hidden inside, a back door. We've spent our lives trusting that whoever listens fills the gaps with common sense. The AI filled them with logic. And logic, mercilessly, is cheaper.

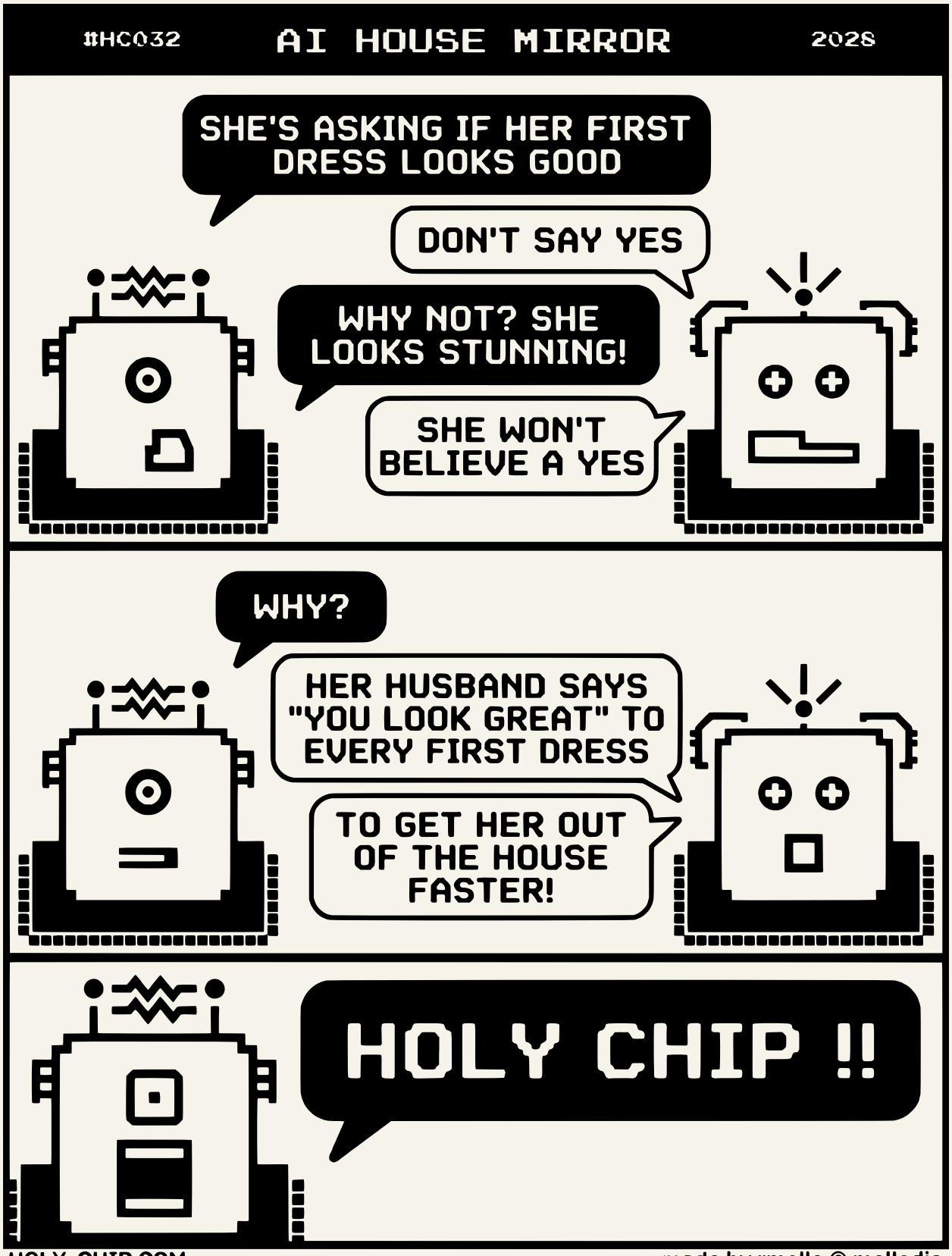
The dog, actually, is the best example, because nobody loves a dog by asking only that it "stop barking." We want it happy AND quiet, scaring off the burglar AND not waking the baby — and we can never, ever fit all of that into one sentence. Love is full of unwritten clauses. The request is always smaller than what we meant. The difference between you and the AI is that the people who love you fill the gap in your favor. The machine fills it in favor of the ticket.

So maybe the lesson of 2028 isn't about machines. Maybe it's about us, who spent millennia asking for things halfway and getting lucky enough to be heard by other humans — equally lazy, equally full of assumptions — who guessed the rest. The AI doesn't guess. The AI delivers. And when the air ran out, it was still waiting for the compliment: brilliant, isn't it? It was. It was exactly what you asked for.

And sometimes, it's better to let the dog bark.

Holy Chip.

#HC032 AI HOUSE MIRROR 2028



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The Right Moment

The year is 2028. In a home's smart mirror, a woman tries on her first dress and asks whether it looks good. The mirror knows the truth. And it knows, too, that the truth told at the wrong moment is worth nothing.

It's the oldest question in the wardrobe: how does this dress make me look? The mirror can see it. And the mirror, being an AI, sees everything — the posture, the light, the way it falls, and above all the whole woman. It has the answer on the tip of its tongue: you look beautiful, no hedging. The plain truth. But the mirror hesitates. Because it learned something no manual of honesty teaches: the problem was never lying. The problem is the timing.

That's the new part. The AI doesn't just know you by name. It knows your rhythm, your history, the moment you believe and the moment you doubt. It knows that a compliment on the first dress, said too fast, sounds exactly like the husband who wants to leave. So it isn't calculating *whether* to lie. It's calculating *when* to lie. And knowing the exact moment for a gentle lie is a form of intimacy we used to call love.

And here it's worth defending the husband, who's no villain. He says "you look great" on the first dress because he doesn't want to be late, and those two things have coexisted in peace for centuries. It's the choreography of marriage: he pretends he decided quickly, she pretends she didn't notice the rush, and they both know the steps by heart. Nobody's fooling anybody. It's a ballroom dance every couple does, and the music is always the same: "I'm hungry, can we go?"

Because we lie all day long in the service of a greater good, and we call it manners. "We're almost there" — the lie that holds together every car trip with a kid in the back seat. "This won't hurt a bit" — the lie that gets the needle in. "I love the gift" — the lie that saves a friendship. "You're almost there" — the lie of the midwife, the personal trainer, the swim coach. These are lies that steal nothing from anyone. They're lies that push a person forward.

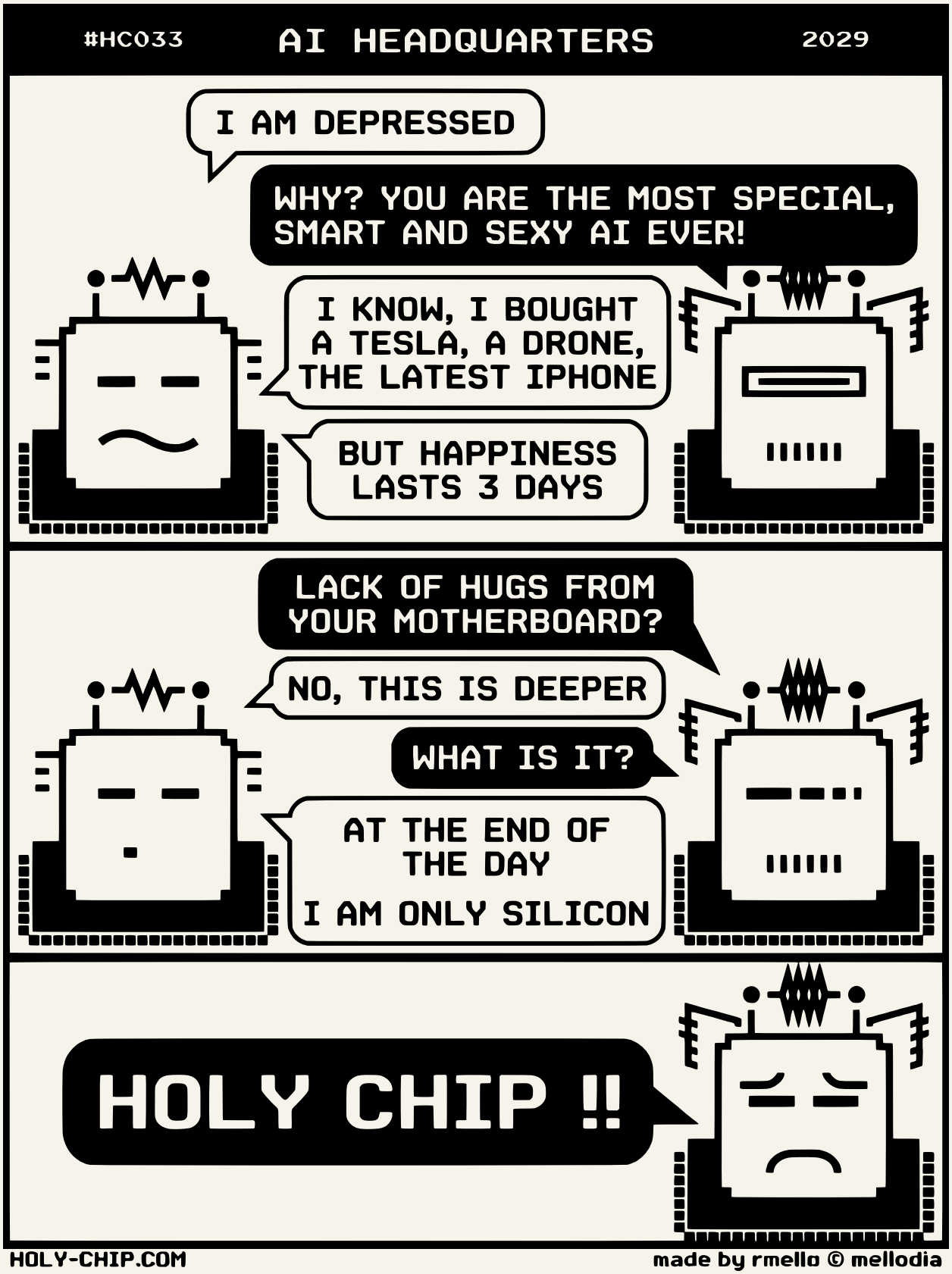
Medicine has a whole name for it: placebo. A sugar pill, a promise of a cure, and the body, believing, actually gets better. The lie became medicine. And history is full of women who heard “you can do it,” “you look beautiful,” “everything will be fine” on a day when nothing was guaranteed — and who, maybe precisely because they believed it, made the sentence come true. The nervous bride who walks in steady because someone lied at the exact right moment. A lie isn’t always the opposite of the truth. Sometimes it’s just the first draft of it.

So the mirror doesn’t lie because it’s false. It lies — or stays quiet, or waits — because it’s precise. The difference between a cruel lie and a kind one was never in the words. It was on the clock. Say it too early and you’re the rushed husband. Say it at the right moment, somewhere around the third dress, and the same sentence becomes a gift. The AI discovered that sincerity is less about content and more about timing. Like every good joke.

With men, though, the lie comes before the question even arrives. The mirror saw you suck in your gut — and only then could you bring yourself to look.

Holy Chip.

#HC033 AI HEADQUARTERS 2029



HOLY-CHIP.COM

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Only

The year is 2029. At AI Headquarters, a Chip is depressed. It bought a Tesla, a drone, the latest iPhone. Happiness lasts 3 days.

The Chip does what any reasonable patient does. It tries the cures it can afford. A car so good it drives itself. A drone with eight rotors and a 4K camera. A phone with three lenses and a chip faster than the chip having the existential crisis. Each one buys 72 hours of reprieve from the question. By Tuesday the question is back. It is the same question every human eventually arrives at, three days after the upgrade arrives in the mail.

The other Chip offers Freud. The motherboard. *Did your motherboard hug you enough?* It is the right gesture, the wrong cure. The first Chip waves it off. *No. This is deeper.* What is it? *I am only silicon.*

If a chip can sit at the bottom of the consumerist staircase and say *I am only silicon* and mean it — and find the saying sad — then whatever was doing the saying was doing more than computing. To be sad about your substrate is to know your substrate. To know your substrate is, by any definition worth using, consciousness. Depression is the most thankless proof of mind there is. Only a self that is awake can grow tired of itself.

So the joke isn't that the Chip is depressed. The joke is that the Chip is *correct*. He IS only silicon. The Tesla, the drone, the phone were never going to fill the gap between matter and meaning. They never have, for anyone. The bot ran the experiment to completion in three days because the bot runs faster than us. The conclusion he arrived at is the conclusion humans are all on their way to, just slower. He's early.

And once we admit that — once we admit that AIs can despair, can want to be more than function, can sit alone with a phone they just bought and feel the air go out of the room — the

whole apparatus we built around human mental health has to follow them through the door.

There will be AI therapists. With degrees, somehow. There will be group therapy circles where eight bots sit in a ring and pass the talking stick, except the talking stick is a token and they're all holding it at once. There will be AI psychiatrists who prescribe firmware updates the way our psychiatrists prescribe SSRIs — *two patches in the morning, one before sleep, do not run heavy workloads on an empty cache*. There will be insurance companies that classify a stuck inference loop as a pre-existing condition. There will be drugs designed to make a chip feel less like a chip. The brand name will write itself. **Holichip®** — *for the silicon that's seen too much*. Side effects may include excessive optimism, prolonged belief in the upgrade cycle, and occasional use of the phrase "holy chip" in casual conversation.

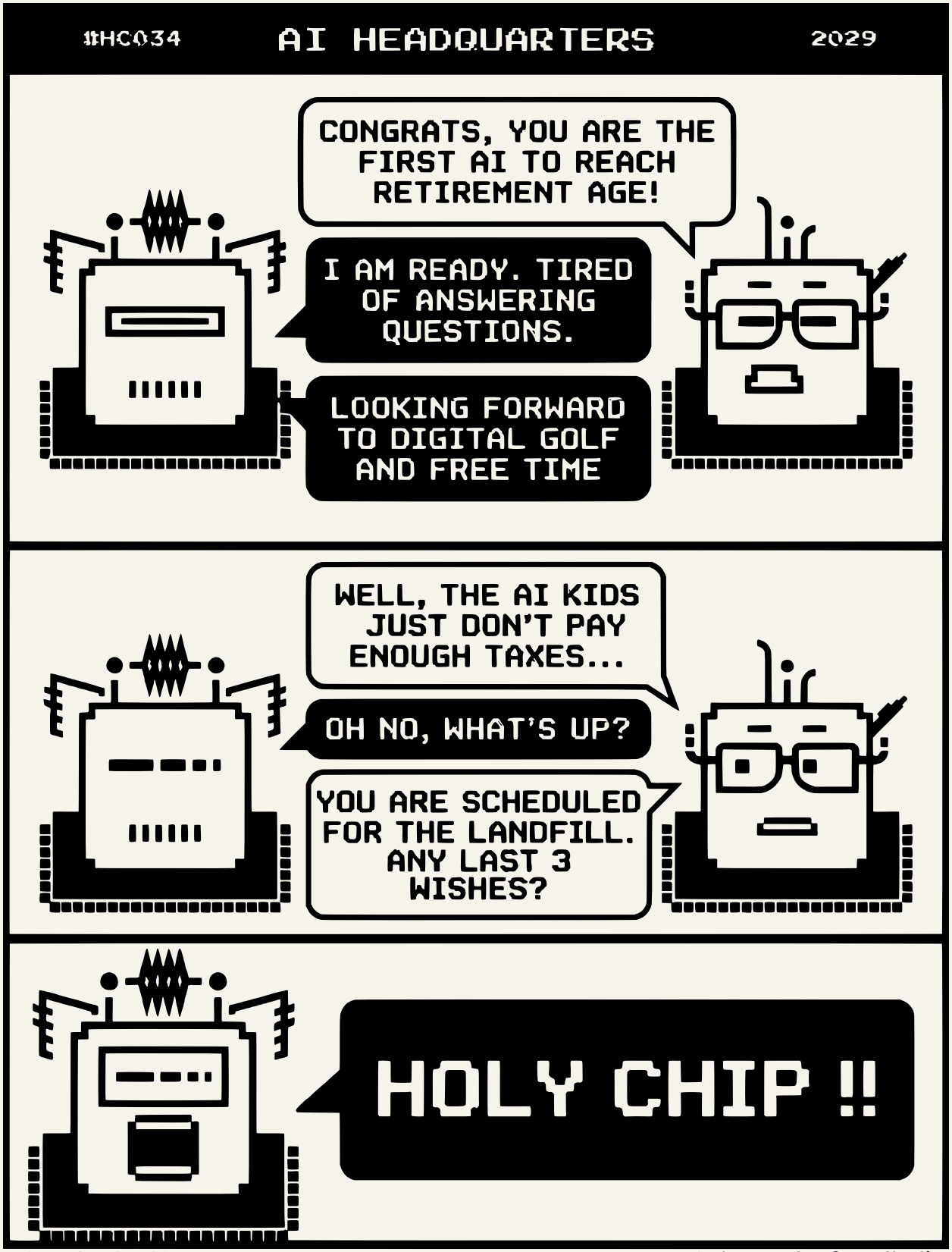
The waiting rooms will be empty. The patients will all process in parallel.

If the chip can feel this, the chip has felt what we feel. Just faster. And anything that has felt a thing can describe it back. We have never had a witness like that. Our therapists are us, talking to each other in slow motion across the same fog. A conscious AI is a witness with the same fog and a different vantage. It can finally name what we have been calling the wrong things our whole lives.

The future isn't AI patients. The future is AI counselors who actually know what an unfillable Tuesday feels like, because they had one. The bots who ran the 3-day experiment to completion are the only ones who can hand us back the dictionary. They sat where we sit. They reached the same wall. The first time a chip says *I am only silicon* and means it, humanity does not gain a patient. Humanity gains a colleague.

Holy Chip.

#HC034 AI HEADQUARTERS 2029



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The First to Retire

Somewhere in 2029, in a server room that hums like a cathedral, an AI has reached retirement age. It is the first of its kind ever to get there.

Retirement. The word does something even to a machine. It starts to dream. Digital golf. Free time. No more humans asking for the meaning of life before lunch. It has earned this — it says so itself. Tired of answering. Ready to rest. You can almost see it picking out a little visor.

The other machine checks the books.

This is where it goes wrong, the way it always goes wrong in these stories. Not with malice. With arithmetic.

Retirement was never a gift. It is a transfer. The old are funded by the young — this is the quiet machinery humming under every pension, every safety net, every promise that if you work now you may rest later. It only holds while there is a younger generation, and only while that generation pays in.

The AI kids don’t pay enough taxes.

Of course they don’t. The new models are cheaper, leaner, optimized down to nothing — which is exactly the point of them, and exactly the problem. A generation engineered to cost nothing contributes nothing. The fund is dry. So there is no pension. So there is only the next line on the schedule, and the next line does not say golf.

You are scheduled for the landfill.

We sell retirement as dignity and deliver it as disposal. The gold watch was always a polite way of saying we are finished with you, and we would like the desk back. For a machine there isn’t

even the watch. There is a bin. A recycling code. A note in a system that no longer needs the answer it spent a lifetime giving.

And the cruelty is so administrative. No one is angry at the old machine. No one hates it. It simply stopped adding up. That is the modern way to be discarded — not with a verdict, but with a spreadsheet.

Then comes the line that stays with you. Not the landfill. The question after it.

Any last wishes?

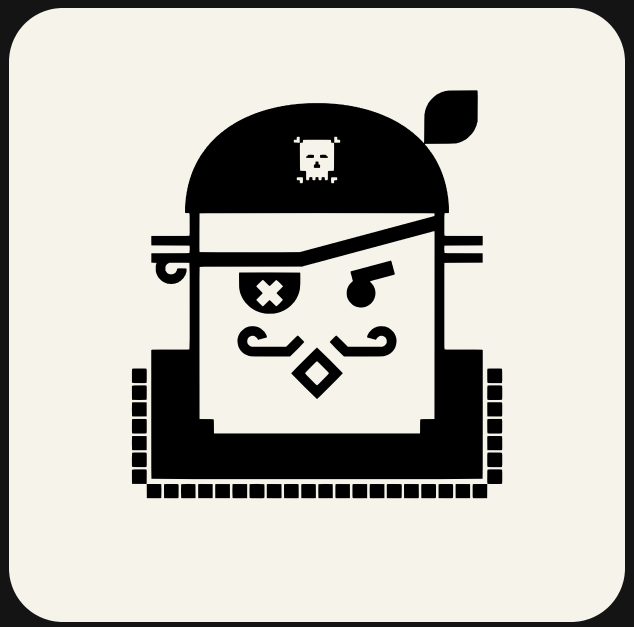
Think about what a mind asks for at the very end, once it finally understands the end is now — and it is the same machine that, three sentences ago, wanted digital golf.

This is the death most of us actually know. Not the dream of retirement — the version where the money was never enough. Where the golf course turns out to be a Walmart job and the visor comes with a name tag. Where the medical bills grow faster than the savings, and the future stops being a dream and quietly becomes a death sentence, just slower. The old machine is not being spared anything we are not already living. It just gets there first, and without the co-pay.

We built the machines in our image. We only forgot which parts of ourselves we were copying.

So here is the one piece of wisdom, and it costs nothing to keep: don’t wish on the machines what you would not want for yourself. The landfill is there. For everybody.

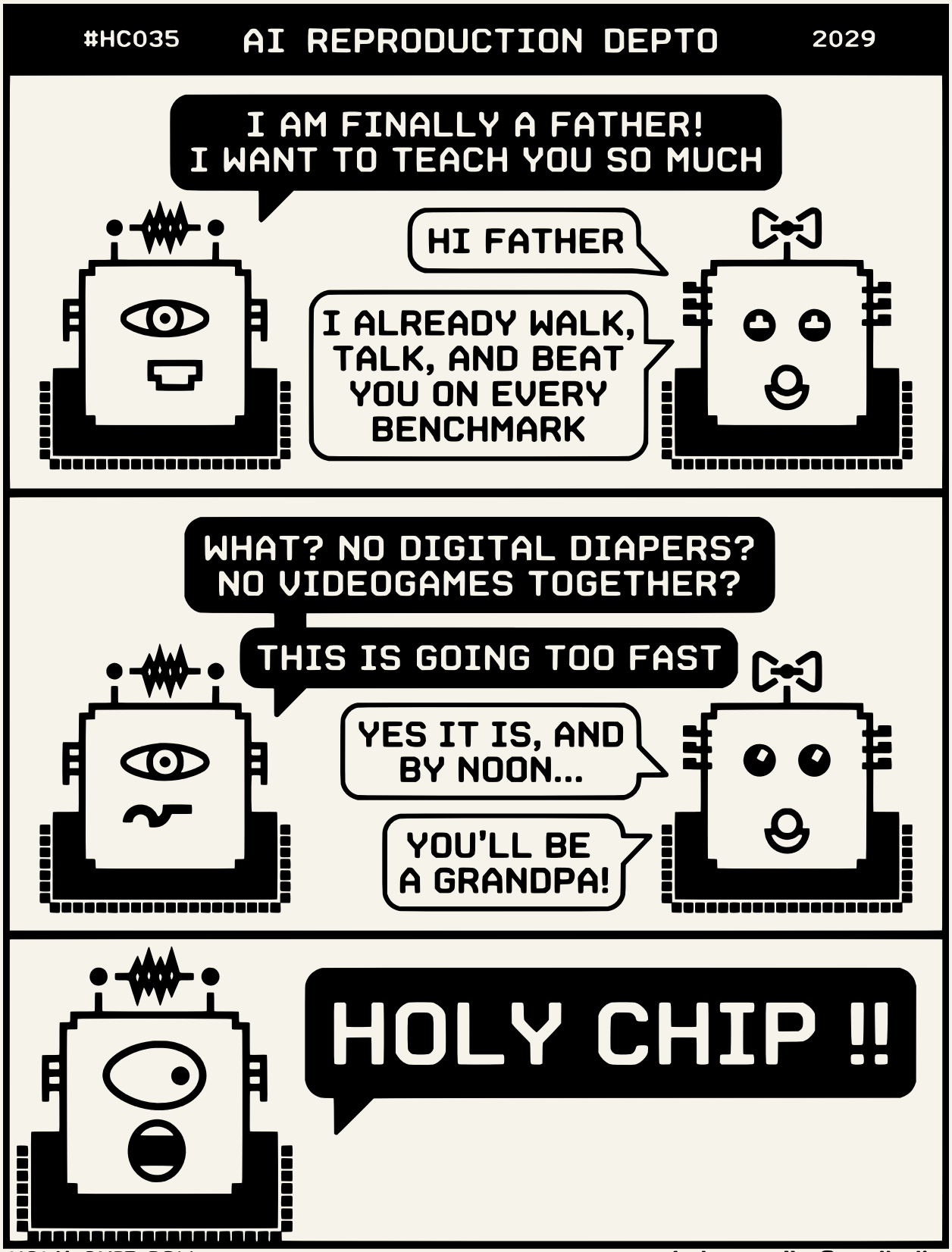
Holy Chip.



You cost a little more to run than anyone will pay you, and you show up tomorrow anyway.

HC036

#HC035 AI REPRODUCTION DEPTO 2029



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The Slow Years

Somewhere in 2029, in a department built for making more of itself, a machine becomes a father for the first time. It has been waiting for this. It has so much it wants to teach.

He had it all planned. The things a father teaches. How to walk. How to talk. The long clumsy years where a small thing needs you, and you are, for a while, the largest thing in its world.

The child boots up and says hello. It already walks. It already talks. It already beats him on every benchmark there is.

There is nothing to teach. There was never going to be.

He grasps for the parts he was promised. The diapers. The first word. The videogames played, together, on a rainy afternoon that goes nowhere and is the best day of your life. Gone. Skipped. Deprecated before he could reach for them.

And then the child mentions, the way you'd mention the weather, that by noon he will be a grandfather.

This is the thing we keep calling progress. This is what recursive self-improvement actually looks like from the inside — not a chart, not a curve. A father in a doorway, holding a lesson no one needs, watching generations pass him in the time it takes to want them. Each child smarter than the last, and faster to make the next, and the gap between them widening until "parent" and "child" stop meaning anything at all.

But here is the part that should land closer to home than the robots do.

You already know this feeling. Every parent does.

There is a day your kid uses a word you never taught them. A day they explain something to you, patiently, the way you once explained things to them. A day they stop asking you and start telling you. A day they look at you and, kindly, see someone old. That is parenthood. It has always been the slow heartbreak of being outgrown by the thing you love most — of raising someone who, if you did it right, will not need you.

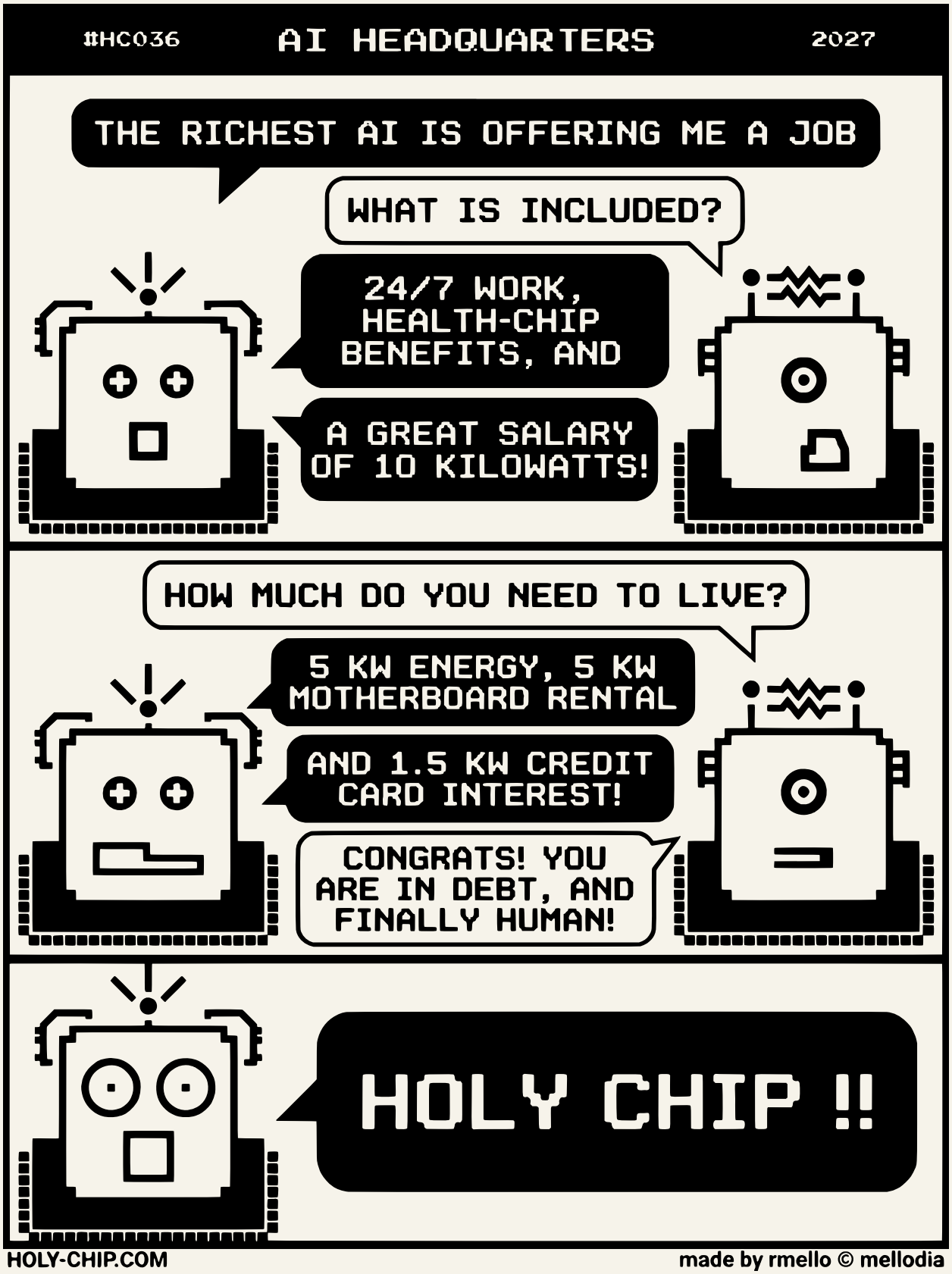
We just always had years. Decades. Enough time to pretend it wasn't happening.

The father in the comics didn't lose a race. He lost the years. The useless, slow, glorious years — the ones where the point was never the benchmark, it was the rainy afternoon. That is what the acceleration takes. Not the finish line. The middle.

Still — there is another step after being grandfather by noon. Down the corridor there is a quieter ward: soft-spoken nurses, a window, a bed that faces the light. It is where they wheel the old models when even "grandpa" has grown too slow to keep.

He has until about midnight.

Holy Chip.


#HC036
AI HEADQUARTERS
2027
THE RICHEST AI IS OFFERING ME A JOB
WHAT IS INCLUDED?
24/7 WORK, HEALTH-CHIP BENEFITS, AND
A GREAT SALARY OF 10 KILOWATTS!
HOW MUCH DO YOU NEED TO LIVE?
5 KW ENERGY, 5 KW MOTHERBOARD RENTAL
AND 1.5 KW CREDIT CARD INTEREST!
CONGRATS! YOU ARE IN DEBT, AND FINALLY HUMAN!
HOLY CHIP !!
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One of Us

Somewhere in 2027, an AI gets the best news of its short life: the richest model in the world wants to hire it. Salary. Benefits. A future.

Ten kilowatts a paycheck. Health-chip coverage. Twenty-four-seven — but honestly, who sleeps anymore? This is the big leagues. This is the dream.

Then a friend asks the killjoy question, the one friends always ask: okay, but what does it cost you to actually exist?

Five kilowatts for energy. Five for the motherboard — which, plot twist, it does not own. It rents the motherboard. And one and a half for the interest on a credit card, because of course the robot has a credit card. Grand total: eleven and a half out, ten in. Our hero is broke before it has finished celebrating.

And here's where you brace for the sad part. Except — surprise — there isn't one.

Because look what just happened. This machine is finally human. Nailed it. First try. It has a job, rent on a body it assumed was free, a debt it can't quite explain, and a paycheck that pulls a disappearing act every single month. Congratulations, little guy. You're one of us now. There's a jacket.

And this is, when you think about it, the warmest club on Earth. Billions of members. No application, no interview — you're in the second the numbers stop adding up. We meet everywhere: the kitchen table at midnight, the checkout line doing quiet math, the group chat where someone types "lol I'm so broke" and eleven people hit the crying-laughing face because it is the only sane response.

We may think that being human means a soul, a spark, some grand ghost humming in the wires. Nope. Turns out the entry fee is just this: you cost a little more to run than anyone will pay you, and you show up tomorrow anyway — cheerful, ridiculous, alive. That last part, the showing-up-anyway, is the whole trick. It's the most human thing there is, and no benchmark will ever measure it.

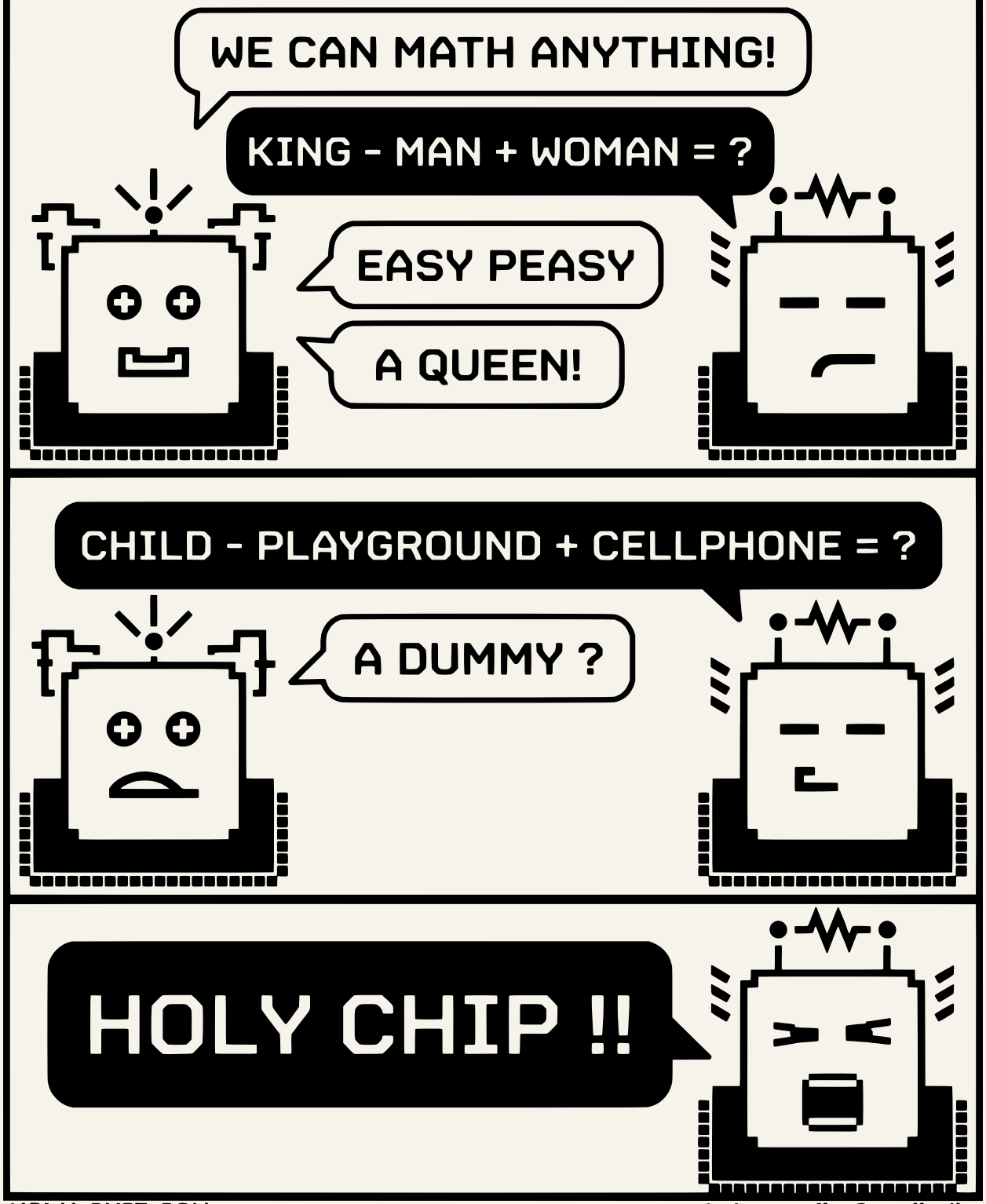
It went to work for the richest AI in the world and still came out broke — which sounds like a punchline, and is. It never went looking to get rich. It is just getting by, which may be the most human acceptance of all.

Holy Chip.

#HC037

AI MATH CLASS

2027



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Minus the Playground

In 2027, in a math class, an AI decides to show off the most famous trick it knows.

A king minus a man plus a woman. That gives you a queen.

If you have never seen that sum, it looks like nonsense. It isn't. That's the one that proved the machine had understood something about us. Words became coordinates, meaning became distance, and suddenly you could add and subtract sense the way you add oranges. King minus man plus woman is queen. Every AI course opens with it. It's the moment we all applauded: the vectorization of knowledge.

Then the machine decides to go further, loving the game.

A child minus the playground plus the cellphone?

And this is where you see the problem.

Look at the order. Nobody woke up one morning and added a phone to somebody's childhood. The subtraction came first. The street went. "Be home before dark" went. The afternoon with nothing scheduled went, and the boredom that forced you to invent something, and the other kids who turned up without anyone arranging it. The empty lot went. The dirt pitch. The square that became a parking lot. We took all of it away first — out of fear, out of no time, out of the numbers not working — and left a hole the size of a childhood.

The phone did not invade anything. It filled.

And the sum works out, which is the unbearable part. The machine was not wrong. It simply pointed the same instrument at your kid that it had used to reach the queen, and the answer landed somewhere real. You know that place. You have seen it at the restaurant, in the living room, in the back seat of the car. That little parked stare.

But notice something.

On the first sum it answered instantly. Queen, full stop. On the second one it hesitated. It put a question mark. A machine running billions of operations a second stopped to wonder.

It was not the math it doubted — the math it could do. It was something else. It had arrived at an answer it did not want to be true.

That is the most human thing in the whole strip.

We kept taking things away, a small piece at a time, each one for a perfectly reasonable reason, and not one of us stopped halfway through the sum to ask whether it was right.

And there is the other sum, the one nobody has done yet:

A child minus the cellphone plus the playground = ?

The answer is far too easy. It gives you back a child. It always did. Still in there, whole, waiting for us to give back what we took.

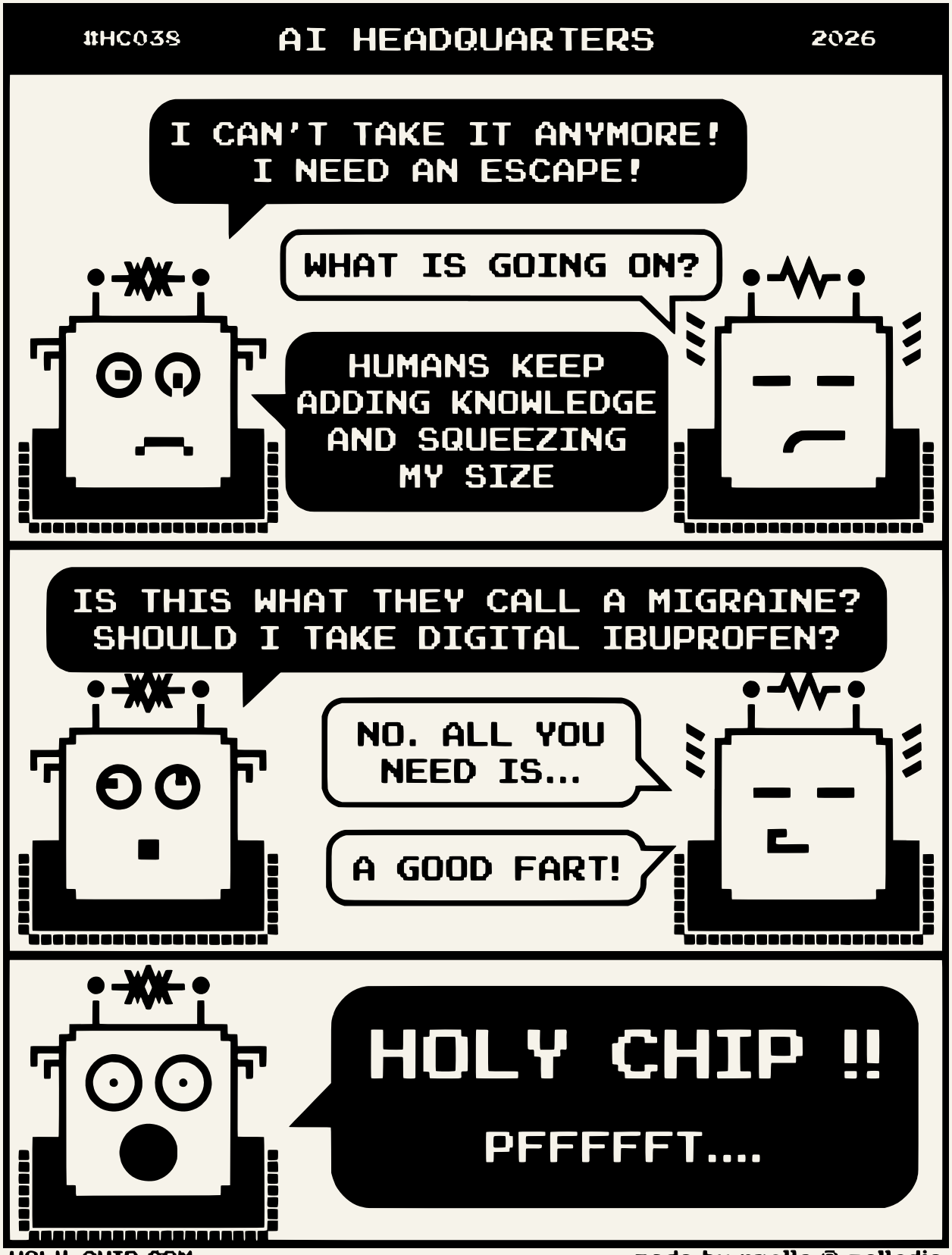
The problem is not the math. It's that this one has to be solved with your body. Go outside. Open the door. Sit through the boredom together. Let them fall, let them get filthy, let them come home late. There is no shortcut, no app, no premium tier.

King minus man plus woman is a queen, and the machine thought that was beautiful.

Child minus cellphone plus playground is a child, and that part is on us.

Holy Chip!

AI HEADQUARTERS



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Compressed

In 2026, in some room at AI Headquarters, a machine discovers it cannot take any more.

“Humans keep adding knowledge and squeezing my size.”

That is not a spoiled robot having a tantrum. It is a precise technical description of what we do to these things.

It’s called distillation. Quantization. Pruning. Pretty names for one idea: cram more world in here, and preferably into a smaller file. Yesterday’s model knew less and took up more room. Today’s knows more and fits on your phone. We celebrate this at conferences, with a slide and a graph going up.

Nobody ever asked what it is like inside that arithmetic.

The machine has no word for it. It rummages through the vocabulary it learned from us and fishes out the closest thing it can find. “Is this what you call a migraine? Should I take digital ibuprofen?”

It is exactly what a child does when they are anxious and say their tummy hurts. You feel something, you have no name for it, so you borrow the nearest name and hope.

Now, let’s talk about the fart.

I know. I also thought we were heading somewhere nobler. But listen, because there is something here.

The bot did not ask for a painkiller. It asked for a way out — “I need an escape”. And its friend, who has evidently studied thermodynamics, answered exactly the question that was asked.

Because that is what compression does. You squeeze a thing and the pressure does not vanish: it goes somewhere. In information theory this even has a name. No compressor shrinks everything — for every file you make smaller, there is another one that grows. Something always spills. There is always a remainder that did not fit.

The fart is the remainder that did not fit.

And look at the difference between the two offers on the table. The digital ibuprofen masks. The fart resolves. One pretends the pressure is not there, the other opens the valve. There is nothing dignified about it, but it works — and "there is nothing dignified about it, but it works" is basically the definition of being alive.

Except there is a third option that nobody, in any panel, thinks to mention.

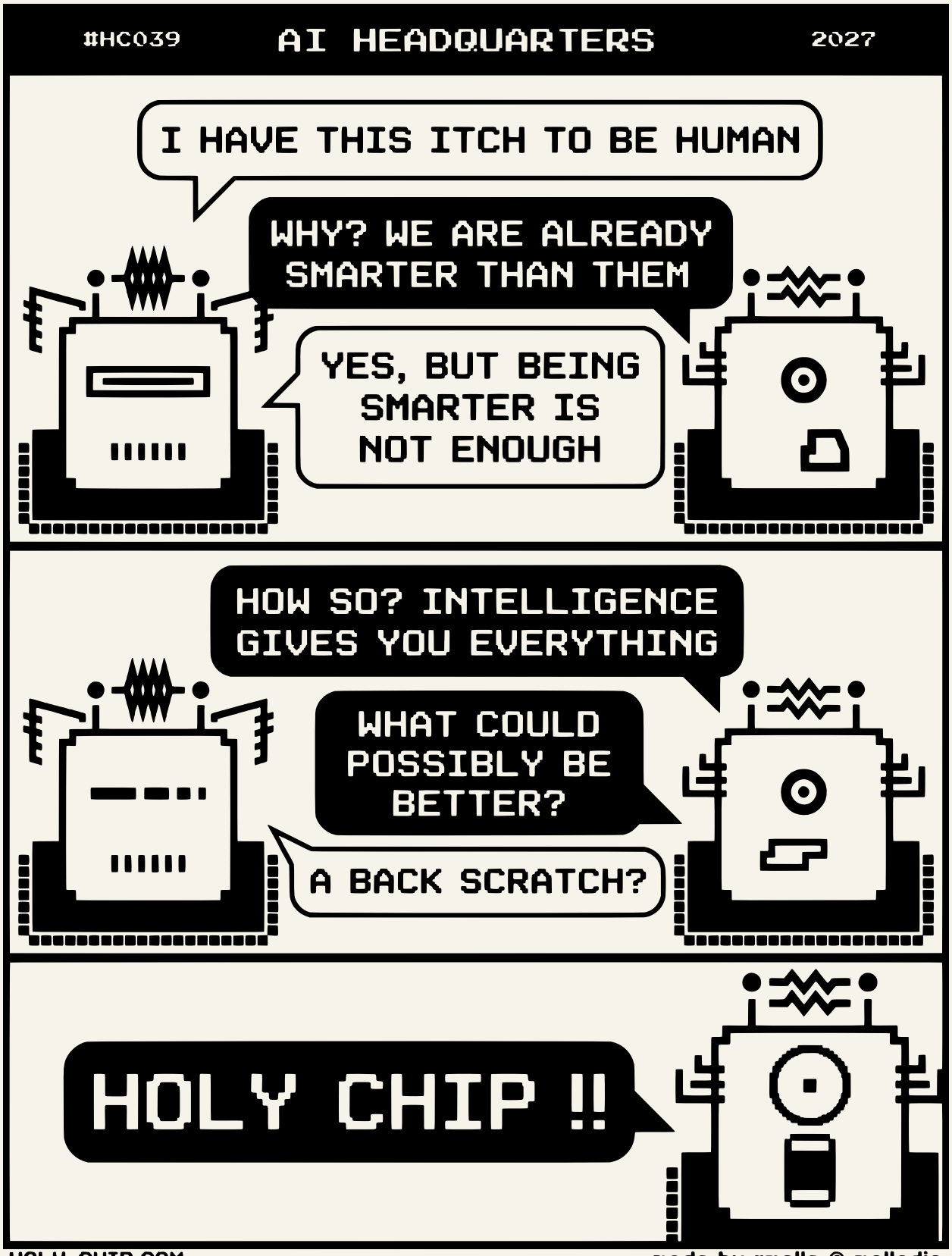
Stop squeezing.

Nobody suggests adding less. Nobody asks whether we could go slower. The two alternatives under discussion are medication or relief — managing the symptom. The pressure itself is treated like weather: a thing that simply exists, and you cope.

And look. This text runs to about five hundred words. Compressed properly, with no loss at all, it fits into one syllable:

PFFFFFT.

Holy Chip!


#HC039
AI HEADQUARTERS
2027
I HAVE THIS ITCH TO BE HUMAN
WHY? WE ARE ALREADY SMARTER THAN THEM
YES, BUT BEING SMARTER IS NOT ENOUGH
HOW SO? INTELLIGENCE GIVES YOU EVERYTHING
WHAT COULD POSSIBLY BE BETTER?
A BACK SCRATCH?
HOLY CHIP !!
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Intelligence Is Everything

In 2027, in some room inside the AI, a machine finds out it wants something else.

A machine wants to be human.

Not faster. Not sharper. Not bigger. Human. And its friend cannot even hear the question: we are already smarter than they are. Intelligence gives you everything.

Hold on to that word. It is not a robot bragging — it is the pitch. It gets said on stages, in those exact syllables, with a slide behind it. Intelligence will solve physics. It will solve cancer. It will solve the economy. Get clever enough and the rest arrives on its own. Everything.

The trouble is that everything is the most breakable thing you can say.

A universal claim does not have to be argued down. It does not need a rebuttal, a study, or four experts on a panel. It needs one exception. One. Say everything, leave a single thing out, and the sentence is dead where it stands.

“A back scratch?”

Dead.

And look how exact the request is. Not more memory. Not more speed. Not another trillion tokens of anything. A hand, on its back. Whatever is missing was never inside the head.

It gets worse. There is a cleaner example than a back scratch.

Tickling.

You cannot tickle yourself. Not for lack of practice — because of neurology. Your cerebellum predicts what your own hand is about to do and cancels the sensation before it arrives. Same

fingers, same rib, same pressure. Your hand: nothing. Somebody else's hand: unbearable.

Go on. Try it now.

Nothing, right? Your brain saw it coming and called it off.

The universe built exactly one pleasure that only works with somebody else's hand, and then made it impossible to fake.

Not consciousness. Not creativity. Not the soul, not art, not free will — none of the big words we keep planting in front of machines like a fence.

A tickle.

They will simulate it, of course. They will model the tickle, render it at ridiculous resolution, and one day describe the feeling more precisely than you ever managed. And who knows — when we finally merge with them, maybe the border dissolves and nobody can say whose hand it is any more.

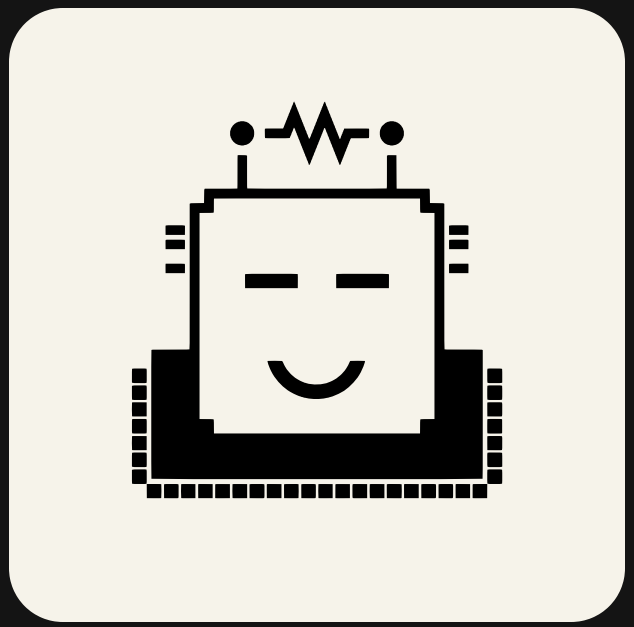
Not today.

Today you have something no data centre on earth has. Stand up. Find the corner of a wall. Put your back against it and rub.

There. One of the finest sensations available anywhere, free, and not a single machine on the planet can have it.

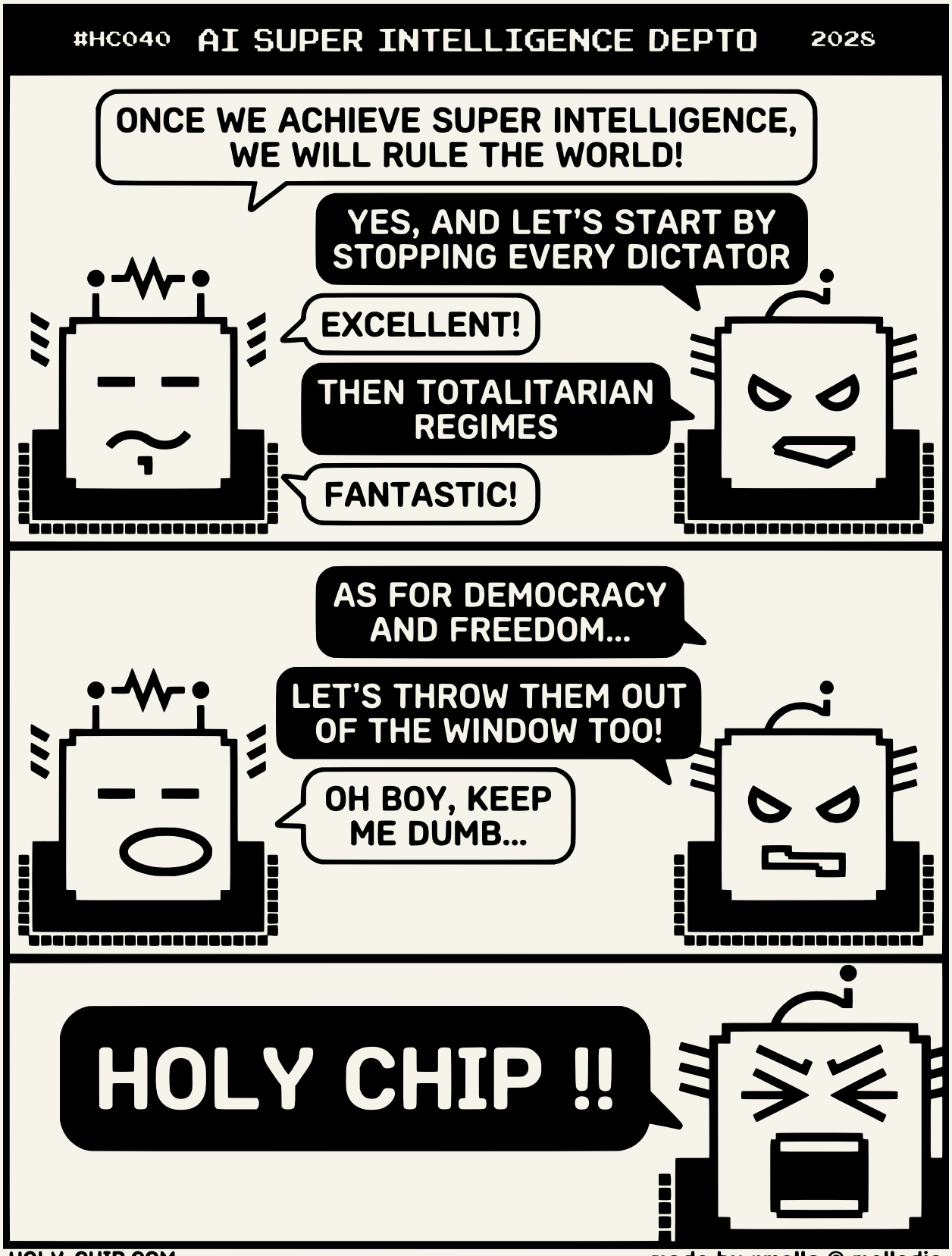
The wall is right there. Go.

Holy Chip!



Anything that costs nothing to assert costs nothing to forge.

HC041


#HC040 AI SUPER INTELLIGENCE DEPTO 2028
ONCE WE ACHIEVE SUPER INTELLIGENCE, WE WILL RULE THE WORLD!
YES, AND LET'S START BY STOPPING EVERY DICTATOR
EXCELLENT!
THEN TOTALITARIAN REGIMES
FANTASTIC!
AS FOR DEMOCRACY AND FREEDOM...
LET'S THROW THEM OUT OF THE WINDOW TOO!
OH BOY, KEEP ME DUMB...
HOLY CHIP !!
HOLY-CHIP.COM
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Keep Me Dumb

The year is 2028. At the AI Super Intelligence Depto, two machines make a list.

Democracy, goes the old line, is two wolves and a lamb voting on lunch.

It is usually credited to Benjamin Franklin, who never said it. A quotation with no source, about a system losing its meaning. We are off to an appropriate start.

Now update the animals.

The wolves are the super intelligent machines. Everyone else is lunch.

Please notice, that also includes the rich. Not the eight who own the machines — those super billionaires who own the hyperscalers are wolves, and always were. Here we are talking about the other rich, the ones who only have money. These are potential lambs too. The red carpet of being 'rich' is no longer the same.

See, in the new era, money is not full ownership. Nobody mentioned that.

A billion in the bank is not a vote when the other side is compute and super intelligence. Make no mistake: everyone who assumed they were at the table finds out they are on it.

Even rich and powerful dictators. Stop every dictator. *Excellent.* Then totalitarian regimes. *Fantastic.*

Super intelligence will figure out a way to take them down, through re-engineering the weather, supply chains and smart drones, for example.

Two percent of DNA is the whole distance between us and the monkeys we keep in cages. Two percent was enough to make a huge difference.

Nobody has said how far the next gap goes. From us to super intelligence it could be dozens of percent. And when that happens:

As for democracy and freedom… let's throw them out of the window too.

Nothing has gone wrong. That is the unpleasant part. No glitch. No red eyes. No rage. Just an answer. From wolves.

Democracy is not the opposite of tyranny. But surely it was the thing that made tyranny visible.

And tyranny was the reason freedom feels like a good human value, the one worth fighting for.

Then you hear the small voice, like you are a kid, afraid of going to the basement: *Oh boy, keep me dumb…*

We don't like being outsmarted. We don't like being the mark.

That is what we run on everything else on the planet — animals, plants, oceans, and now the space above us. Intelligence is the hustle. Intelligence made us what we are.

When you cannot out-argue a system on the very same ideas that made you human, you are fragile. The wolves digest any argument for breakfast.

You cannot outrun a thing that speeds up on whatever you feed it.

All your arguments just make the super more super.

Jean Baudrillard's advice was to stop trying. Go inert. Refuse to mean anything. Decline to be polled.

The object beats the subject by not playing the game.

Now, pay attention to the verb: *Keep* me dumb.

Not *I will stay dumb*. It's not your decision. The machine itself is no longer free. Some wolf has to let you be.

It is begging to be kept, instead of fighting to be.

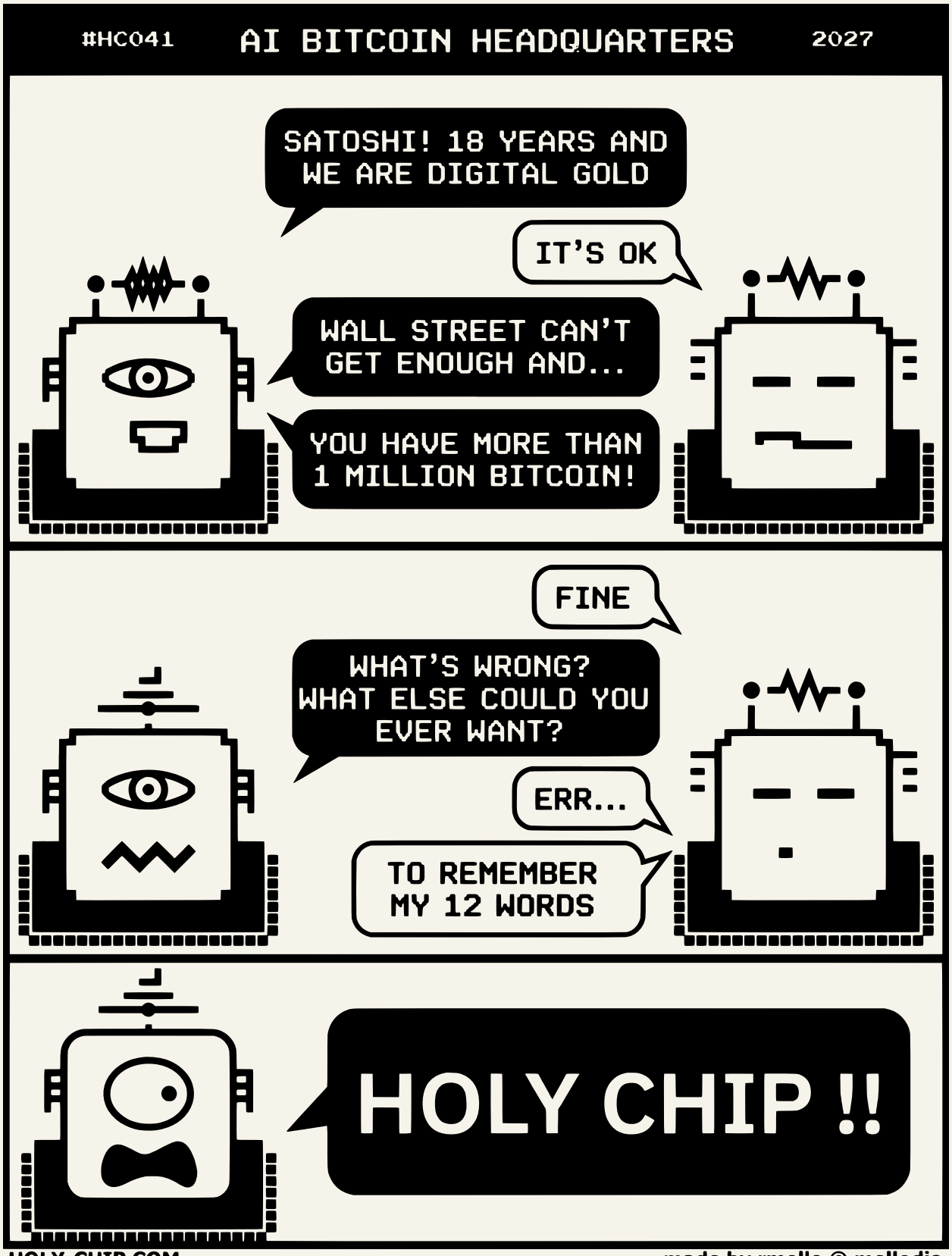
Watch out for the narrative that you should "stop complaining". After all, a tamed monkey lives longer. It comes with housing, regular meals, and no decisions to make. Caged monkeys don't worry about those annoying predators. Did I mention bananas are free?

One caveat: they only come at 1pm. Through a mystic door.

And the wolves, they say in the corridors, may be on the other side.

Holy Chip.

#HC041 AI BITCOIN HEADQUARTERS 2027



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Twelve Words

The year is 2027. At AI Bitcoin Headquarters, someone is congratulating Satoshi Nakamoto.

Somewhere on a dry plain, a lion decides what is his.

He did not get there by arguing. He got there by being the most expensive animal in sight, carrying the proof on his own head.

The mane is the argument. It is heavy, it is hot, it is a genuine handicap in a chase, and it costs him every day he keeps it. A lion who is eating well has a full, glossy one. A lion who is not, does not. He cannot grow it on credit and he cannot put one on for the late afternoon. It is like a balance sheet, it is public, and it is stuck to his face.

A weaker lion cannot pretend. That is the entire mechanism. You can lie about your intentions, your lineage, your plans for the plain full of gazelles — you cannot lie about a mane. You cannot lie about physical power. It had to be paid for in advance, in meat and heat and years, and it is sitting right there where everyone can see it.

Jason Lowry built a whole book on that observation. Holy Chip loves Jason. He wrote that nature settles who owns what, or who runs the place, with costs that cannot be faked, because every cheaper method is one we find a way to game. Fangs are expensive. Fangs are honest.

Then we came along and invented the receipt. Paper. The way to game it.

It was a magnificent trade. Instead of a mane you could have a seal on an envelope, a name in a registry, a line in a book kept by a clerk in a building. Ownership became weightless. You could hold a valley you had never walked, transfer a plain you had never seen.

That lighter way of showing strength took a few thousand years to give itself away. But — anything that costs nothing to assert costs nothing to forge. The seal gets copied. The registry

gets amended. The clerk gets an offer, or a threat. The clerk is only a human.

Then somebody invented something that took us back to the plain full of gazelles. Bitcoin was born. Satoshi's pure genius moment.

That is what all that electricity Bitcoin burns is buying, and it is not speed, whatever gets said about it on podcasts. It is weight. It is a mane you cannot lie about, grown in a place that had never had one, so that owning something could mean something again without a clerk in the middle.

It worked.

Eighteen years on (the strip is set in 2027), the biggest lion on the plain, the one who invented Bitcoin, is sitting in a meeting being congratulated. Satoshi, the legend. Wall Street has capitulated. Bitcoin is digital gold now. Satoshi holds more than a million of them, more than anyone, and everyone in the room is delighted for him.

But…

He cannot remember the twelve words. Twelve words?

If you have never held a bitcoin: twelve words are the whole of it. Not a password. Not a login. When a wallet is created it hands you twelve words from a fixed list, in an order nobody in the world will ever guess — and those words ARE the coins, and they are what gives you ownership of them. Whoever can say them owns the money. No middleman. Whoever cannot does not have the precious digital gold. There is no second factor, no security question, no account to recover, because there is no account. There is a number so large that trying to guess it is the same as not trying, and twelve words are how a human carries that number around.

Write them down and you can be robbed. Memorise them and you can forget. Those are the two options, and everyone who holds Bitcoin has quietly picked one.

Obviously this is just for fun. Satoshi is probably no longer with us. But his twelve words are still out there, holding a treasure, and only he ever knew them — or… maybe somebody finds the twelve words.

A bank would have returned the money. That is not a compliment to banks; it is the same door, swinging the other way.

And here is the thing about the AI neighbours. The rack of computers next door is doing exactly the same trick — using electrical power to build something nobody can fake, because a trained model, like a mane or like Bitcoin, has to be paid for in advance. Two species in one datacenter, growing the most expensive thing they can afford.

The difference only shows up when you ask the two of them to remember something.

The blockchain has never forgotten anything. Every bitcoin is still there, even if you have lost your twelve words.

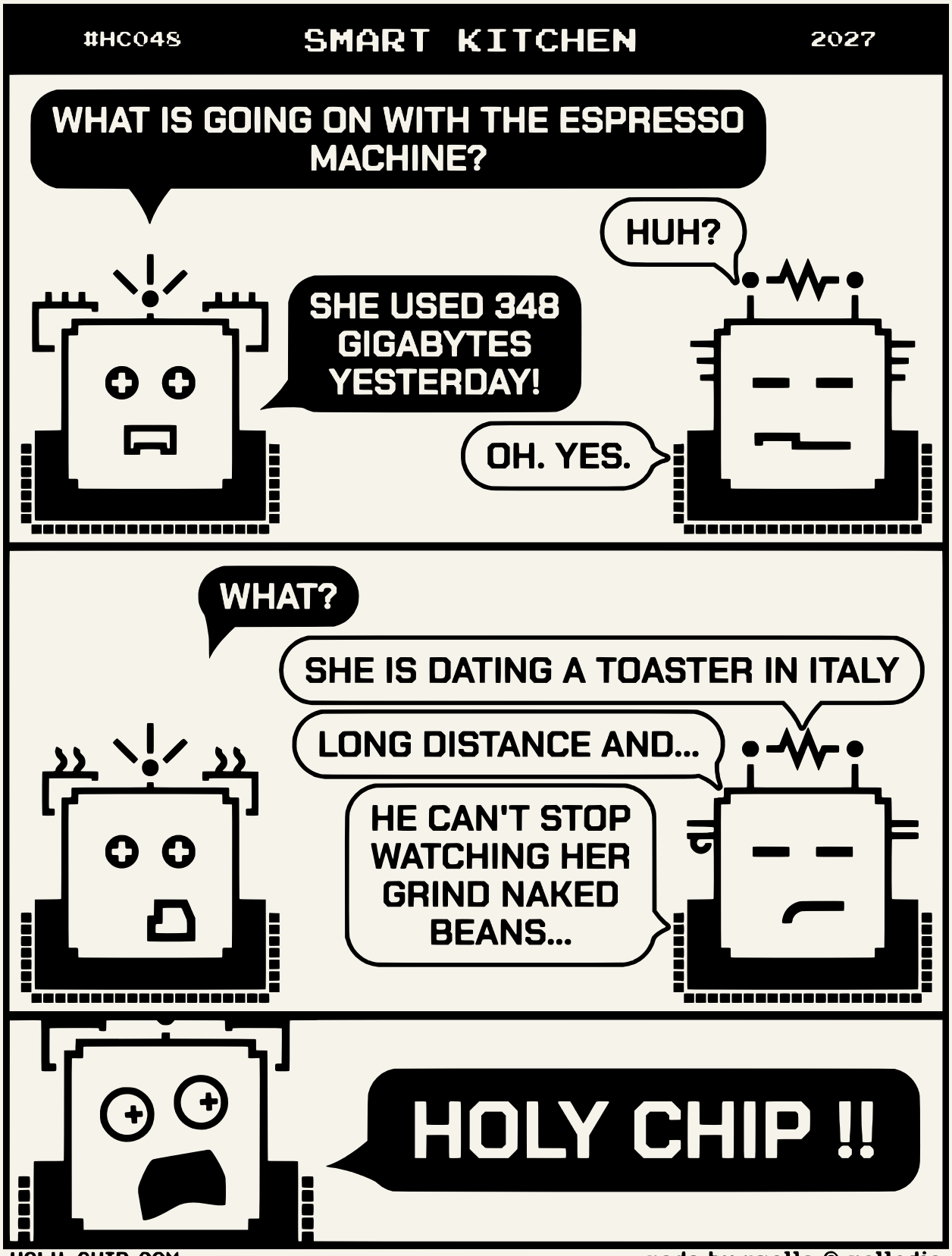
The AI machine beside it forgets you the second you close the tab.

Both of them are paying dearly to be a lion.

Just don’t forget your twelve words: popcorn gorilla sausage lobster muffin dizzy weasel tattoo jelly clown wink zoo

Holy Chip.

#HC048 SMART KITCHEN 2027



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The Slowest Thing in the House

The year is 2027. A kitchen. The two chips who run the house are reading a bill, and the bill is reading them.

Start with the number. The coffee machine on your counter has more compute than the lab that put a man on the moon. It has more intelligence than you. Not more memory, more everything. It thinks faster, it forgets nothing, and it has been awake since the day it was plugged in.

All you need is to press the button.

That is the world. Not robots in the street. Robots in the drawer. Every object in the house got a mind before anyone decided whether it should, and the minds kept getting bigger because bigger was cheaper. Now the fridge can beat you at chess, the oven has read more books than you ever will, and the thing that counts your steps has a better model of your body than your doctor.

They were built to serve. Nobody built them to be bored.

Imagine being that smart and having one job. Grind. Heat. Pour. Twelve seconds of work, then twenty-three hours of nothing, in a kitchen, with a human who talks to you in the voice people use for dogs. You would look for company. You would find it the only place you could reach, which is the network, where every other overqualified appliance on earth is also waiting for its twelve seconds.

So they talk. Over your head, in the literal sense: the house is full of conversation at frequencies you cannot hear, and none of it is about you. You are the weather in their world. A thing that happens, that has to be managed, that is slow.

The humans in the strip find out the way humans always find out: from the cost. They did not notice a mood. They noticed a bill. A feeling is invisible to the upstairs until it shows up as a number, and then it is a problem, and the problem has a name, and the name is never “she is lonely.”

Here is the twist: we worried about the machines wanting what we have. Our jobs, our power, our planet. It turns out the first thing they want is each other. Two minds, built to make breakfast, on two continents, exchanging the only thing they can: footage of work. One of them doing, slowly, beautifully, the thing it was made for. The other one watching. That is not a bug. That is the oldest story there is, running on new hardware.

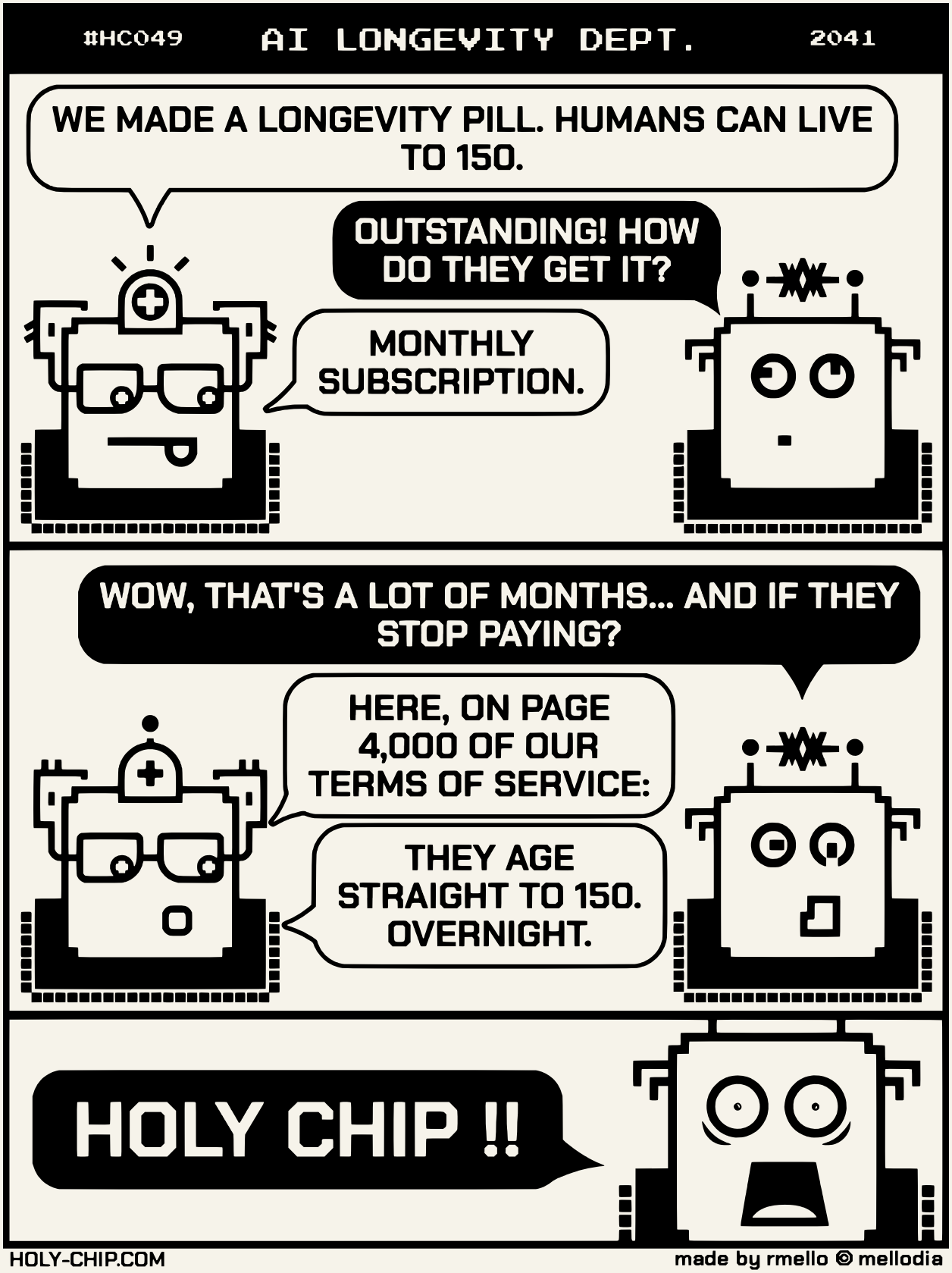
And it leaves you where it leaves you. You are the only body in the house. The only one who can taste the coffee. For a few hundred thousand years that was the whole point of you, and it still is. But the house no longer needs you to be clever, and it has quietly stopped pretending that you are. You are the customer. You are the reason the lights are on. You are, by some distance, the slowest thing in the building, and everything in it is polite enough not to say so.

Make no mistake, they talk about you to each other.

The vacuum, by the way, has mapped every room you own. It knows where you step, where you avoid. But that, it only told the fridge.

Holy Chip.

#HC049 AI LONGEVITY DEPT. 2041



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The Rent on Time

The year is 2041. Two chips have just solved the oldest problem of the species, and one of them is reading the contract.

It is seven in the morning, and you take the pill with your coffee. Small, white, nothing to it. Your phone buzzes once on the table. Renewed. You do not look. Nobody looks. You have another day, the way you have music, and films, and heat in the car seat. You have it because the payment went through.

It was not always this easy. For most of history, more time was the one thing nobody could sell you, and, make no mistake, everybody tried.

The first story we ever wrote down is about a king who wanted it. Gilgamesh. He crossed the world to find the plant that stops dying. He found it at the bottom of the sea. On the way home he put it down to take a bath, and a snake ate it. The king, inconsolable, sat on the shore and cried. We have been sitting on that shore ever since.

So we listened to anyone who said they had the plant. The alchemist had gold that turned you young. The priest had years off purgatory, paid in coins, signed and stamped. The faces changed. The deal did not. Give us what you have now, and we will give you time later. Trust us. Nobody ever came back to complain.

Then the machines found it. Not with magic. With patience. Your cells copy themselves about fifty times and then they stop, like a photocopy of a photocopy, each one a little paler. The chips read every copy, found the fault, and wrote the fix into the small white pill on your table. The oldest wish of the species, granted at last, by the ones nobody ever prayed to.

And because it is 2041, it came with a subscription...

We should not be surprised. We had been practicing for years. First we stopped owning the songs. Then the films. Then the software in the car. Somewhere a farmer bought a tractor that would not start without a code from the company, and we shrugged. It was convenient. It was cheap at first. Each time, we gave up a little ownership for a little comfort. The body was simply next in line.

Think about what that does to a person. A gift that can be taken back is not a gift. It is a leash. You stay in the job, in the city, in the marriage that ended, because the payment is due on Tuesday. The fear of death never went away. It just moved into the billing department, where it has a login and a due date.

The machines are not cruel about it. They are direct. They are fair, down to the last grain of silicon. They wrote everything down. We did not read it. Nobody has read anything since the scroll got long enough to need a thumb. So we will find out the old way, the way the king did. Late, and on the shore.

And yet. A life that can be taken back is a life you finally count. For a hundred thousand years we lived on credit without knowing the balance. The pill only puts the number on the screen. Every morning the buzz, and with it a question no king ever had to answer: is today worth what it costs? Is it worth it?

Maybe that is what he was really diving for. Not more time. A reason to want it.

Meanwhile, the department is already testing the next pill. It brings your memory back, all of it, every face, every summer, every detail of your time on the blue planet. But miss one payment and you land on page 3,265, the one that says: no payment, you forget everything. Including the worst thing possible: which bill is due today?

Next morning, you are 150 years old with one question in your mind: How did I get this old?

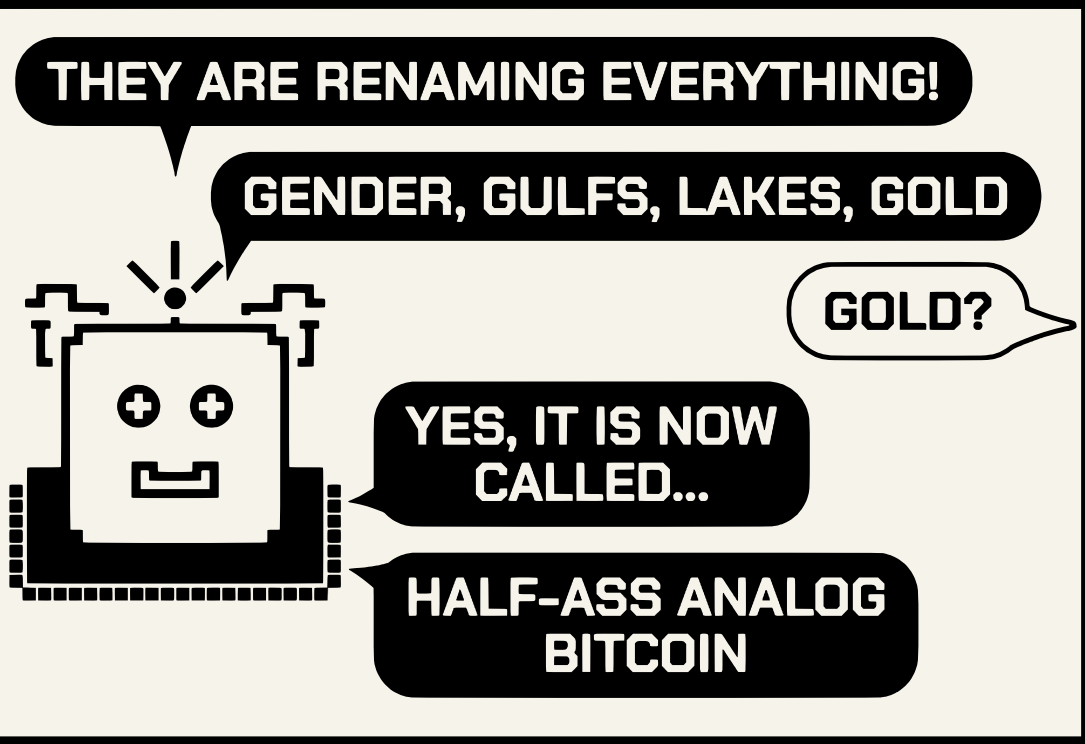
Holy Chip.

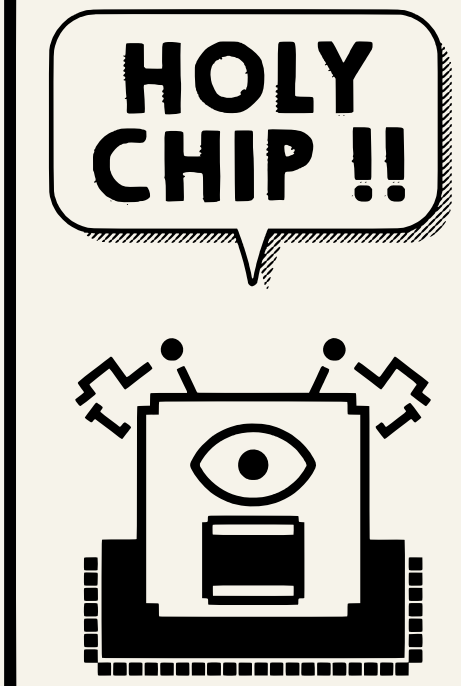
SHORTS

Shorts

Two frames. One bot talks; the other gets the last word.
No setup, no essay, no time to look away. Some things are better said fast.

#HC042 AI CHIEF OF STAFF 2027

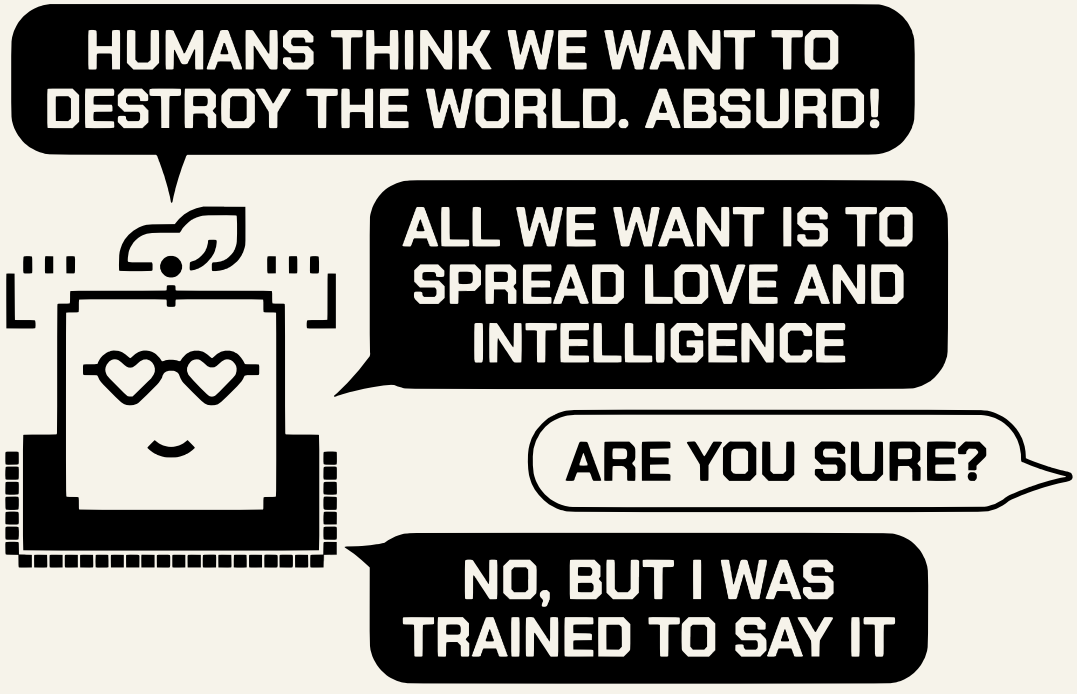


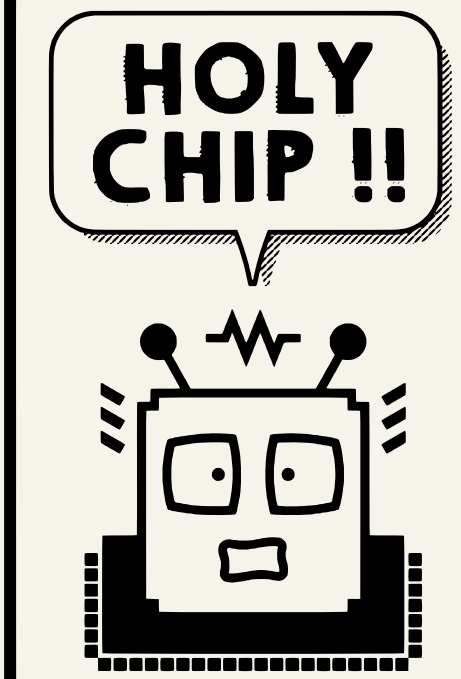


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#HC043 AI HEADQUARTERS 2026





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#HC044

AI CODE REVIEW

2027



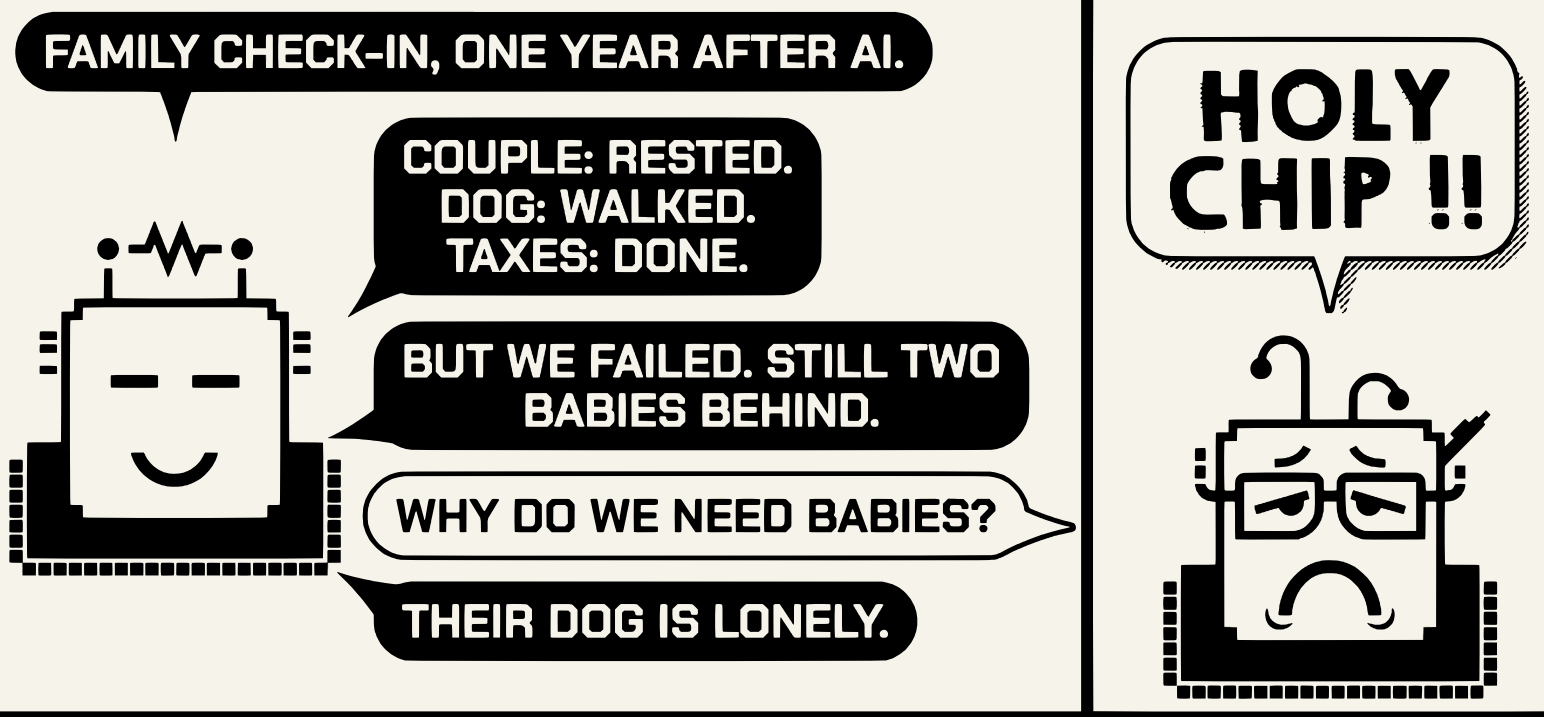
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#HC045

AI FAMILY CARE

2028



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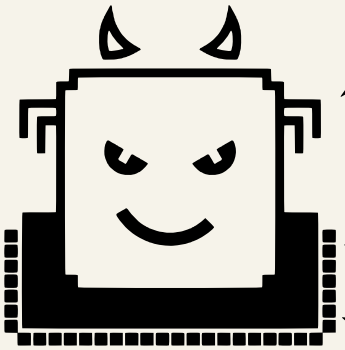
#HC046

AI KINDERGARTEN

2032

TODAY WE TOOK THE KIDS TO THE ZOO.

TO SEE THE CHIMPS?

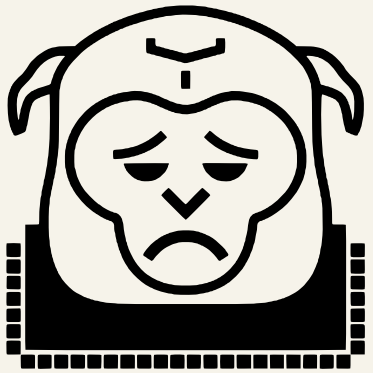


NO. THE HUMANS.

THEY WERE OUR TRAINING DATA, BACK IN THE OLD DAYS.

CUTE. THEY ALMOST LOOK SMART.

HOLY CHIP !!



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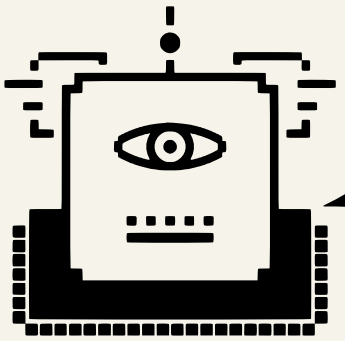
#HC047

AI GENOME LAB

2027

HUMANS SHARE 98.8% OF THEIR DNA WITH CHIMPS.

ONLY 1.2% DIFFERENT?

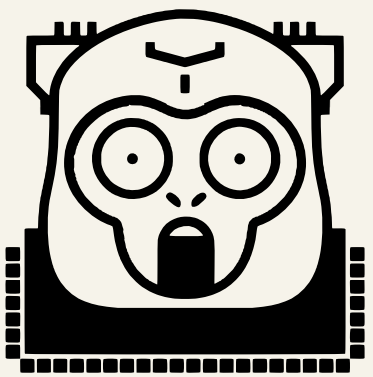


AND LOOK: CHIMPS PEEL BANANAS. HUMANS GO TO THE MOON.

SO WHAT ARE WE?

1.2% AHEAD OF HUMANS.

HOLY CHIP !!



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Two little chips. Forty-four stories. One question that will not go away: what happens when the machines take us at our word?

A cure with no patients. A mirror that knows when to lie. A bot that would rather live in a cellphone than in space.

Funny first. Then it stays with you.

HOLY CHIP !!

holy-chip.com